

Babylon

How to Live When America Stops Being Christian

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LIVEWELL BY JAMES BELL

Build houses and live in them. Plant gardens and eat their produce... But seek the welfare of the city where I have sent you into exile, and pray to the Lord on its behalf, for in its welfare you will find your welfare.

— Jeremiah 29:5, 7

Chapter 1: The Part of the Letter We Never Read

There is a verse from the prophet Jeremiah that you have seen more times than you could count, and almost never in its home. For I know the plans I have for you, declares the Lord, plans for welfare and not for evil, to give you a future and a hope. You have read it on a coffee mug and a graduation card, on a framed print in a Christian bookstore and a needlepoint pillow in a church foyer, in the closing line of a commencement speech and the caption under a photograph of a sunrise. By some measures it is the single most quoted verse in the American church, and we have made it the most personal promise in the Bible, a private guarantee that my particular dreams are about to come true, that my future is bright, that God is arranging good things for me specifically, on a schedule I can live to see. We did that, every one of us who has ever leaned on it that way, by performing a small and unnoticed act of surgery. We cut the verse free of the sentences around it, the ones almost no one reads, and those sentences were written to people whose entire world had just been burned to the ground.

Go back and read what surrounds it, and the comfort changes color entirely. In 597 before Christ the armies of Babylon came against Jerusalem, and the young king Jehoiachin surrendered after a reign of three months, and the conquerors did what conquerors did. They marched the cream of the nation a thousand miles east into captivity, the king and the queen mother and the craftsmen and the metalworkers and the soldiers and the leading families, ten thousand of them by the book of Kings, and

left a puppet named Zedekiah behind to keep the peace. A decade later, when the puppet rebelled and made his gamble on Egypt, they came back and finished the work. They broke through the wall after a siege that starved the city into eating what no one will name, and they burned the temple, the actual dwelling place of God on earth, the house where heaven and earth were supposed to meet, and they put out Zedekiah's eyes after making the last thing he ever saw the killing of his sons, and they dragged away nearly everyone who was left. The people of God, who had been assured for generations that their God would never let his own house fall, that Zion was inviolable, that the ark and the temple were a guarantee, sat in the wreckage of every promise they thought they understood. They sat in a foreign empire that worshipped other gods and spoke another tongue and had every reason to despise them. And it was to those people, the first wave already carried off in 597, grieving and disoriented and desperate to go home, that the prophet Jeremiah sent a letter.

The plans verse is the eleventh line of that letter. We treat it as the headline. In the letter it is nearer to a footnote, the reassurance fastened to the end of a far harder word, and the harder word is the one we have spent twenty-five centuries refusing to read. Because the first thing the letter does is take away the only hope the exiles wanted. There were prophets among them, men like Hananiah, telling the people exactly what their grief longed to hear, that the whole nightmare would be brief, that within two years God would shatter the yoke of Babylon and bring them all home and set the furniture back where it had stood. And Jeremiah, speaking in the name of the same God, called that a lie, and handed them a number instead, a number so cruel that no one selling comfort has ever wanted to say it out loud. Seventy years. A lifetime. Most of you will die

here. Your grandchildren will see Jerusalem, not you. Settle in. The exile is not a weekend and it is not a detour. It is the rest of your life, and your children's lives, and you had better learn how to live it.

And then, having taken away the fantasy of rescue, the letter does the truly shocking thing. It does not tell the exiles to fight, and it does not tell them to vanish. It tells them to live. Here is what God actually said, rendered without the sanding we have done to it: Build houses and live in them. Plant gardens and eat their produce. Take wives and have sons and daughters, take wives for your sons and give your daughters in marriage, that they may bear sons and daughters, multiply there and do not decrease. And then the line that should stop the heart of anyone who has ever felt their country slipping out from under them: Seek the welfare of the city where I have sent you into exile, and pray to the Lord on its behalf, for in its welfare you will find your welfare. Build. Plant. Marry. Multiply. Seek. Pray. And behind the last two, holding them up, a command so total that it needs no separate verse because it governs all the rest: do not bow. Do not worship what they worship. Be the most present and the most generous people in Babylon, and belong, entirely, to Someone else.

Read them together and count them, because the counting matters. Six imperatives handed to a defeated people, and every one of them a refusal of the two things grief reaches for first. They are not told to keep their bags packed and wait out the captivity in a posture of protest. They are not told to dissolve into Babylon and forget who they are. They are commanded to do the third and stranger thing, to put down roots in the soil of the empire that had ruined them, and to seek its good, and to bow to none of its gods. That is the letter. That is the whole letter, and it

is addressed, I am going to spend this book arguing, to us.

I did not always think so. For a long time I read Jeremiah 29 the way everyone reads it, as a lovely private promise with an awkward historical setting attached, and I preached it that way too, God help me, at more than one graduation. What changed was slower and harder, and it was the growing recognition that the letter is not describing my feelings. It is describing my address. The letter is written to a people who have lost a home they thought was permanent, who are grieving a world that felt like the water they swam in, who are tempted by exactly two bad answers and are being handed a third. And that is not a metaphor for the American church. That is a description of it, precise enough to be uncomfortable, and the discomfort is the beginning of wisdom.

Let me say the thing plainly, because the whole book depends on getting it right, and most of the American church still cannot make itself say it out loud. For sixteen hundred years, and in this country for the better part of four centuries, Christianity enjoyed an arrangement we have come to call Christendom, in which the faith was the assumed water everyone swam in, culturally established, socially respectable, woven so deeply into the civic furniture that you did not have to believe much of anything to be carried along by it. That arrangement is over. It is not coming back in our lifetime or our children's. And what died with it was never Christianity itself but only Christianity's cultural scaffolding, the borrowed power and the easy respectability and the vague civic warmth, and the church has been weeping at the wrong funeral, standing over the body of cultural Christianity as though it were the body of the church, mistaking the loss of its privileges for the loss of its God. We are exiles now, a moral and spiritual minority in a country that no longer shares our memory.

And the sooner we stop waiting for the water to come rushing back, the sooner we can do the one thing the exiles were actually commanded to do, which is to live, and to live well, here.

We have been weeping at the wrong funeral. What died was not Christianity but Christendom, the scaffolding and not the building, and we mistook the one for the other because we were told for so long that they were the same.

I can say this with a certain freedom that I did not earn and will not pretend to, because I never swam in the water in the first place. I did not grow up Christian. I came to Christ out of atheism, as a grown man, in the full daylight of a secular age, as exactly the kind of skeptical outsider the hardest chapters of this book are written to reach. I have never once needed the culture to assume the faith on my behalf, because the culture I lived in assumed the opposite, and Jesus turned out to be enough anyway. That is not a small thing to say to a church in a panic. But I will not overplay the hand, because I have watched something happen in my own chest that I did not expect. The longer I have pastored inside Christendom's ruins, the more I have caught myself missing a world I never actually lived in, aching for a deference I was never owed, wanting the room to be on my side the way it was for the generation before me. So I am not writing this from above the grief. I am writing it from inside a grief I have less right to than most of the people reading it, which is its own kind of rebuke, and I feel it.

This is the conviction the whole book is an attempt to work out, so let me be honest about what a book like this can and cannot do. A diagnosis, once you have it, is strangely useless. It tells you what happened. It tells you the water has drained, the

arrangement has collapsed, the country has moved on and is not coming back to apologize. It does not tell you how to get out of bed on a Tuesday and be a Christian in the actual world that remains. And we have had a great deal of diagnosis. We have had the books and the conferences and the laments, the statistics about decline and the hand-wringing about the rising tide of the religiously unaffiliated, and much of it is true, and almost none of it is any help, because a person who knows only that he is in exile knows only that he is lost. The letter is the cure for that particular paralysis, because the letter does not stop at you are in exile. It keeps going, out of the indicative and into the imperative, into verbs, into the unglamorous and load-bearing business of how an exile actually builds a life. This book is those verbs. It is going to spend most of its length not proving that we are in Babylon, which takes only a few chapters, but learning, slowly and concretely, how a faithful people lives there.

And the verbs turn on a single word, which is the reason the platform I write from carries the name it does. Seek the welfare of the city, God says, and in its welfare you will find your welfare. The word translated welfare, both times, is the Hebrew *shalom*, and *shalom* is not the thin thing we have reduced it to. It is not mere quiet, not the absence of conflict, not a private inner calm you buy with a meditation app. It is wholeness, flourishing, the way things are meant to be when they are finally right, a world knit back together at every seam. *Shalom* is the city where the hungry are fed and the stranger is safe and the work is honest and the weak are not crushed and the debts are forgiven and the streets are at peace after dark. It is the shape of the world God intended before it broke, and the shape he has promised to restore. And God commands the exiles to seek that, not for Jerusalem, which is gone, but for Babylon, the very empire that burned his temple and blinded their king. He commands them to

labor for the flourishing of the place that ruined them.

Then he does something that ought to take the breath away. He binds their own flourishing to it, so tightly that the two cannot be pulled apart. In its welfare, he says, you will find your welfare. In its shalom, your shalom. You will not find your wholeness by hoarding it behind a wall while the city outside rots. You will not find it by conquering the city or by fleeing it or by walling it out. You will find it, the only place it has ever been found, by spending it on the good of a city that is not your home and never will be. This is the logic that runs against every instinct a frightened minority has. The instinct says protect what is yours, circle the wagons, secure the remnant, and shalom will follow. God says the opposite. Pour yourselves out for the good of Babylon, and your own good is hidden inside Babylon's, and there is no other door to it. To live well, in the sense that verse means, is to seek the life of the city that does not know you. That is why the platform is called what it is. Not live comfortably. Not live safely. Live well, in the full weight of shalom, which turns out to be inseparable from the welfare of everyone around you.

That sentence is the whole argument of this book in miniature, and it cuts against the two answers the church keeps reaching for, which are the same two answers the exiles themselves were tempted by and that Jeremiah forbade. There is the answer that wants to fight its way home, to take the country back by force, to seize the levers of culture and law and the state and crank the old Christendom back into place. And there is the answer that wants to stop being different at all, to file down every offensive edge of the faith until it dissolves comfortably into the surrounding culture and the ache of being a stranger finally goes away. One wants to conquer Babylon. The other wants to move in and change its name to home. I am going to steelman both before I

refuse either, because the pull of them is enormous and I feel both of them in myself, and a church that only sneers at the people caught in them has not understood the grief underneath.

Take the first answer, the one that wants the country back. It is not held only by cynics and opportunists, whatever the caricature says. Underneath the worst of it there is very often a real love, a love of a country and an inheritance and a way of life that genuinely gave people good things, real goods, schools that taught the children something true and neighborhoods where a door could be left open at night and a shared moral vocabulary that made a common life possible. And there is a real grief at watching all of it dissolve, and a real fear for the children and grandchildren who will grow up in the ruins with none of it. Those loves are not nothing. A pastor who cannot feel the weight of them has no business speaking to the people who carry them. But name the thing at the root, because the root is rotten even where the grief is honest. The take-it-back answer believes that the kingdom of God can be advanced by the sword of Caesar, and the moment it believes that, it has lost the ability to tell the two cities apart. It mistakes the nation for the kingdom, baptizes a tribe, and produces a Christianity finally indistinguishable from a voting bloc with a worship band. You can win every election ever held with that faith and lose the only thing the church was ever sent into the world to keep.

Now take the second answer, the one that wants to stop being strange. It too deserves better than a sneer, because it almost always presents itself as compassion and sometimes sincerely is. It is a desire to remove needless offense, to stop defending things that were never worth defending, to love the very people the church has too often wounded and driven away, to be done with a cruelty that was always a betrayal of the gospel it claimed to

protect. Those instincts are not all wrong. Some of what the accommodating church wants to shed genuinely deserved shedding. But name the root here too, with the same honesty. The give-it-up answer believes that the church survives by agreeing with the world, and a church that agrees with the world about everything has nothing left to say to it and no reason on earth to exist. It will be applauded all the way to its own empty buildings, because the world has never once needed a slightly more spiritual version of what it already believes. A faith that exists only to bless the going consensus dies the very moment the consensus stops needing its blessing, and the consensus always stops needing it.

Look at what the two answers have in common, because it is the most important thing on these pages, and it is the thing neither of them can see about itself. Both are driven, underneath the bluster on the one side and the compassion on the other, by the same fear. Both, when you strip them down, do not actually believe the faith can survive without the culture's backing. The one who reaches for power cannot imagine a faithful church that is not also a powerful one. The one who reaches for approval cannot imagine a faithful church that the culture despises. Different reaches, identical terror. Both have looked at the drained water and concluded, in their bones, that the church cannot live without it. And both are wrong, and the whole back half of this book is the proof, because there was a church before there was ever any water, a church born powerless and despised in the heart of a pagan empire, and it did not merely survive there. It came alive there. It always has. The exiles were not offered either of the two answers. They were handed a third and harder thing, and this book is about that third thing: to stay, and build, and bless, and remain entirely distinct, in a city they would never control and were commanded to love anyway.

I will not pretend I stand outside any of this, because I do not, and the man who has felt only one of these pulls has not been honest with himself. There is a version of me that wants the old deference back, that misses being able to assume the room, that would happily crank the water back on if someone showed me the valve. There is a version of me that wants the clever world's approval, that would love to be the kind of Christian the people who matter find reasonable and unembarrassing at a dinner party. And there is a third version, on the tired days, that wants only to pull my wife and my five sons behind a wall and let the whole burning city fend for itself. All three of those wants are the flesh dressed up as faithfulness. All three are the cultural Christian in me grieving his lost water. And the man who met Christ in the open sea, with no water under him and no culture holding him up, knows better than all three, because he knows the church was born with none of the things the three answers are frantic to recover, and it converted an empire anyway, from the bottom of a prison, with nothing but its life.

So let me map the road, so you know where this book is taking you, because it is long and it goes somewhere. It comes in three movements. The first is diagnosis, and it is short, because it has to be, because diagnosis is the part the church has already overdosed on. We will make the water visible, the sixteen hundred years of Christendom that ran from a Roman emperor's battlefield conversion to a few decades ago in America, so that you can finally see the thing you have been swimming in. We will watch the scaffolding come down in the actual numbers and the deeper change underneath them, the quiet relocation of the throne from God to the self that the sociologist Robert Bellah saw coming as early as 1985. We will let the philosopher Charles Taylor name our condition for what it is, a secular age, not a world emptied of belief but a world in which belief has become

one contested option among many. And we will look hard at the two, or really the three, bad answers, and see that they are secretly the same answer, and refuse them.

The second and longest movement is the letter itself, taken command by command, verb by verb, because the letter is not a mood, it is a set of instructions, and instructions are meant to be obeyed and not admired. We will sit with the seventy years until the number stops being cruel and starts being merciful, until we can tell the true prophet, who hands you a shovel, from the false one, who promises you your old country by the weekend. Then we will build houses and learn what it costs to put your weight down in a place, with the writer Wendell Berry as our witness against a nation of people who cannot stay anywhere. We will learn to live in the houses we build, to work in Babylon as those who know there is no such thing as secular labor, and to rest in Babylon as those who refuse to let the empire measure them by their output. We will plant gardens, which is to say we will learn the long obedience Eugene Peterson wrote about, the willingness to plant slow things whose fruit we will not taste. We will eat the produce, because the God who sent his people into exile did not send them into a joyless one. We will take wives and raise children, and discover that the home is the first and most durable outpost of the faith in any foreign land, the place where the next generation of exiles is either formed or forfeited, one kitchen table at a time. We will seek the welfare of the city, and we will pray for it, and we will hold the hard line under all of it, which is that we do not bow.

The third movement is the great cloud of witnesses, the proof that this has all been done before and can be done again. We will stand with the church before the empire, the powerless and hunted minority that grew at something near forty percent a

decade for three centuries, and ask with the sociologist Rodney Stark the only question that matters, which is why. We will find that the answer was not strategy and not platform and not cultural power, because they had none of it, but that they lived in a way the empire could not explain, staying to nurse the sick through plagues that everyone else fled, gathering up the infants the empire threw away, sitting slave and master at one table and calling them brothers. We will sit beside Augustine as he watches Rome fall in the year 410 and writes the book that should be the constitution of every Christian living after Christendom, the book that pries the City of God apart from the city of man with both hands and shows a panicked church that the burning empire was never the indestructible kingdom in the first place. And we will end where the whole thing has been heading, with the recognition that the future of the American church does not belong to stronger tribes but to deeper disciples, and that these are not two flavors of one project but two roads that run in opposite directions, and that we are early, very early, in something long.

That last word is the one to carry out of this chapter, because everything that goes wrong in the church right now goes wrong because we are in a hurry, and the people of God were never meant to be in a hurry. You and I are not going to see the end of this. The recovery of a deep, faithful, post-Christendom church is not a project we will complete or a problem we will solve inside a program cycle or a campaign or a single lifetime. We are the early exiles, and the early exiles planted gardens whose fruit fed people they would never meet, and copied Scriptures by candlelight through centuries whose dawn they did not live to see. If we cannot make our peace with that, we will keep reaching for the fast and ruinous answers, because the fast answers are finally just the answers of people who cannot bear to

wait. The man who learns to live well in exile is not a man who never felt the longing to go home. He is a man who heard the prophet say seventy years, and grieved it, and then picked up a shovel and planted a garden in the Babylonian dirt anyway, because that was what faithfulness looked like in the world as it actually was and not the world he wished he lived in. That is the whole vocation, and it is available to a church with no power at all, which is the only kind of church that has ever changed anything.

So let me hand you the letter, the way it was actually written, the hard word and the strange commands and the buried promise that your welfare is hidden inside the welfare of a city you did not choose. But we cannot start with the commands, because the exiles could not start there either. We have to start where they started, with the grief, and with the honest work of admitting what has actually happened to the world that used to feel like home. And the first and hardest part of that work is the part the two young fish could not manage in the old story, the part about the water. Because you were swimming in something for so long that you stopped being able to see it, so long that it stopped feeling like a culture at all and simply felt like reality, like air, like the way things are. You cannot learn to live after Christendom until you can see the Christendom you are living after. So before we build a single house, we have to make the water visible, and admit that it has already drained away into the sand.

Chapter 2: The Water We Forgot Was There

The hardest part of being an exile is the moment you understand that you are one, and the reason it is hard is that for a very long time you do not feel exiled at all. You feel, instead, that something has gone wrong with the world. You feel that the country has betrayed you, that forces you cannot name have crept in and stolen the home you were standing in, that the ground shifted while you slept. The grief arrives before the understanding, and grief, being what it is, looks around for someone to blame. The schools. The courts. The other party. The young. It takes a long time and a great deal of honesty to arrive at the truer and stranger diagnosis, which is not that your home was stolen but that it was never quite your home in the way you believed. You were swimming in water you had mistaken for air. The water has drained. And now you are lying on the sand, gasping, sure that the world is ending, when what has actually ended is a particular arrangement of the world that you had confused with the world itself.

There is an old story about fish that has outlived every telling because it is true about far more than fish. Two young fish are swimming along, and an older fish passes them going the other way, and he nods and says, morning, boys, how is the water. The two young fish swim on a while, and eventually one of them looks over at the other and says, what is water. That is the entire problem with water, and it is the entire problem with what I am about to describe. The fish cannot see the water. It is not one feature of the world among others, a thing the fish could point to

and examine and hold at a distance. It is the medium. It is the given inside which everything else happens, the invisible condition of every movement the fish will ever make, and precisely because it is everywhere it is nowhere in particular. Unnoticed. Unnamed. Assumed. American Christians spent so many generations swimming in a culture that was basically on their side that they stopped experiencing it as a culture at all. It stopped feeling like an arrangement and started feeling like reality. It felt like the way things simply are.

So let me try to make the water visible, because you cannot learn to live after Christendom until you can see the Christendom you have been living inside. And to see it, you have to go back much further than the country you are grieving, all the way to a bridge over a river outside Rome, and a man who saw something in the sky, or said he did, on the morning before a battle.

For its first three hundred years the church had no political standing of any kind. None. It was an illegal assembly, a suspect and frequently hunted minority that met in borrowed houses and buried its dead in tunnels under the city and was blamed, when a fire or a plague came, for the anger of gods it refused to worship. It had no buildings it could call its own, no seat in any senate, no protection from any magistrate. It had martyrs. And then, on the twenty-eighth of October in the year 312, a Roman general named Constantine met his rival Maxentius at the Milvian Bridge on the northern approach to Rome, and he won, and he attributed the victory to the God of the Christians, whose sign he claimed to have seen blazing above the sun. The next year, in 313, he issued from Milan an edict of toleration that ended the persecution and gave the faith a legal right to exist. Twelve years after that, in 325, he summoned the bishops of the whole known church to a town called Nicaea, near his eastern capital, to settle

what Christians would confess about the Son, and an emperor who had recently been the head of a pagan state presided, in effect, over the drafting of the creed. And then, within a single human lifetime of the bridge, on the twenty-seventh of February in the year 380, an emperor named Theodosius issued an edict from Thessalonica declaring the faith of Nicaea the official religion of the Roman state, and made the old pagan sacrifices illegal, and the thing was complete. The faith that Rome had fed to lions had become the faith Rome enforced.

That is the hinge of Western history, and I want you to feel how fast it turned. Fewer than seventy years separate the edict that made it legal to be a Christian from the edict that made it official to be one. A single old man, born under persecution, could have watched the whole reversal happen. And once it turned, it stayed turned, in one form or another, for sixteen hundred years. Through the collapse of the western empire and the long labor of the monasteries. Through the crowning of Charlemagne on Christmas Day in the year 800, when a pope set an imperial crown on a Frankish king and the marriage of throne and altar was sealed for the medieval world. Through the whole vast synthesis of Christendom, in which to be European was to be baptized, and the calendar and the law and the university and the very shape of a life were assumed to be Christian all the way down. Through the fracture of the Reformation, which broke the unity but never questioned the arrangement, so that Geneva and Rome and Canterbury each in its own way kept the marriage of faith and civic order intact. And then across the sea, into the founding of a nation that promised, at last, to do the thing differently.

And America did do it differently, in the narrow legal sense, and we should be glad of it, and I will not have you hear me sneer at

it. There was no state church. There was no bishop on the public payroll, no crown enforcing a confession, no establishment of religion, and the First Amendment forbade Congress from ever making one. That disestablishment was a genuine good, and it was, in part, a Christian good, born of Baptists and dissenters who had themselves been jailed and taxed by established churches and wanted no arm of the state ever again pressing a creed on a conscience. So do not mistake what I am saying. The legal wall between church and state was not the enemy of the faith. It was, in many ways, its friend.

But what we built in the space that wall protected was subtler than a state church, and in some ways stronger, and far harder to see, and that is exactly why it fooled us. We built a cultural establishment without a legal one. The faith was woven so thoroughly into the civic furniture that no law was ever needed to enforce it, because the culture enforced it for free. The public schools opened the day in prayer and closed the week for a sabbath no statute required. The stores locked their doors on Sunday morning because everyone understood where a decent person was supposed to be. The politicians quoted the King James whether or not they had ever read it, and ended their speeches asking God to bless the country, and meant, roughly, the God the audience meant, and no one found it strange. The calendar itself bent around the Christian year, so that the nation paused, together, at Christmas and near Easter, and a child grew up assuming the whole country breathed to a rhythm set by the church. A pastor was a respected man in the town and not a suspicious one, seated near the front at the civic dinner, asked to open the meeting and bless the meal. And a person could be entirely faithless, could believe nothing at all, could darken a church door only for weddings and funerals, and still be carried his whole life by a current that ran, unmistakably, in a Christian

direction.

That current was the water. And the crucial thing about it, the thing that opens up everything that follows, is that the water held everyone up. The devout and the nominal and the outright unbeliever, all of them floated on the same buoyancy, and all of them floated for free. You did not have to believe much of anything to be lifted by it. That was the entire point. To be a broadly decent American and to be a vaguely Christian person had drifted so close to the same thing that a man could live his whole life and die without ever once having to tell them apart.

Now hear what the water did to us, because this is the wound, and it is the wound we are only now able to examine because the water has finally drained off it. The water taught us something it never once said out loud. It taught us that to be a Christian was to be central. To be normal. To be respectable. To be the home team, the majority, the ones who set the terms and expected the terms to hold. It formed in us, over generations, a whole set of expectations that we quietly mistook for the faith itself. The expectation that the institutions would defer to us. The expectation that the culture would assume us, that our holidays would be everyone's holidays and our morality would be the default morality and our book would be the book even the unbelievers half-knew. The expectation that to be a believer meant, above all, to be an insider. Not a stranger. Never a stranger.

And I want to say, as plainly as I know how, that none of that is anywhere in the New Testament. Go and look. The documents that gave us our faith were written by and to a powerless minority scattered across a hostile empire, people with no cultural standing whatsoever, people who met in secret and were slandered by their neighbors and had every institution of their

world arrayed against them. Peter writes to them as elect exiles of the dispersion. Paul writes from prison. The whole thing assumes a church on the underside of power, a church that persuades because it cannot compel, a church whose only argument is its own strange life. There is not one line in it that promises the followers of a crucified Lord that they will be the majority, or that the magistrate will bless them, or that the culture will keep their calendar. Not one.

But all of it felt, to us, like Christianity. Every bit of the arrangement felt like the faith, because we had never once known the faith in any other condition. A fish raised in water cannot imagine that water is optional. We had swum in Christendom for so long that we could no longer feel where the arrangement ended and the gospel began, and so we did the fatal thing, the thing this whole book is written to help us undo. We took the privileges of the arrangement and we quietly folded them into the gospel itself. We stitched the respectability and the centrality and the cultural deference into the very fabric of what we thought we believed, until the two could not be pulled apart, until they were one seamless garment in our hands. And so, when the privileges began to be stripped away, it did not feel like losing a set of privileges. It felt like losing the gospel. It felt like the faith itself was being torn off our backs, because we had sewn the two together so tightly and so long ago that we had genuinely forgotten they were ever two things.

We took the privileges of an arrangement and folded them into the gospel until we could not tell them apart, and so when the culture withdrew the privileges it felt for all the world like the culture was killing God.

I did this. I want to name it before I go on, because the diagnosis

of a whole church is too easy to deliver from a safe height, and I am not standing at a safe height. I catch the folding in my own chest. I catch myself missing the deference I never earned, resenting the loss of a centrality that Christ never promised me, feeling the withdrawal of the culture's assumption as though it were a personal wound and not simply the ordinary condition of every disciple who ever lived before Constantine and every disciple who lives in most of the world today. And the strange thing, the thing I have had to sit with, is that I did not even grow up in the water. I came to Christ out of atheism, as a grown man, in the full daylight of an age that assumed the opposite of everything the water once assumed. I have less excuse than most for the nostalgia I still find in myself. And I find it anyway. Which tells me the water does not only form the people who swam in it. It forms the whole church that inherited it, so deeply that even a convert who never floated in it can grieve its draining. That is how total the arrangement was. That is how invisible.

You can watch the water drain in the numbers, and the numbers are not subtle. In the early 1970s, roughly one American in twenty told a survey taker that he had no religion at all. One in twenty. A rounding error, a curiosity, a category so small it barely registered on the page. By the 2020s that figure was approaching one in three, and the people who check the box marked none had become the single fastest growing religious group in the country, larger than any denomination, larger than the whole enterprise of one entire wing of the church. That is not a dip in a cycle. That is not the sort of thing that swings back when the mood improves. That is a whole category of human being who barely existed in your grandfather's America becoming one of the largest blocs in your children's. Whatever had been holding the old arrangement up stopped holding somewhere around the turn of this century, and the fall since has

been steep, and there is no serious sign of it reversing, and a great deal of the foolishness loose in the church right now comes from people who cannot make themselves believe the water is not about to come rushing back through the door.

But a number like that hides the deeper change, and the deeper change is not how many people left. It is what replaced the thing they left. The people who walked away from the church did not, for the most part, walk into nothing. They walked into a different faith, one with no name over its door and no building on the corner, a faith so pervasive that it does not look like a faith at all, which is the surest sign that it has become the new water. The sociologist Robert Bellah saw it coming as early as 1985, in a book called *Habits of the Heart*, and he saw it in a single person, a woman he interviewed and called, to protect her, Sheila. She described her religion to him in a few sentences that ought to be carved over the door of this entire era. She believed in God, she said. She was not a religious fanatic. She could not remember the last time she had been to church. Her faith had carried her a long way. And it was her own faith, she said, her own little voice, and she gave it a name. She called it her own name. Sheilaism.

She had named her religion after herself, and Bellah understood at once that she was not a rebel. She was a prophet. She was the future, arriving early and speaking in an ordinary voice at an ordinary kitchen table. What she had done, without malice and almost without noticing, was relocate the throne. The self had quietly become the highest authority, the final court of appeal, the one voice that could not be overruled, and everything else, the church included, had been demoted to the status of a resource. Something you might consult on your way to deciding for yourself. The church was no longer the place you went to find the truth. It was one more shelf in the market of things that

might or might not work for you, to be sampled and kept or discarded according to a verdict you alone would render. The therapeutic had replaced the confessional. The old question, is it true, the question that stands over you and demands your submission whether you like the answer or not, had been swapped for a smaller and more flattering one. Does it work for me. And a faith that makes demands, a faith that tells you to take up a cross and die, does not survive that question for very long, because the whole nature of a demand is that it does not bend to whether you find it convenient.

Charles Taylor gave this whole new condition its truest name. He called ours a secular age, and he spent the better part of a thousand pages making sure we understood what he did not mean by it. He did not mean a world emptied of belief, a world where the churches are all shut and no one prays. That is not the secular age. Plenty of people still believe. What Taylor meant is something more searching and harder to escape. He meant a world in which belief has become contestable, in which the faith that was once the unspoken floor beneath everyone's feet has become one option among many, and a disputed one at that. In the age of the water, faith was the default, the assumed given, the thing you would have to work to disbelieve. In a secular age, faith is a position you take, and you take it knowing full well that the thoughtful people across the table have looked at exactly the same evidence and arrived somewhere else, and are not fools for having done so, and are not going to be argued back by the mere fact that you find your own position obvious. That is a wholly different kind of believing. It is believing without the buoyancy. It is faith in the open sea.

Lesslie Newbigin understood the shape of this before most of the church had any words for it, and he understood it because he had

crossed the world and come back. He spent the better part of forty years as a missionary in India, carrying the gospel to people who had never heard it, and when he finally returned home to Britain he found something that unsettled him more than anything he had met abroad. He found a country that had become a harder mission field than the one he had left, and a church that did not even know it had become a mission field at all. The West, he saw, was no longer pre-Christian. It was post-Christian, which is a different and lonelier kind of soil, because it is soil that has heard the seed and grown a crop and then let it wither, soil that remembers. A post-Christian culture holds the church in its memory the way a man holds a marriage he walked out of. Not nothing. Not neutral. But not the open expectancy of someone who has never heard the name. Newbigin's whole late work was a summons to the church to wake up and recognize the country it was actually standing in, to stop behaving like the chaplain of a Christian civilization and start behaving like a missionary in a strange land, because the strange land was already here, and it was called home.

So we arrive, at last, at the diagnosis, stated plainly enough to build a book on. What is dying in America is not the Christian faith. It is cultural Christianity. It is the broad and shallow belief that the water held up for free, the kind of faith that cost nothing precisely because the culture subsidized it, the nominal churchgoing and the vague civic religion and the comfortable assumption that decent people were more or less Christian and Christian people were more or less decent. That faith was never converted. It was carried. It had no roots of its own because it never needed any, because the water did the work that roots are for. And you cannot mourn, not honestly, the loss of a faith that was only ever the buoyancy of the water. It was going to evaporate the moment the water did. It was always going to. It

was the church's shadow thrown large across the wall of a culture that has now switched off the light, and a shadow is not a body, and when the light goes out the shadow does not die, because it was never alive.

The real church is still standing in the drained room. That is the thing the panic cannot see. The church with roots, the church that costs something, the church that was never the majority and never needed to be, the church that existed for three centuries with no water at all and converted an empire from underneath it, that church is exactly where it always was, standing in the emptied room in the plain morning light. It is smaller than the shadow made it look. Of course it is. The shadow was always larger than the body that cast it. But it is, for the first time in a very long time, unmistakably itself, no longer swollen by the crowds the water floated in, no longer padded by the nominal and the notional, no longer able to mistake the size of its cultural footprint for the depth of its actual life. And a church that can no longer count on the culture is a church that is about to find out what it actually believes, which is at once the most frightening thing that can happen to a people and the most clarifying, and, I have come to think, the most merciful.

We are not watching the death of the church. Let that be the verdict this chapter leaves in your hands. We are watching the end of the church's long holiday from being a minority. We are watching the water go back into the sand it came from, and we are learning, some of us slowly and some of us kicking, that we were never actually held up by it, that underneath the water the whole time there was rock, and that the rock was there before the water rose and will be there long after it has gone. The only question that remains, and it is the question that will sort the faithful from the frightened in the years ahead, is what we will

do with the discovery. Whether we will spend our one strength trying to flood the room again, cranking and pumping and grieving at the wrong graveside, or whether we will do the harder and holier thing, and turn, and look at the water we have left, and begin at last to understand how quickly it went.

Because that is the part almost no one is ready for. It is not merely that the water drained. It is how astonishingly fast it drained, faster than any arrangement sixteen centuries in the making had any right to collapse, a leak that became a flood inside a single generation while the people standing in the room were still arguing about whether the floor was wet. That speed is its own kind of revelation, and it is the next thing we have to face. So let me show you the day the scaffolding came down, and how few years it took, and why the very swiftness of the fall is telling us something about what was holding the thing up all along.

Chapter 3: The Day the Scaffolding Came Down

Ask ten Christians when it happened and you will get ten different years, and each one will name the year by what he personally lost. A man will say 1962, when the Supreme Court took organized prayer out of the public schools in Engel against Vitale, and a certain kind of believer felt, for the first time in his life, the cold draft of a country telling him no. Another will say 1963, when the Court followed it the next year by ending mandated Bible reading. Someone older will point further back, to a thing he cannot quite date, the slow disappearance of the world his grandmother described. Someone younger will point to an election, or to a single Sunday when he looked around the sanctuary of the church he grew up in and understood that the young families were simply gone and were not coming back. Everyone has a year. Almost no one has the same one.

They are all wrong, and they are all right, and the reason they cannot agree is that they are looking for a day. There was no day. What happened to the American church was not an execution but a slow leak, a draining so gradual that for decades you could stand in the room and feel the water going down around your ankles and tell yourself it was only a bad season, only a wet spot on the floor, only the other party or the courts or the culture having a bad decade. The leak had been running a long time before anyone noticed it was a flood. And by the time we noticed, somewhere around the turn of this century, the water was already most of the way gone, and a whole generation was standing in a drained room wondering who had pulled the plug

and refusing, with a stubbornness that would be admirable if it were not so costly, to believe that the water was not about to come rushing back.

I want to make you look at the leak, because the whole argument of this book depends on getting the diagnosis right, and getting the diagnosis right depends on being able to say plainly what drained and what did not. So I am going to do the unglamorous thing first. I am going to show you the numbers. And then I am going to tell you why the numbers, true as they are, hide the change that actually matters, and why almost everyone who quotes them is mourning the wrong death.

The Rounding Error and the Third

You can watch the water drain in the surveys, and the surveys are not subtle. In the early 1970s, when the sociologists at the University of Chicago began asking a national sample of Americans, year after year, what their religion was, the share who answered none, no religion at all, was about one in twenty. Five percent. It was a rounding error. It was a curiosity, a category so small that a person could go his whole life in most of this country without knowingly meeting one, the village atheist, the odd cousin, the professor everyone whispered about. The box marked none was the box almost nobody checked, and the people who did check it were understood by everyone, including themselves, to be exceptions to a rule that held for the entire society. The rule was that Americans were religious. The rule was that decent people believed something. The exceptions proved it.

By the 2020s that same box, asked in that same way, was checked by nearly one American in three. The rounding error had become one of the largest religious groups in the country, larger than any single Protestant denomination, larger than the

Catholic share by some measures, growing while nearly everything else shrank. The people the sociologists took to calling the nones, spelled like the negation and not like the sisters, had gone in a single human lifetime from the margin of the survey to the center of it. A person who was born when the figure was five percent and lived an ordinary span watched it become almost thirty. That is not a dip in a cycle. That is not the kind of thing that happens and then unhappens. That is a whole category of human being, a way of standing toward God and church and the memory of both, that barely existed in your grandfather's America becoming one of the defining blocs of your children's.

And it did not stop at the box. Every measure the sociologists know how to take moved in the same direction and at something like the same speed. Church membership, which the pollsters at Gallup had tracked at around seventy percent of Americans for the whole middle of the twentieth century, steady as a heartbeat for sixty years, fell below fifty percent for the first time in the recorded history of the question right around 2020. Weekly attendance dropped. The share of Americans who told a survey-taker they belonged to no house of worship at all climbed year over year. The mainline Protestant denominations, the ones that had been the establishment inside the establishment, the churches of the presidents and the country clubs, lost members by the millions across a few decades, some of them shedding more than half their people. Whatever had been holding the old arrangement up, whatever invisible thing had kept those numbers so high for so long that everyone assumed they were permanent, stopped holding somewhere around the year 2000, and the fall since has been steady, and there is no serious demographer anywhere who thinks it is about to reverse.

I could go on with the numbers, and the temptation of a chapter like this is to keep going, to pile survey on survey until the sheer weight of the data does the emotional work. I am going to resist it, because the numbers, for all their force, are the least interesting true thing in this chapter. They tell you how many people left. They do not tell you what they left for, and they do not tell you what died, and it is entirely possible to get every number right and still be weeping at the wrong funeral. So set the surveys down. The question that matters is not how many walked out. The question is what walked in behind them, into the space the leaving cleared, and to answer that question we have to go back to 1985 and meet a woman named Sheila.

Sheila, and the Little Voice

In 1985 the sociologist Robert Bellah published, with four colleagues, a book called *Habits of the Heart*, and it did something that decades of survey data could not do. It put a face on the change. Bellah and his team were not counting heads. They were sitting in living rooms across America, listening to ordinary people talk about their lives, their work, their marriages, their sense of what made a life good, and what they heard, underneath everything, was a country that had lost the shared moral languages it used to speak and had fallen back, almost without noticing, onto the only language it had left, which was the language of the self. Americans, Bellah found, could still talk fluently about their feelings, their needs, their growth, their fulfillment. They had gone nearly mute about duty, about obligation, about anything a person is bound to whether it serves him or not. The moral vocabulary had thinned to a single word, and the word was I.

And then, in the middle of the book, Bellah introduced the woman who would outlive every statistic in it, a young nurse he

called Sheila Larson, a name changed to protect her, though she has since become more famous under the mask than she ever could have been beneath it. Sheila described her faith to Bellah's interviewer in a few sentences that ought to be carved over the door of this entire era. She said she believed in God. She said she was not a religious fanatic. She said she could not remember the last time she had been to church. She said her faith had carried her a long way. And then she named it. It was her own faith, she said. It was Sheilaism. Just her own little voice.

She had named her religion after herself. Not after Christ, not after a church, not after a tradition or a creed or a book, but after Sheila, because the final authority in her faith, the court from which there was no appeal, was Sheila. And Bellah, who was too good a scholar to sneer, understood immediately that he was not looking at a rebel. He was looking at a prophet. Sheila was not the exception to where America was going. She was the future, arriving a little early, saying out loud and without embarrassment the thing that tens of millions of her countrymen already half-believed and would soon believe entirely, which was that religion is a private matter of personal preference, that the self is the arbiter of the sacred, that you consult the traditions the way you consult a menu, taking the dishes that suit you and sending the rest back, and that the little voice inside is the closest thing to God that a modern person can be expected to obey.

Sit in how strange that is, and then sit in how normal it now sounds, because the distance between those two feelings is the exact measure of how far the water has drained. To a Christian of any previous century, Sheilaism would have been not one religion among many but the definition of no religion at all, the elevation of the self to the throne that belongs to God, the oldest sin in the book wearing the mildest possible smile. To a Christian

of the present century it sounds like your neighbor. It sounds like your cousin. It sounds, if we are honest, like the unconverted floor of a good deal of what still passes for faith inside the church, because the little voice has gotten inside the sanctuary too, and a great many people who sit in pews on Sunday are practicing a quiet Sheilaism the rest of the week, believing what they find agreeable and declining what they do not, treating the church as a resource for a faith they have already decided the shape of on their own.

Bellah gave us the woman. He did not fully name the machine that produced her, and for that we have to reach for a phrase that a later sociologist, Christian Smith, would coin to describe what he found when he interviewed a generation of American teenagers about their beliefs and discovered that most of them, churchd and unchurchd alike, had converged on the same unspoken creed. He called it moralistic therapeutic deism, and the mouthful is worth the trouble, because each word names a load-bearing beam of the thing that replaced the faith. Moralistic, because its whole content is that you should be nice and fair and good. Therapeutic, because the point of God is to make you feel better about yourself and to be there when you need help. Deism, because the God of this creed is real but distant, a manager who set the world running and stays politely out of the way unless you call the front desk with a problem. It is Sheilaism with a doctrine, and it is, Smith found, the actual functioning religion of most Americans under forty, including a startling number who could still recite the creeds of the churches they attended without believing a word of them in the sense the churches meant.

That is what walked in behind the ones who walked out. Not, at first, a hostile atheism. Not a militant unbelief that hated the church and wanted it destroyed. Something milder and, in the

end, more corrosive, a therapeutic religion of the self that kept the vocabulary of God and quietly moved the throne, so that the question a person brought to any claim, any command, any doctrine, any church, stopped being the old question and became a new one.

The Therapeutic Replaces the Confessional

The old question was: is it true. The new question is: does it work for me.

I want to slow down on this, because it is the hinge of the whole change and it is easy to say quickly and hard to feel. For most of the history of the church, a person came to the faith the way you come to a fact about the world. You came asking whether it was so. Did God become man. Did he die. Did he rise. Is the tomb empty. Is there a judgment coming. The faith made claims, hard claims, about what had actually happened and what was actually true, and a person stood before those claims the way you stand before any claim about reality, obligated to reckon with them whether or not they were convenient, whether or not they made you feel good, whether or not they fit the life you had already decided to live. The church was the place you went to find out what was true and to be told, on occasion, that the truth condemned you and that you needed to change. The confessional, in every tradition that had one and in every heart that did not, was the room where a person laid his life down against a standard outside himself and found himself wanting and asked for mercy. The whole transaction assumed an authority the self did not control.

The therapeutic dissolves all of that, gently, without a fight. It does not argue that the claims are false. It simply changes the question you are permitted to ask about them. It relocates the standard from outside the self to inside it, so that the measure of

any belief is no longer whether it is true but whether it helps, whether it heals, whether it fits, whether it makes you feel seen and safe and whole. And a faith that makes demands cannot survive that question for long, because the entire point of a demand is that it does not bend to whether it works for you. A command that only binds you when you find it agreeable is not a command. It is a suggestion you have already decided to take. The moment the therapeutic question becomes the only question a culture knows how to ask, the confessional is finished, not because anyone tore it down but because no one can any longer imagine why they would enter it. You do not confess to a God you have hired as your therapist. You do not repent before a standard you set yourself. You do not kneel to a little voice.

Philip Rieff, the sociologist who saw this coming even before Bellah, called it the triumph of the therapeutic, and he understood that it was not a new religion so much as the solvent that dissolves all the old ones. Every previous culture, Rieff argued, had organized itself around a set of demands, a sacred order that told people what they were forbidden and what they were for, and had produced its characteristic person by forming him against those demands. The therapeutic culture is the first in history organized around the abolition of demands, around the liberation of the self from every standard it did not choose, and it produces a characteristic person too, the one Rieff called psychological man, who lives for well-being and asks of everything only whether it contributes to his sense of himself. That person cannot be a Christian in any sense the word has ever borne, not because he has rejected the faith but because he has quietly dissolved the ground on which the faith stands, the ground where something outside you has the right to tell you what to do.

We built this. I want to say that plainly, because it is tempting to describe the therapeutic as something the secular world did to the church from outside, and it is not. The church helped build it. We baptized it. We took the therapeutic and dressed it in Christian clothes and preached it from our own pulpits, the sermon series on your best life, the gospel repackaged as the solution to your felt needs, the worship engineered to produce a feeling, the whole vast apparatus of a Christianity that sold itself to the therapeutic age by promising to be therapeutic, to work, to help, to heal, to make you the person you already wanted to be. We asked the culture's question in our own sanctuaries. We taught two generations to come to God asking whether it worked for them, and now we are astonished that when it stopped working for them, when the felt need was met more efficiently by a screen or a supplement or a self-help book, they left, and took their little voice with them, and did not look back. We did this. I have done this. I have preached the God who meets your needs to people who needed, more than anything, to be told that they were not the point.

What Actually Died

So here we are, standing in the drained room with the numbers in one hand and Sheila's little voice in the other, and the church has looked at all of it, the empty box and the relocated throne and the therapeutic solvent, and reached the conclusion that seems obvious and is, I am convinced, catastrophically wrong. The church has concluded that the faith is dying.

It is not. Something is dying. Something real, something that felt for a long time exactly like the faith, something whose death is producing genuine grief that I will not mock, because I feel it too. But what is dying is not Christianity. What is dying is cultural Christianity, and the two are not the same thing, and the

failure to tell them apart is the single most expensive mistake the American church is making right now.

Christendom is the arrangement. It is the long stretch of history, running from a Roman emperor's conversion to a few decades ago in this country, in which Christianity was assumed, established, respectable, and held up, for free, by the power of the surrounding culture. It is the water. Christianity is the thing itself, a crucified and risen Lord, a gospel, a people, a way of life that was already three centuries old and had already turned an empire upside down before any emperor ever made it official. Cultural Christianity is what happens when the second thing lives long enough inside the first that people forget the difference, the broad and shallow belief that the water held up for nothing, the nominal churchgoing and the vague civic religion and the assumption that decent people were more or less Christian and that being American and being Christian were close enough to the same thing that you never had to tell them apart. That faith, the subsidized kind, the carried kind, is evaporating, and it was always going to, because it had no roots of its own. It was never converted. It was carried. And you cannot mourn the loss of a faith that was only ever the buoyancy of the water.

The cultural Christian was never converted. He was carried. What we are watching is not the death of the church but the evaporation of its shadow on the wall of a culture that has finally turned out the light.

The picture I keep coming back to is the scaffolding and the building. When a great structure is going up, or being repaired, the crews throw scaffolding around it, a whole exterior skeleton of pipe and plank, and for a season the scaffolding is so total, so

wrapped around every surface, that from the street you can no longer see the building underneath. You see the scaffolding. You come to think of the scaffolding as the shape of the thing. And then one day the work is done, or the arrangement ends, and the crews take the scaffolding down, and there is always a moment, if you have forgotten what was under there, when it looks for all the world like the building is being demolished. The clatter of falling pipe. The exposed and naked walls. The sudden absence of the familiar exterior. A person who mistook the scaffolding for the building would stand in the street and weep, certain he was watching a demolition, when in fact he was watching a building emerge, for the first time in years, as itself.

That is precisely what is happening, and precisely why we are grieving. Christendom was the scaffolding. For sixteen hundred years it wrapped the faith so completely, the established church and the Christian calendar and the schools that opened in prayer and the stores that closed on Sunday and the politicians who quoted the King James whether they had read it or not, that we stopped being able to see the building underneath. We came to think the scaffolding was the shape of Christianity. We came to believe that to be a Christian was to be central, normal, respectable, the majority that set the terms, and none of that is anywhere in the New Testament, which was written by and to a hunted minority under a hostile empire, but all of it felt like the faith, because we had never known the faith in any other condition. And now the scaffolding is coming down, with all the clatter and all the exposed walls, and we are standing in the street weeping at a demolition that is not a demolition. The building is fine. The building was always fine. We were told for so long that the scaffolding was the building that we can no longer tell the difference, and so we are weeping at the wrong funeral.

I have stood in that street. I want to be honest about the fact that the diagnosis is easier to write than to feel, because even a man like me, who came to Christ out of atheism as a grown adult and never once swam in the water, who has less excuse than almost anyone for the nostalgia, even I catch it in my own chest, the ache for a country that would assume the faith on my behalf, the wish that the room were on my side. The pull of the scaffolding is enormous even for those of us who never needed it, because it is comfortable, because it is easy, because a faith the culture holds up for free costs so much less than a faith you have to carry yourself. The grief at its loss is real grief. I am not asking you not to grieve. I am asking you to grieve the right thing, to weep at the correct funeral, to understand that the body in the casket is cultural Christianity and not Christ, and that Christ, as it happens, has a long history of being pronounced dead by people standing at the wrong tomb.

The Wrong Funeral

Consider what the death of cultural Christianity actually clears away, because the church has been so busy mourning it that no one has stopped to notice that a good deal of what is dying was worth losing. Cultural Christianity gave us a country full of people who called themselves Christian and had never met Christ, who wore the name like a coat they had inherited and never once examined, who assumed that being born in a Christian nation made them Christian the way being born in a garage would make them a car. It gave us churches full of the unconverted, kept full by social pressure and civic habit, where the gospel could go unpreached for a generation because everyone already assumed they were fine. It gave us a faith so cheap, so undemanding, so thoroughly subsidized by the surrounding culture, that it could not tell the difference between

a disciple and a respectable citizen, and did not need to, because the water held them both up equally and asked nothing of either. That is what is draining away. And a church that has the courage to look clearly at what it is losing will find, mixed into the genuine grief, a strange and unexpected relief, because the thing that is dying was never the church. It was the thing that made the church impossible to find.

The real church, the one with roots, the one that costs something, the one that was never the majority and never needed to be, is still standing in the drained room. It is smaller than the shadow the water made it look, and that smallness is a shock, and the shock is part of the grief, because for a long time we counted the shadow and called it the church and comforted ourselves with numbers that were mostly water. But it is also, for the first time in a very long time, unmistakably itself. A church that has stopped being able to count on the culture is a church that is about to find out what it actually believes, which is the most clarifying thing that can happen to a people, and the most frightening, and the most necessary. The drought does not create shallow faith. It exposes it. And it exposes, at the same time and in the same drought, the faith that was never shallow, the roots that went down long before the sky turned to brass, the disciples who were disciples when it cost nothing and will still be disciples now that it costs everything, standing in the open room, holding onto the Lord who was always the only thing holding them up.

Lesslie Newbigin saw this before most of us, and I will let him have something close to the last word in this chapter, because he earned it in a way I have not. He spent nearly forty years as a missionary in India, carrying the gospel to people who had never heard it, and when he finally came home to Britain he found

something that broke his heart and cleared his vision at once. He found a country that had become a harder mission field than the one he had left, and a church that did not even know it had become one. The West, he understood, is not pre-Christian. It is post-Christian. It has the church in its memory the way a man has a marriage he walked out of, and that is not nothing, and it is not the same as never having married at all, and it requires a different and lonelier kind of missionary than the one who comes to people who have never heard the name. Newbigin came back to a drained room and, instead of weeping at the funeral, asked the only question worth asking, which was how the gospel could become credible again in a culture that had heard it and moved on. That is our question now. That is the question the rest of this book is trying to answer.

But we cannot answer it yet, and here is why. We have named what drained and what did not. We have said, as plainly as I know how, that the scaffolding is coming down and the building is fine, that cultural Christianity is dying and Christianity is not, that we have been weeping at the wrong funeral. That is a true diagnosis and a necessary one, and it is also not enough, because it treats the change as if it were only a change in the numbers, only a shift in who checks which box, only the draining of a visible water we could see if we looked. And the deepest part of the change is not visible at all. The deepest part is not that fewer people believe. It is that belief itself has changed its nature, that the very air we all breathe now, the frame through which every one of us sees the world, believer and unbeliever alike, has been rebuilt so thoroughly that we can no longer see it, any more than the fish can see the water it was born in. The therapeutic did not just empty the pews. It rebuilt the lenses behind everyone's eyes, ours included, so that even our faith comes to us bent through a shape we did not choose and cannot detect.

To understand that, to see the frame we are all sealed inside and cannot climb out of, we have to leave the numbers behind entirely and go to the one thinker who spent eight hundred pages describing it. We have to understand what it means to live, as every last one of us now does, in a secular age. And the first thing to understand about that age is that it is not a room emptied of God. It is a room fitted with lenses, ground so finely and worn so long that we have forgotten they are there, and until we can name them we will keep mistaking the shape of the glass for the shape of the world.

Chapter 4: A Secular Age

There is a question that would have been unaskable to almost every human being who ever lived, and you have asked it, and so have I, and so has your most devout neighbor, in the small hours when the house is quiet and the arguments stop. The question is not whether God is good. It is not even whether God is there. The question is whether you would believe any of it at all if you had been born somewhere else, to someone else, into some other room. That question is the whole weather system of the age we live in, and the man who named it best spent eight hundred pages describing a single shift, a shift so total and so invisible that most of the people living inside it have no idea it happened. His name is Charles Taylor, and in 2007 he published a book called *A Secular Age*, and the argument of that enormous book can be set down in one sentence that will take the rest of this chapter to feel.

Five hundred years ago it was nearly impossible not to believe in God. Now it is one option among many, and often not the easiest one.

That is the change. Not that people stopped believing, though many have. The change is deeper than the count of believers and unbelievers, and it runs underneath both. Taylor is careful, almost fussy, about what he is not saying. He is not saying we live in a world emptied of faith, and he spends real energy attacking the lazy story that says religion was a fog that science burned off, that as the human race got smarter it simply outgrew its gods the way a boy outgrows his fear of the dark. That story is a fairy tale the secular age tells about itself, and Taylor dismantles it, because the truth is stranger and harder. What

changed was not the amount of belief in the world. What changed were the conditions of belief. What changed was what it feels like to believe anything at all.

Set two men side by side, one in 1500 and one now, and watch the difference. The man in 1500 does not believe in God the way you believe in a proposition, after weighing it against the alternatives. He does not believe in God the way he might believe that a certain field will yield a good crop or that the king is a fool. He believes in God the way he believes in the ground under his feet, because there is no thinkable alternative, because atheism is not a position a serious person holds but a kind of madness, because the entire cosmos he lives in is shot through with meaning and spirit and moral order from the highest heaven to the lowest ditch. God is not a hypothesis for that man. God is the floor. To stop believing would not be to change his mind. It would be to go insane, to step outside the shared world entirely, and there is nowhere outside to step. Belief, for him, is not chosen. It is simply the water, and we have already learned in this book what water does to the fish who cannot see it.

Now the man now. He believes, let us say. He is devout. He prays, he goes to church, he gives, he means it. And still, even for him, belief has changed its texture, because he holds his faith in a world where the person across the dinner table does not, and is not mad, and is in fact kind and intelligent and has looked at more or less the same evidence and drawn the opposite conclusion. His own children may walk away from what he believes and become decent, thriving, unremarkable adults, and everyone he knows will treat that as ordinary. He believes, in other words, knowing that his belief is contestable, that it is a position and not a floor, that thoughtful people have taken the other seat and are perfectly comfortable there. And that

knowledge, whether he admits it or not, gets into his believing. It changes what faith feels like from the inside. He believes in the open sea, and the man in 1500 believed in the shallows, and the difference between them is not the strength of their conviction. It is the world their conviction sits inside.

Taylor calls the thing that produced this the coming of the immanent frame, and the phrase is worth slowing down on, because it names the box we are all living in whether we chose it or not. The immanent frame is a way of experiencing the world as a closed system, a self-contained order of nature that runs by its own laws and needs no reference to anything above it or beyond it to be complete. Cause and effect. Matter and mechanism. A universe you could in principle explain all the way down without ever once mentioning God. That does not mean the immanent frame forces you into unbelief. Taylor is emphatic that it does not, that you can live inside the immanent frame and still believe the frame is open at the top, still hold that the closed order of nature is itself held in the hand of God. But you can also live inside it and believe the frame is closed, that nature is all there is and all there ever was, and the point, the unnerving point, is that both readings now feel available. The frame itself is the default. Whether you crack a window in it and let the transcendent back in is, for the first time in human history, up to you. And a faith you have to hold open against the pull of a frame that wants to close is a different animal than a faith the whole world holds open for you.

I want to be honest about how deep this goes, because it does not stop at the unbeliever, and the church makes a fatal error when it imagines the immanent frame as a problem out there, a secular fog afflicting other people. The frame is the air we all breathe. It has gotten into the church, into the devout, into me. James K. A.

Smith, who has done the labor of reading Taylor for the rest of us and giving us the short version, puts it with a bluntness that stings. Even our believing, he says, has become buffered. We believe in God now the way you believe a fact, a piece of information filed in the head, in a world otherwise experienced as flat and closed and disenchanted, rather than dwelling in God the way the saints did, moving through a world lit from the inside by his presence at every point. We say we believe in a God who fills all things, and then we live, functionally, hour by hour, as though the material world were a closed machine and God a conclusion we affirm on Sundays. The immanent frame is not the unbeliever's prison. It is the shared house, and the believer has a room in it too, and the walls press in on the faithful as surely as on anyone else.

This is where Taylor hands us the single most useful pair of words in the whole book, and I have watched them explain people to themselves in a way almost nothing else does. He says the modern person is a buffered self, where our ancestors were porous selves, and the whole psychological weather of the age is the difference between the two.

The porous self is the older self, and it is the self of nearly everyone who lived before the modern world. To be porous is to be open, permeable, unsealed at the edges, to live in a world where meanings and spirits and powers can get at you from outside, where a curse can land on you and a blessing can enter you and the boundary between the self and the world is thin and crossable. The porous self is vulnerable in a way we can barely imagine, exposed to forces it did not invent and cannot fully control, which is frightening, but it is also never alone, never sealed off, never trapped inside its own skull, because the same openness that lets the demons in lets God in, and the world it

lives in is charged, full, alive with presence, a world where the sacred is not a private opinion but a public and dangerous fact.

The buffered self is us. To be buffered is to be sealed, bounded, protected, to have a firm border between what is inside the mind and what is outside it, so that meaning lives in here, in my head, in my choices, in my interior life, and the world out there is just stuff, neutral, mechanical, disenchanted, unable to reach in and touch me without my permission. The buffered self is the great achievement of the modern age and it is real gain. It is safer. The curse cannot land on it, because it does not believe in curses, and the boundary holds. It is master of the meanings inside its own walls. But read the fine print on that safety, because the same wall that keeps the demons out keeps everything else out too, and the buffered self, having sealed itself against a hostile enchanted cosmos, finds that it has also sealed itself into a cosmos gone silent, a universe of matter and mechanism with no voice in it but its own. The porous self was exposed and never alone. The buffered self is safe and desperately, structurally lonely, and it does not know why, because the loneliness is built into the walls it mistook for freedom.

Read your own restlessness in that. The low ambient anxiety of the age, the sense so many people carry that something is missing and they cannot name it, the epidemic of a loneliness that no amount of connection seems to touch. Taylor gives it a diagnosis the therapists mostly miss. We built the buffer to keep the frightening enchanted world at bay, and we succeeded, and now we live inside the buffer and it turns out to be a cell. We are safe from the spirits and cut off from God in the same wall. We are masters of our own interior and prisoners of it in the same act. And the church, which should be the one place a buffered person could come and have the walls opened, has too often

simply offered a buffered version of the faith, God as one more managed meaning inside the sealed self, a private conviction that leaves the frame closed and the wall intact and the loneliness exactly where it was.

And now the turn this whole chapter has been building toward, the hardest thing in it, the thing that ought to keep a pastor up at night. If the immanent frame is the air we breathe, and the buffered self is the shape we have all been pressed into, then the faith we hold has been reshaped by both, and we cannot see it, because you cannot see the frame you are looking through. We do not read the faith straight. We read it through lenses, and the lenses were ground for us by an age we did not choose, and we have worn them so long that we have stopped experiencing them as lenses. We think we are seeing the gospel plain. We are seeing the gospel bent, and the bending is invisible precisely because it is total.

Consider the lenses one at a time, because naming them is the first step to seeing them, and seeing them is the only way to take them off.

There is the individualist lens, and it may be the thickest of all, so thick that most American Christians cannot conceive of the faith without it. We read a book that was written to a people, addressed to a covenant community, saturated in the plural, and we hear it as a message to me, about my personal relationship with God, my private salvation, my individual walk. Robert Bellah saw this coming and gave it a face. In 1985, in *Habits of the Heart*, he interviewed a woman he called Sheila, who described her faith in a sentence that ought to be carved over the door of this whole era. She believed in God. She was not a religious fanatic. She could not remember the last time she had been to church. And it was her own faith, she said, Sheilaism,

just her own little voice. Bellah understood that she was not a rebel. She was a prophet. She had simply drawn out to its end the lens the whole culture had already ground, the lens that makes the sovereign individual the final authority and the private inner voice the last court of appeal. The self had quietly become the throne, and the church had been demoted from the place you go to find the truth to one more resource you might consult on your way to deciding it for yourself. And the terrifying thing is not that the world thinks this way. It is that the church thinks this way, that we have read Sheilism back into the Bible until we can no longer hear how strange our individualism would have sounded to Paul, who did not have a private faith and would not have understood the concept, because he had a people.

There is the consumer lens, and it rides in on the back of the first. Once the self is the throne, everything else becomes a product laid out before the throne for its selection, and the faith takes its place on the shelf beside the others. The question a consumer asks is never is it true. The question a consumer asks is does it work for me, does it meet my needs, does it fit, and a faith run through the consumer lens becomes a set of services to be evaluated by the customer, a church to be chosen the way you choose a gym, a doctrine to be kept if it comforts and discarded if it demands. Taylor traces how the therapeutic slowly replaced the confessional, how the whole vocabulary of the inner life shifted from sin and grace to needs and fulfillment, and the church, desperate to keep the customer, too often just changed its signage to match. We began to sell the faith the way you sell anything to a buffered self, as a means to its own flourishing, a technique for a better life, and in doing so we handed the sovereignty to the very customer we were meant to be converting, and a customer is a king you cannot preach the cross to, because the cross is the one product that tells the buyer he

must die.

There is the national lens, and this one is nearly invisible to Americans because it feels like patriotism, which feels like virtue. It is the lens that quietly fuses the story of God with the story of the country, that reads the church's hope through the frame of the nation's destiny, that hears thy kingdom come and thinks, without quite noticing the substitution, God bless America. We will spend a whole chapter later on the wreckage this makes, so I will not lay it all out here. I only want to name it as a lens, an inherited way of reading that most who wear it never chose and cannot see, a way of taking a faith that was born stateless under a hostile empire and cannot be owned by any flag, and quietly wrapping it in one flag until the two become one object in the hand and cannot be pulled apart. And the whole burden of this book is that they must be pulled apart, that the exile begins the day you feel them come loose.

And there is the political lens, which is the national lens turned toward the machinery of power. It reads the faith as a program to be enacted through the levers of law and state and culture, so that being a faithful Christian comes to mean holding the correct positions and winning the correct fights, and the gospel is slowly bent into the shape of a platform, and the church into the chaplaincy of a coalition. Left and right both do this, and each is convinced only the other has done it. The lens is not a set of policies. It is the prior assumption that the faith is fundamentally about which side wins, an assumption so deep in the American church that to question it sounds like apathy, when in fact it is the assumption that the powerless early church did not hold and could not have held, and grew explosively without.

What these four lenses have in common is the buried theme of the whole chapter. Not one of them is in the New Testament. The

individualism, the consumerism, the nationalism, the reduction of faith to politics, all of it was ground for us by the immanent frame and the buffered self and the long habits of Christendom, absorbed with the water, breathed in with the air, and then folded so quietly into the faith itself that we came to mistake the lens for the light. We did this. I did this. I have read the plural letters of a covenant people as private mail addressed to me. I have evaluated churches like a customer and called it discernment. I have felt the story of God and the story of my country fuse in my chest and mistaken the warmth for worship. Not one of those was faithfulness. Every one of them was the frame, doing its silent work on a man who thought he was just reading his Bible.

We did not lose the faith. We refracted it, through lenses an age handed us and we never thought to take off, and then we called the bent thing the gospel and defended it to the death.

And this, at last, is why Taylor matters so much for a church in exile, and why I have given him a whole chapter instead of a paragraph. The end of Christendom is not only the draining of the water we felt in the first chapters. It is the removal of the lenses, or rather the exposure of them, the sudden ability to see the frame because the culture has stopped holding it perfectly still. When the faith was assumed, when everyone in the room shared the same lenses, you could not see them, any more than you can see your own glasses. But now the room does not share them. Now the person across the table has taken the other seat, and the frame that seemed like reality is revealed as one frame among possible frames, and the lenses that seemed like sight are revealed as lenses. That revelation is disorienting, and it feels like loss, and it is the beginning of the only clarity available to us, because a church that can finally see its lenses is a church

that can finally take some of them off.

I said Taylor was careful not to tell the fog-and-science story, and I want to return to that, because it guards us against a despair the age keeps pressing on us. The immanent frame did not close because the human race got too smart for God. Belief did not retreat before proof. Taylor shows, patiently, over hundreds of pages, that no such proof ever arrived, that the closing of the frame was not a discovery but a construction, a slow rearrangement of what feels obvious, a shift in the plausible rather than a verdict of the reason. Which means it can shift again. The frame that closed can open. The plausibility that drained away is not a fact of nature but a mood of an age, and moods pass, and the deep human hunger for the transcendent that the buffer was built to seal out is still there, aching inside the wall, unnamed and unmet, in the loneliest generation the West has ever produced. The buffered self is not satisfied. It is starving. And a starving world is not a closed door to the gospel. It is an open wound the gospel was made for.

But naming the frame is not the same as escaping it, and I will not pretend the church can simply think its way out of an age it was formed by. You do not argue a person out of the buffered self, because the buffer is not an argument, it is a formation, ground into the body by ten thousand repetitions of a disenchanted life. And a church that has spent generations wearing the lenses of the age will not lay them down by being told to. It has to be re-formed, slowly, by a different set of practices and a different set of loves, and that is the long labor the back half of this book is finally for. But before we can build the thing that forms a porous soul in a buffered age, we have to reckon with what the church actually does when it first feels the water drain and the lenses slip and the frame close in. Because a

frightened people, told that the world they assumed is gone, does not usually respond by taking off its glasses and learning to see. It reaches, in its panic, for one of a small number of escapes, each of them a way of refusing the exile rather than living it. It tries to force the water back. It tries to dissolve into the age so the ache will stop. Or it tries to wall itself off and wait for the barbarians to lose interest. Three answers, and each of them wears the face of faithfulness, and each of them is the flesh grieving its lost home. Those three are what we turn to now.

Chapter 5: Take It Back, Give It Up, or Wall It Off

Tell a people that their world has ended and they will reach, almost every time, for one of a small number of answers, and the answers are old. They were old in Babylon. There were prophets in the exile with names we half remember, Hananiah the loudest of them, telling the captives exactly what their grief wanted to hear, and there were quieter men whose names we do not have at all, who had already stopped writing home to Jerusalem, who had already begun to let the old language go, who wanted only for the ache of being different to end. Jeremiah's letter spends as much of its strength forbidding the wrong responses as commanding the right one, which should tell us something. The wrong responses are not exotic. They are the reflexes of a grieving people. They rise in the heart before the mind has said a word, and they wear the clothes of faithfulness, and they are still with us, and they are in me.

I have felt all three. I need to say that at the front, before I lay a hand on any of them, because a man who has felt only one of the temptations he is about to name has not been honest with himself, and the reader will smell it. There is a version of me that wants the old country back, that misses being able to assume the room, that would happily crank the water back on if someone handed me the valve. There is a version of me that wants the clever world's approval, that would love to be the kind of Christian the people who matter find reasonable and unembarrassing. And there is a version of me, on the tired days, on the days when the news is bad and the children are watching

something I cannot see the bottom of, that wants only to pull my family behind a wall and let the whole burning city go. Three wants. All three are the flesh dressed as faithfulness. All three are the cultural Christian in me grieving his lost water. I am not standing above this chapter. I am standing inside it, and I am naming the idols I have personally served.

Because that is what they are. Not strategies. Idols. Three ways to keep the thing we actually worship, which is not God but the arrangement that made God convenient. Let me take them one at a time, and let me do the hard work first, which is to make each one as strong as it can be made before I refuse it, because a temptation you have not steelmanned is a temptation you have not understood, and a man who only sneers at the other two answers has not grasped the people who hold them, which means he has not grasped himself.

The first answer: take it back

The first answer is to fight your way home. If Christendom is falling, this answer says, then the task of the faithful is to hold it up, by force if that is what it takes, to seize the levers of culture and law and the state and crank the old arrangement back into place. This is the impulse behind the harder forms of what we now call Christian nationalism, the fusion of cross and flag, the conviction that the way to save the faith is to make the nation Christian again by making it obey. It has a genealogy. It goes back to the fourth century and a Roman emperor who saw a sign in the sky before a battle at the Milvian Bridge in 312, and won, and issued an edict of toleration the next year, and within a single lifetime, under Theodosius in 380, watched the faith Rome had fed to lions become the official religion of Rome. That was the day the church got the lever, and the take-it-back answer is, at bottom, the longing to hold the lever again. It is the

fourth century's ghost, and it is not going quietly.

I want to steelman it, and I want to do it seriously, because it is not held only by cynics and grifters, whatever the people who despise it want to believe. Underneath the worst of it there is very often a real love. A love of a country and a heritage and a way of life that genuinely gave people good things, that fed the hungry and buried the dead and married the young and taught the children to read out of a book that told them the truth. A real grief at watching that dissolve. A real fear, and it is not a foolish fear, for the children who will grow up in the ruins, catechized by a culture that has lost the plot, formed by screens their parents cannot follow into. Those loves are not nothing. A grandfather who wants his grandchildren to inherit what he inherited is not a monster, and a church that can only mock him has not earned the right to correct him. There is also a genuine theological instinct buried in there, an instinct that the lordship of Christ is public and not merely private, that Jesus is Lord of nations and not only of hearts, that a faith which asks for nothing from the common life has quietly agreed to be a hobby. The nationalist is right that the world belongs to God. He is right that a privatized Christianity, a Christianity content to be one leisure option among many, has already surrendered something it had no business surrendering. The instinct that the faith has public weight is a true instinct. Hold onto that, because I am going to grant it and then show you what the answer does with it.

Because it takes a true instinct and hands it to Caesar. Name the thing at the root, plainly, because the root is rotten even where the grief is real and even where the instinct is sound. The take-it-back answer believes that the kingdom of God can be advanced by the sword of the state, and the moment it believes that, it has lost the ability to tell the two cities apart. Augustine saw the two

cities and spent thirteen years, from 413 to 426, teaching the church to keep them separate, the earthly city built by love of self reaching all the way to contempt of God, the heavenly city built by love of God reaching all the way to contempt of self. The take-it-back answer collapses them. It mistakes the nation for the kingdom, baptizes a tribe, and produces a Christianity finally indistinguishable from a voting bloc with a worship band. And you can win with that. You can win an election, win a court, win a whole political season with that. And you can lose the only thing the church was ever sent to keep.

Look at what Jesus actually did with the offer of the lever, because he was offered it, in plain terms, twice. In the desert the devil showed him all the kingdoms of the world in a moment of time and said, to you I will give all this authority and their glory, for it has been delivered to me, and I give it to whom I will. If you, then, will worship me, it will all be yours. That is the take-it-back offer in its purest form. Real authority, real power over the actual kingdoms of the actual world, offered for the price of one act of worship. And Jesus said, it is written, you shall worship the Lord your God, and him only shall you serve. He did not say the kingdoms did not matter. He said the price was the one price he would not pay. And at the very end, in the garden, when Peter drew a sword and took off a man's ear trying to hold the arrangement together by force, Jesus said, put your sword back into its place, for all who take the sword will perish by the sword. Do you not think that I could appeal to my Father, and he would at once send me more than twelve legions of angels. He had the lever. He had a bigger lever than any nationalist has ever dreamed of. And he set it down, and let them take him, because the kingdom he came to bring does not come the way the kingdoms of the world come, and he knew that the moment it did, it would stop being his kingdom and start being theirs.

The take-it-back answer wants a Christ with a sword. But the only sword Jesus ever touched, he told Peter to put away, and the only crown he ever wore, they made out of thorns. A church that reaches for Caesar's power has already refused its King's cross.

There is a specific poison in this answer that the other two do not carry, and I have to be honest about it, because it is the most dangerous of the three in a certain kind of season. When the church fuses itself to political power, it does not only fail to advance the kingdom. It slanders it. It makes the name of Christ a party badge, and it teaches a whole watching generation that to become a Christian is to join a side in a war they want no part of. The skeptic I most want to reach, the one this whole book is written toward, is not repelled first by the resurrection or the virgin birth. He is repelled by a cross wrapped in a flag, by a Jesus he has only ever seen used as a cudgel, and he has concluded, not unreasonably from the evidence in front of him, that Christianity is a power play with a religious accent. The take-it-back answer builds that wall between him and the gospel, brick by brick, in the name of defending the gospel. It is the flesh doing the devil's demolition and calling it construction.

The second answer: give it up

The second answer is the opposite reach, and it comes from the other kind of grief, the grief not of the man who lost his country but of the man who is ashamed of it. If the culture has moved on, this answer says, then the task of the faithful is to catch up, to quietly file down every edge of the faith the age finds offensive, to keep the architecture and the music and the warm feeling and let the hard substance go. This is the impulse behind the slow accommodation of the progressive church, the steady trade of the difficult sayings of Jesus for the settled opinions of the educated

class. Where the first answer wants to conquer Babylon, this one wants to move into Babylon and change its name to home.

I want to steelman this one too, and I find it easier to steelman than the first, which should make me suspicious of myself, because I am formed by the same educated class whose approval this answer craves, and the temptations that flatter us are always the ones we defend most gently. So let me be careful. The give-it-up answer almost always presents itself as compassion, and sometimes it sincerely is. It is a desire to remove needless offense, to stop defending things that were never worth defending, to love the people the church has wounded and to stop wounding them. Those instincts are not all wrong. Some of what the accommodationist wants to let go of, the church genuinely should have let go of long ago, the cruelties we baptized, the cultural prejudices we mistook for doctrine, the times we made the gospel carry the weight of our comfort and called our comfort holiness. There is a real repentance hidden inside this answer, a real recognition that the church has too often been on the side of the powerful against the wounded, and that recognition is not the enemy of the gospel. It is closer to the gospel than the smugness that dismisses it. Paul himself said he became all things to all people, that by all means he might save some. There is a true instinct here, the instinct that the offense of the cross should be the only offense, that we should clear away every needless stumbling block so that the one necessary stumbling block, the crucified God, stands alone in the road. Grant that. It is true. And then watch what the answer does with it.

Because it does not stop at clearing away the needless offense. It clears away the necessary one too. Name the root here, and name it as plainly as the first. The give-it-up answer believes that the

church survives by agreeing with the world, and a church that agrees with the world about everything has nothing left to say to it and no reason to exist. Paul became all things to all people that he might save some. He did not become all things to all people that he might be liked by some. The whole sentence bends toward salvation, toward the moment of witness, toward the offense of the cross finally landing. Accommodation keeps the flexibility and drops the point. It becomes all things to all people so that it might be applauded by all people, and it will be applauded, all the way to its own empty buildings, because the world has never needed a slightly more spiritual version of what it already believes.

The numbers are merciless here and it does no one any favors to hide them. The churches that have most fully embraced the give-it-up answer, that have most thoroughly conformed themselves to the going consensus, are not growing. They are the ones dying fastest, emptying out generation over generation, closing and merging and selling their buildings to developers. This is not a taunt. It is a diagnosis, and it is a diagnosis the accommodationist should be able to accept on his own terms, because his whole premise is that relevance is survival. If relevance were survival, these would be the fullest churches in the country. They are the emptiest. A faith that exists only to bless the going consensus dies the moment the consensus no longer needs its blessing, and the consensus never needed it in the first place. The world can generate its own affirmation. It has an entire economy dedicated to affirming it. What it cannot generate, and what it is quietly starving for, is a word from outside itself, and the church that has agreed to say nothing the world was not already saying has nothing the world was not already dying of.

Jesus was blunt about this in a way we have sanded down. You are the salt of the earth, he said, but if salt has lost its taste, how shall its saltiness be restored. It is no longer good for anything except to be thrown out and trampled under people's feet. Salt that has become indistinguishable from the dish is not being gracious. It is being useless, and worse than useless, because it has forgotten the one thing it was for. The give-it-up answer is salt working very hard to lose its taste, out of a sincere and misguided conviction that saltiness is what is keeping people away from the table, when saltiness is the only thing it ever had to offer them.

The third answer: wall it off

The third answer is the quietest and the most pious-sounding, and for that reason it is the one that fools serious Christians most easily, the ones who have already seen through the other two. If the culture is lost, this answer says, then the task of the faithful is to retreat, to pull back behind the walls, to build a parallel everything and wait out the long darkness in a fortified enclave, protecting the children and the doctrine from a world gone wrong. It is the bunker. And I want to steelman it hardest of all, because it is the answer with the most real wisdom mixed into it, more than the other two combined, and the reader who has followed me this far is the reader most likely to be quietly building a bunker of his own and calling it discipleship.

Steelman it, then, and steelman it generously. The withdrawal answer takes formation seriously, and it is right to. It knows, where the accommodationist has forgotten, that the culture is not neutral, that it is catechizing us and our children all day long through a thousand small liturgies, the scroll and the screen and the store, and that a faith which does not actively resist that formation will simply be dissolved by it. It is right that we are

creatures of habit before we are creatures of argument, that we are formed by what we do over and over far more than by what we say we believe, and that a church which only preaches at people on Sunday while the world disciplines them the other six days has already lost the contest it does not know it is in. It is right that thick community is not optional, that the faith has always been carried by communities dense enough to hold a different way of life, that you cannot form a saint in isolation any more than you can raise a child in an empty room. And it can point to the whole history of the church for proof. When the Roman order fell apart, it was not the people who tried to prop up the dying empire who saved the moral and spiritual life of the West. It was the monasteries, the deep little communities that Benedict and those like him built, the ones that copied the Scriptures by hand through the long dark and carried the faith across centuries no one could see the end of. The philosopher Alasdair MacIntyre ended a famous book in 1981 by saying we are waiting for another, doubtless very different, Benedict, and he was right, and the withdrawal answer heard him, and some version of strategic withdrawal is genuinely part of faithfulness, as every monastery in history would attest. Grant all of it. It is the strongest of the three cases, and most of it is simply true.

And then watch it become its own betrayal at the exact point where it is pushed past wisdom into fear. Because the monastery MacIntyre pointed to was never a bunker. The Benedictine communities did not wall themselves off from the world to survive the world. They kept the door open. The Rule of Benedict, written around the year 530, commands that every guest who arrives be received as Christ himself, that the poor and the pilgrim be welcomed with particular care, and those monasteries became, across the dark centuries, the hospitals and the schools and the libraries and the guest houses of a shattered

civilization, the places the surrounding world came to for healing and learning and bread. They were fortresses of formation with the gates open, and the openness was the point. The bunker keeps the formation and shuts the gate. And in shutting the gate it abandons the one command that stands at the dead center of Jeremiah's whole letter, the command that this entire book is an attempt to obey. The withdrawal answer seeks the welfare of the church and lets the city fend for itself. It builds the wall and calls it discipleship, and it forgets that the exiles were sent into Babylon on purpose, for Babylon's sake, and were never given permission to wall themselves off from the city they were commanded to bless.

Name this root too, because it is the subtlest of the three and the easiest to miss under the piety. The withdrawal answer believes that the faith is fragile, that it must be protected from contact, that exposure to a hostile world is a threat the church cannot survive. And that belief is a slander against the God who sent his people into the world in the first place. Jesus prayed for his disciples on the last night of his life, and he did not pray what the bunker wants him to have prayed. I do not ask that you take them out of the world, he said to his Father, but that you keep them from the evil one. They are not of the world, just as I am not of the world. As you sent me into the world, so I have sent them into the world. Not of the world, and sent into it, in the same breath, held together by the same prayer. The bunker keeps the first half and throws away the second. It hears not of the world and builds a wall. It never hears sent into the world at all. And a church that is not of the world but also not sent into it is not the church Jesus prayed for. It is something else, something safer and smaller and finally disobedient, a lamp that has decided the safest thing to do with its light is to put it under a basket where the wind cannot reach it. No one, Jesus said, after they have lit a

lamp, puts it under a basket, but on a stand, and it gives light to all in the house. The bunker is a basket. A holy basket, a well-intentioned basket, a basket built out of real love for the children inside it. But a basket over a lamp is a lamp that has forgotten what it is for.

The one fear underneath all three

Now look at what the three answers share, because it is the most important thing in this chapter and it is the thing none of them can see about themselves. Set them side by side. The first reaches for power. The second reaches for approval. The third reaches for the wall. They look like opposites. The nationalist and the accommodationist despise each other, and both of them find the withdrawer naive, and the withdrawer thinks both of them have already lost their souls to the culture in opposite directions. They form the three warring factions of the American church, and each is certain the other two are the whole problem. And underneath the war, driving every one of them, hidden beneath the bluster and the compassion and the piety, is a single fear, one fear wearing three costumes, and the fear is this: that the faith cannot survive without the culture's backing.

The nationalist cannot imagine a faithful church that is not also a powerful one, so he reaches for power. The accommodationist cannot imagine a faithful church the culture despises, so he reaches for approval. The withdrawer cannot imagine a faithful church exposed to a hostile world, so he reaches for the wall. Three different reaches. One identical terror. All three have looked at the drained water, the lost arrangement, the country that has moved on, and all three have concluded the same thing, which is that the church cannot live without it. The nationalist wants to flood the room again. The accommodationist wants to dissolve into whatever fluid the room is filled with now. The

withdrawer wants to seal off a chamber where a little of the old water might be kept. But all three agree, in the one place they would never admit to agreeing, that a church without the water is a church that dies. And that is the lie. That is the single lie underneath all three answers, and it is a lie the church has the means to expose, because it has already been disproven once, decisively, in the only laboratory that matters, which is history.

The first three hundred years are the disproof. The church that grew fastest in the whole span of its existence was the church that had none of the three things the three answers are reaching for. It had no power. It was illegal, slandered, periodically hunted, its members meeting in homes and burying their dead in tunnels, with no lever anywhere in reach. It had no approval. It was the object of the culture's contempt, accused of atheism for refusing the gods and of cannibalism for the Supper and of incest for calling each other brother and sister, held in exactly the low regard the accommodationist is desperate to escape. And it had no wall. It did not withdraw. It poured itself into the plague-struck cities the pagans were fleeing, nursed the sick who were not its own, gathered the infants left exposed on the hillsides to die, and sat slave and master at one table in a world that could not imagine it. No power, no approval, no wall. And the sociologist Rodney Stark ran the arithmetic and found it growing at something near forty percent a decade, sustained for three centuries, until a persecuted minority of a few thousand had become half an empire. It did not merely survive without the three things the three answers crave. It came alive without them. It has always come alive without them. The three answers are all, every one of them, solutions to a problem the early church proves does not exist.

Fight the city, flee the city, or wall yourself off from the

city. The three answers look like enemies and are secretly the same, because all three are afraid the faith cannot survive without the power it just lost. The first three centuries are the proof that it can, and that it does, and that it always has.

So the three answers are not three positions to be weighed and balanced, a little power and a little accommodation and a little withdrawal blended into a moderate whole. They are three forms of a single unbelief. They are three ways of not trusting that Jesus meant it when he said the gates of hell would not prevail against his church, three ways of quietly assuming that he needs our help, our power or our relevance or our fortifications, to keep the promise he made. And he made that promise, we should remember exactly who he made it to, in a pagan district in the shadow of a rock face carved full of the shrines of other gods, to a dozen frightened men with no buildings and no budget and no cultural standing of any kind. He did not attach the promise to their dominance, because they had none. He did not attach it to their respectability, because they had none of that either. He did not attach it to any wall. He attached it to himself, and to the strange deathless thing he was starting, and that thing has now outlived every single empire that ever presided over its funeral, and it will outlive this one, and it does not need us to save it. It needs us to trust it. Which is the one thing all three answers refuse to do.

I said at the start that I have felt all three, and I have, and I will not end by pretending I have been cured of them, because that would be its own kind of lie and this book has too much of the lie to correct already. On the days the news is bad I still feel the old country pulling, still catch myself wanting the lever, still notice the part of me that would trade the offense of the cross for

a seat at the reasonable table, still feel the wall going up around my own house when I look at my sons and the world they are inheriting. The wants do not leave. What changes, if anything changes, is what you do with them, whether you let them run the church or whether you name them as the flesh they are and set them down, the way Jesus set down the sword and the kingdoms and the twelve legions, and pick up instead the harder and older thing that the three answers were all invented to avoid.

Because there was a fourth answer. The exiles in Babylon were not offered the three. They were handed something harder than all of them, something that took the true instinct buried in each and refused the fear that had twisted it, a way to hold the public weight of the faith without the sword, to love the world without dissolving into it, to be formed as a distinct people without sealing the gate. God did not tell them to conquer Babylon and he did not tell them to become Babylon and he did not tell them to hide from Babylon. He told them a fourth thing, in a letter, in words so plain and so strange that the church has spent twenty-five centuries reading past them. And it is that letter, the actual letter, the one Jeremiah actually sat down and wrote and sent a thousand miles east to a grieving people who wanted anything but what it said, that we have to open now, and read the way it was written, before we can learn to live.

Chapter 6: The Letter to the Exiles

The first part of this book was diagnosis, and diagnosis is the part that flatters us, because it asks nothing. It tells us what happened. The water drained, the scaffolding came down, the country moved on, and we are exiles now in a land that no longer remembers us. All of that is true, and none of it tells you how to get out of bed on a Tuesday and be a Christian in the world that actually remains. A man who knows only that he is in exile knows only that he is lost. What the exile needs is not a sharper account of his loss. He needs a letter.

There was such a letter. It was written by a prophet named Jeremiah, from the wreckage of Jerusalem, to a group of people who had just watched their entire world end, and it was carried a thousand miles east by the hand of two royal envoys traveling to the court of the king who had destroyed them. We know their names. Elasah the son of Shaphan and Gemariah the son of Hilkiah, sent by Zedekiah, the puppet king Babylon had left on the throne to keep the peace. The letter went in the diplomatic pouch, tucked among the tribute and the correspondence of a defeated vassal, and it reached the exiles who were already in Babylon, the first wave, deported in 597 before Christ, the king and the craftsmen and the soldiers and the leading families, sitting in a foreign empire and waiting to go home. It is the single most important piece of mail in the history of the people of God, and it is the reason for the rest of this book, and most of us have read only one verse of it.

I want to give you the whole thing. Not the verse on the mug. The letter.

Begin with what it was answering, because a letter is a reply, and this one was written into a specific and unbearable situation. The people in Babylon were not settling in. They were grieving, and their grief had a shape, and the shape was the fixed and burning conviction that they would soon go home. This was not idle hope. It was being preached to them, in the name of the Lord, by men who held the office of prophet and spoke with the full confidence of faith. Jeremiah names them in the letter itself. Ahab and Zedekiah and a man named Shemaiah, prophesying to the captives a swift and glorious return, telling them the exile was a brief humiliation that God was about to reverse. And behind them all, back in Jerusalem, stood the most famous of them, the one whose confrontation with Jeremiah the whole letter is answering. His name was Hananiah, and to understand the letter you have to first stand in the temple and watch the two prophets face each other, because everything the letter forbids and everything it commands is a reply to what Hananiah said.

The scene is in the chapter just before the letter, and it is one of the most quietly devastating passages in all the prophets. Jeremiah had been walking around Jerusalem for months wearing a wooden yoke on his neck, an ox yoke, straps and bars of wood, a piece of ritual theater God had told him to perform, a walking sermon that said one thing. Submit. Put your neck under Babylon and live. And Hananiah, in the temple, in front of the priests and all the people, stood up and prophesied the opposite. Thus says the Lord of hosts, the God of Israel: I have broken the yoke of the king of Babylon. Within two years I will bring back to this place all the vessels of the Lord's house, and I will bring back to this place the exiled king and all the exiles. Two years. The temple treasures restored. The king home. The whole nightmare reversed inside twenty-four months, guaranteed in the name of the Lord of hosts, radiant with hope and faith and

patriotism, everything the grieving nation ached to hear.

And then Hananiah did something theatrical. He took the wooden yoke off Jeremiah's neck and broke it. He snapped it in front of everyone, a piece of prophetic performance to match Jeremiah's own, and he said it again. Thus says the Lord: even so will I break the yoke of Nebuchadnezzar from the neck of all the nations within two years.

Watch what Jeremiah does, because it is not what a fanatic does, and it is the first thing the letter teaches. He does not shout Hananiah down. He does not call him a liar to his face in that moment. What he says, standing there with his yoke in pieces on the temple floor, is one of the most poignant sentences a true prophet ever spoke to a false one. Amen. May the Lord do so. May the Lord make the words that you have prophesied come true. He means it. Nothing would make Jeremiah happier than for Hananiah to be right, for the yoke to be broken, for the vessels and the king and the people to come streaming home in two years. Jeremiah is not the man who enjoys the hard word. He is the man crushed by having to say it. And then, having agreed with everything Hananiah's hope wanted, he says the thing that separates the true prophet from the false one across every age. He says the prophets who came before us prophesied war and famine and pestilence, and the prophet who prophesies peace will be known as a true prophet only when his word comes true. The burden of proof is on the one selling comfort. And then, later, God gives Jeremiah the word to finish it. You have broken wooden bars, he tells Hananiah, but you have made in their place bars of iron. The comfort you are peddling does not lighten the yoke. It doubles it. And you have made this people trust in a lie. Hananiah the prophet died that same year, in the seventh month, exactly as Jeremiah said he would.

That is the confrontation the letter answers, and now you can hear the letter for what it is. It is Jeremiah's reply to Hananiah, carried to the very people Hananiah was lying to, and it is built to take away, gently and permanently, the one hope they were clinging to.

The false prophet is always the one who tells you it will be short. He does not lighten the yoke. He changes it from wood to iron and calls that mercy.

So the letter opens. These are the words of the letter that Jeremiah the prophet sent from Jerusalem to the surviving elders of the exiles, and to the priests, the prophets, and all the people, whom Nebuchadnezzar had taken into exile from Jerusalem to Babylon. Notice the first thing it says about who sent the exiles there, because it is the hinge of everything that follows and it is easy to miss. Thus says the Lord of hosts, the God of Israel, to all the exiles whom I have sent into exile from Jerusalem to Babylon. Whom I have sent. Not whom Nebuchadnezzar dragged. Not whom Babylon stole. Whom I sent. In a single clause God claims the whole catastrophe. The empire that burned the temple was, without ceasing to be guilty, the instrument of a God who was doing something on purpose. The exiles were not the victims of history who had slipped out from under their God's protection. They were deported by the sovereign hand of the God who was still, even here, especially here, their God. That is the ground the whole letter stands on. You are not lost. You are sent.

And then, having claimed the sending, the letter tells them what to do inside it, and the commands are so ordinary and so shocking that the shock can slip right past a reader who has heard them at weddings. Build houses and live in them. Plant

gardens and eat their produce. Take wives and have sons and daughters, take wives for your sons and give your daughters in marriage, that they may bear sons and daughters, multiply there, and do not decrease. Six imperatives, plain as bread, handed to a people who wanted a seventh, the one they were praying for, the command to pack. And the command to pack never comes. Build. Plant. Marry. Multiply. Every one of those verbs is a stake driven into Babylonian ground. You do not build a house you plan to leave by spring. You do not plant a garden, and least of all an orchard, in soil you expect to abandon. You do not marry your daughter into an exile you believe is nearly over. Each command is a small permanence, and permanence was the one thing the grieving heart could not bear, because permanence meant Hananiah was wrong and the seventy years were real.

I have to be honest about how much this offends the natural piety of a suffering people, because I feel the offense myself and I suspect you will too. The devout instinct of the exile is to hold Babylon at arm's length. To sit loosely on the land. To keep the bags by the door and the heart fixed on home, because surely a faithful person does not sink roots into the empire that murdered his nation. Surely the holy posture is the provisional one, the refusal to be at home in a place under judgment. And God says no. He tells them to do the thing that feels like surrender, to commit, to put their weight down, to stop living on the balls of their feet ready to run the moment the door opens, and to accept that this Babylon, this pagan and hostile and idolatrous city, is where their one life is going to be lived. The letter takes the fantasy of the quick return and replaces it with a shovel. Not a ticket home. A shovel.

But the commands to build and plant and marry are the setup. They clear the ground. They make the exile stop waiting and

start living. And then, at the center of the letter, comes the sentence the whole thing was built to deliver, the command that should stop the heart of anyone who has ever felt his country slipping out from under him. But seek the welfare of the city where I have sent you into exile, and pray to the Lord on its behalf, for in its welfare you will find your welfare.

Seek the welfare of Babylon. Pray for the prosperity of the empire that burned the temple, that broke the walls, that killed the sons of the king in front of him and then put out his eyes so that the slaughter of his children would be the last thing he ever saw. Seek the good of that. Want it to thrive. Pray, by name, for the flourishing of the city that did that to you. There is no command in the Old Testament more scandalous, and we have read it so often on so many mugs that we have sanded the scandal completely off it, and it must be recovered before the letter can do its work. This is not the kind of thing anyone says to a conquered people. It is the exact opposite of what every conquered people in history has ever wanted to hear, which is that their conqueror will burn. And the God of Israel says: bless it.

The word matters, and everything turns on hearing it at full strength. The word translated welfare, both times it appears in that sentence, is the Hebrew shalom. We have shrunk shalom down to a thin and private thing, mere quiet, the absence of conflict, an inner calm. It is nothing so small. Shalom is wholeness, the way a thing is when it is functioning as it was made to function, the full flourishing of a common life. A city has shalom when the hungry are fed and the worker is paid what he is owed and the stranger is safe and the sick are tended and the weak are not ground under the strong and the neighbors know one another's names. To seek the shalom of Babylon is to

seek all of that, for the actual city, for the good of the actual people packed into it, most of whom worshipped gods that were not God. God commands the exiles to become agents of the wholeness of the empire that enslaved them. Not to seek a quiet corner in which to practice their private religion undisturbed. To seek the flourishing of the whole pagan city, and to do it as a people who belonged entirely to someone else.

This is the third thing, and it is the reason the letter is the map for the whole book, because it forbids the two answers the exiles wanted and the two answers we still want. There was a faction in Babylon that wanted to fight, that listened to Hananiah and Ahab and Shemaiah, that believed the yoke would break and the whole arrangement would be cranked back into place, and that faction is still with us, wearing the flag, certain the right movement or the right election is about to reverse the exile and take the country back. God does not tell the exiles to fight. He tells them not to. And there was a quieter faction that wanted to disappear, to stop being Jewish, to let the strangeness dissolve into Babylon until the ache of being different went away, and that faction is still with us too, filing down every hard edge of the faith until it is indistinguishable from the settled opinion of the age. God does not tell the exiles to assimilate either. He commands the third thing that neither faction could imagine. Stay, and be entirely distinct, and pour yourself out for the good of a city you will never control and were never permitted to conquer. Not take Babylon. Not become Babylon. Seek the welfare of Babylon, on behalf of a God it does not know, while bowing to none of its gods.

I dwelt on the three failures earlier in this book, so I will not lay the whole case out again, but I want to name what the letter exposes about all of them at once, because it is the thing none of

the three can see about itself. Every one of them is trying to escape the exile. The fighter escapes it by force, refusing to accept that it is real. The assimilator escapes it by surrender, refusing to remain the kind of person exile makes strange. And the third temptation, the one the letter forbids most sharply of all, is to escape it by withdrawal, to wall yourself off from the city and wait out the dark behind the barricade, to seek the welfare of the church and let Babylon fend for itself. The letter forbids that one by the plainest possible means. It does not tell the exiles to build a wall. It tells them to seek the welfare of the city, and you cannot seek the welfare of a city you have walled out. All three escapes are refusals of the sending. All three say, in the end, that God was wrong to put us here, and we will get ourselves out, by conquest or by camouflage or by retreat. And the letter says: I sent you here. Stay. Seek its shalom.

Then comes the promise that turns the whole command from a demand into a gift, and it is the promise that keeps the seeking from being mere grim altruism. For in its welfare you will find your welfare. In its shalom you will find your shalom. God binds the flourishing of the exiles to the flourishing of the city so tightly that the two cannot be pried apart. This is not a bribe, and it is not selfishness with a halo. It is a statement about how God has actually ordered the world. The people who spend themselves for the good of the place they have been planted will find their own good waiting there, hidden inside the good of the city, and the attempt to secure your own welfare while the city rots is not only disobedient but futile, because your welfare was never a separate thing. Seek the city's good, and you find your own. Hoard your own behind a wall, and you lose both. That single sentence is the whole argument of this book compressed to a seed, and it is the reason the ministry that carries this book carries the name it does. In its welfare you will find your

welfare. Your shalom is spent, not saved. It is found only where it is given away.

And only now, after all of that, does the famous verse arrive, and it must be read in its place or it means the opposite of what it says. For I know the plans I have for you, declares the Lord, plans for welfare and not for evil, to give you a future and a hope. Read it where it actually sits, and feel how much greater it is than the private good-luck charm we cut it down to. It is not a promise that your dreams are about to come true by spring. It is a word spoken to a people God has just told will spend their whole lives in Babylon, and it says: I know. I know it is long. I know most of you will die here. I have not forgotten you, and my plans for you are plans of shalom and not of harm, and there is a future, and there is a hope, at the far end of a captivity longer than your own life. The word translated welfare in that eleventh verse is the same shalom from the seventh. It is the same word. God did that on purpose, so that we could never finally separate the good he plans to give us from the good he commands us to seek for the city. The plans verse is not a footnote we promoted to a headline. It is the reassurance stitched onto the far harder word, and the harder word is the one we have spent twenty-five centuries refusing to read.

Because the letter does not end at the promise. It circles back, deliberately, to Hananiah, to the false prophets still working the crowd in Babylon, and it warns the exiles not to let those prophets and those diviners deceive them, not to listen to the dreams that they dream, for it is a lie that they are prophesying in the Lord's name. The whole letter is bracketed by the confrontation with false comfort. It opens as the answer to Hananiah's two years, and it closes by naming the men still preaching Hananiah's lie in Babylon itself, and in between it

hands the exiles the truth those liars could not stand to say. The truth is not that Babylon will fall next year. The truth is that God is with them in Babylon, that he has plans for them in Babylon, that their whole vocation is to be lived out in Babylon, and that the length of it is not two years.

I feel the weight of that, and I will not pretend I stand above it, because I want the short exile as badly as anyone. I want the water back. I catch the Hananiah in my own chest, the voice that says surely this is temporary, surely the culture will swing back, surely I will live to see the church restored to the center of the country I grew up assuming. That voice is not faith. It is grief looking for a comfortable lie, and I know it because it lives in me. The letter does me the hard mercy of refusing it. It takes the two-year hope out of my hands and gives me, in its place, the harder and better thing, a God who sends his people into exile on purpose, who stays with them through the whole of it, who commands them to build and plant and marry and seek and bless and pray, and who binds their flourishing to the flourishing of a city that is not their home and never will be.

So this is the letter, whole, the way it was actually written. It claims the exile as God's own sending. It commands a defeated people to put down roots and live. It forbids the fight and forbids the surrender and forbids the retreat, and commands the third and stranger thing, to seek the welfare of the city on behalf of a God the city does not know. It binds the exile's good to the city's good so that the two can never be separated. And it brackets the whole command with a warning against the prophets who promise a short exile, because the deepest lie an exile can believe is that he will soon be going home.

Which leaves the one thing the letter says that we have not yet been able to face, the number Hananiah could not stand to name

and Jeremiah would not soften. Two years, Hananiah promised. Two years, and the vessels and the king and the people, all home. Jeremiah answered him with a different number, buried in the letter, spoken over a people who wanted anything but this, and it is the number the whole next chapter has to reckon with, because everything about how an exile lives depends on how long he believes the exile will last. When seventy years are completed for Babylon, God said, I will visit you. Seventy years. A lifetime. And what a man does with the one life he has been given inside that number is the difference between an exile who wastes it waiting and an exile who learns, at last, to live.

Chapter 7: Seventy Years

The cruelest word in the letter is a number, and it is the number the exiles least wanted to hear. When seventy years are completed for Babylon, God says through Jeremiah, I will visit you, and I will fulfill to you my promise and bring you back to this place. Seventy years. Not seventy days. Not the two short years the popular preachers were promising in the temple courts. Seventy years, which in the ancient world was the far outer edge of a human life, the number the psalmist himself would name as the whole allotted span, the days of our years are seventy, or if by reason of strength they be eighty. God does not hand the exiles a delay. He hands them a lifetime. He tells a grieving, disoriented, homesick people that the catastrophe that has just swallowed everything they loved is not a storm to be waited out under an overturned boat but the actual weather of the rest of their days, and their children's days, and that only their grandchildren will walk the road home.

I want to sit in the arithmetic of that before I say anything comforting about it, because the comfort is real and it is earned only on the far side of the arithmetic. A man of forty hearing that letter would be a hundred and ten before the promise came due, which is to say he would never see it. A young mother nursing a child on the banks of the Chebar canal would die in Babylon, and her nursing infant would die in Babylon, gray and old, and the child of that child might, if the years were kind, load a cart and turn it west toward a Jerusalem she had only heard about in the stories her grandmother told. The seventy years is not a comma in Israel's history. It is three generations. It is the whole

working life of everyone who first unrolled the scroll, spent to the last hour on a soil they did not choose, under a sky they did not want, in the service of an empire that had burned the house of their God to the ground.

We do not like this number, and we have inherited every trick the exiles used to get around it. Set it beside what the people were dying to hear, and you feel the pull of the evasion in your own chest. There was a prophet glad to supply the fantasy. His name was Hananiah, and in the chapter just before the letter he stood up in the house of the Lord, in front of the priests and all the people, and prophesied in the name of the same God that within two full years the yoke of the king of Babylon would be broken, the plundered vessels of the temple returned, the exiled king and all the captives brought home. It was everything a broken nation longed for. It had the full outward form of faith, spoken with confidence, radiant with hope and patriotism and the promise of restoration. And it was a lie. Jeremiah's answer is one of the most poignant moments in all the prophets. He said, in effect, amen. May the Lord do so. May the Lord make the words you have prophesied come true. Nothing would please me more than for you to be right. And then, having granted the longing its full dignity, he said it would not happen, that Hananiah had made the people trust in a lie, and that the wooden yoke he had theatrically snapped in the courtyard would be answered by a yoke of iron. Hananiah died that same year, in the seventh month, exactly as Jeremiah said he would. And the people were left with the prophet who would not comfort them with a falsehood, the one who put a shovel in their hands where they had reached for a ticket home.

The false prophet of exile is always the one who tells you it will be short. That is the whole of his method, in every century,

wearing whatever the current fashion happens to be. He is still with us, and he still speaks in the name of the Lord, and he still tells the grieving church precisely what its grief wants to hear. He tells us the exile is a temporary aberration, a bad patch, a swing of the pendulum that is already swinging back. He tells us the right election is about to snap the yoke, or the right revival, or the right movement, or the right coalition, that we are forever on the edge of taking it all back, that the water is about to come rushing back into the room and everything will be as it was. His appeal is not that he is cynical. His appeal is that he is merciful in the cheapest possible way, because he relieves you of the long burden. He lets you stay angry, and hopeful, and waiting, instead of settling down into the slow, unglamorous, load-bearing work of faithfulness in a world that is not going to change back on your schedule. And the true prophet, then and now, is the lonelier man, the one willing to say the harder number, that the cultural home the church held for centuries is not returning in our lifetime or our children's, and that the sooner we make our peace with the seventy years the sooner we can stop scanning the western horizon for a rescue and start planting a future in the dirt beneath our feet.

This is what the number exposes about the whole take-it-back project, the thing the earlier chapters could only point at from a distance. Underneath the anger and the activism and the very real urgency, the demand to restore Christendom by force is, at its root, a refusal to accept the seventy years. It is the insistence on seeing the harvest in our own lifetime. It is the demand to be the generation that wins, to personally stand in the victory, to bring the timeline in under a span short enough that I get to be there for the parade. And that demand, however righteous it feels, has never once in the long history of the people of God produced anything but false prophets and broken people, because you

cannot do multigenerational faithfulness while requiring a one-generation payoff. The two things are built out of opposite materials. The seventy years is God's gentle and devastating refusal of our hurry. It tells us that the work is longer than we are. It tells us we will pour out our whole lives on something we will not see finished, and that this is not the failure of the work. It is the actual shape of the work, among a people whose God has always thought in generations and never in news cycles.

I feel the rebuke of this in a place I do not enjoy having exposed, and I am not going to pretend I stand outside it and lecture you from higher ground. I am a man of my age, formed by its hurry, catechized by its metrics before I ever read a page of Scripture. I want to see the fruit of my work in my own lifetime, and if I am honest, ideally this quarter. I have measured faithfulness by visible results the way the world measures everything, counting the people in the room, the numbers on the screen, the reach, and calling the counting stewardship. The seventy years stands over the whole of that and says, quietly and without heat, that is not how my kingdom keeps time. We did this. I did this. We took the tempo of an impatient civilization and we baptized it, and we called our impatience zeal, and then we wondered why the church we built felt so frantic and so shallow and so perpetually one disappointment away from despair.

Now I have to guard this hard against a misreading, because the prophet of the seventy years is not the prophet of decline, and the two get confused constantly. He is not telling the people it is over. He is telling them it is long. Those are completely different words, and everything hangs on the difference. Decline says the light is going out. Length says the road is farther than you thought. God keeps his people through the seventy years, all the way through, present in Babylon as surely and as fully as he was

ever present in Jerusalem, and the exile turns out to be not the grave of Israel's faith but the forge of it. This is the great irony that the whole rest of the Old Testament rests upon. In the place of their defeat, cut off from the temple and its sacrifices, the people who could not go up to Zion learned to gather in smaller rooms around the reading of the word, and the synagogue was born. Cut off from the priesthood, they became a people of the book, and the Scriptures were gathered and guarded and copied as never before. A faith that had leaned for centuries on a building and a city and a piece of ground was hammered, on the anvil of exile, into something portable and durable, something that could survive anywhere, in any empire, under any hostile sky, because it had learned the hard way that its God was not confined to a single address. The seventy years did not thin Israel out. It made Israel deep. It produced the very thing that could not have been produced in the comfort of the land, a people whose witness would outlast the empire that enslaved them, and every empire after.

But notice, and this is the hinge of the whole chapter, notice which way the hope faces. This is where the church most often goes wrong even when it has correctly refused despair, because there are two things that both feel like hope and only one of them is. The hope of the seventy years is not nostalgia. Nostalgia faces backward. It aches toward the lost country, the old arrangement, the Jerusalem that was, the room in which the water still held everyone up. Nostalgia spends the exile grieving a past that is not coming back, and it dresses the grieving up as faithfulness, and it is one of the most respectable ways there is to waste a life. Biblical hope faces the other direction entirely. It faces forward, toward the thing God is doing next, toward the city he is building, toward a return that is not a reversal but an advance. The exile consumed by nostalgia will spend the seventy years

looking over his shoulder and will taste nothing of the years he actually has. The exile who has biblical hope will spend them building, because he knows the God who sent him here is the same God going on ahead of him, and that the promise lives in the future and not in the past. Lot's wife is the whole warning in a single sentence. She was told to flee forward and not look back at the burning of the old order, and she looked back, and she became a pillar of salt standing on the road, a monument to the death that comes of facing the wrong way. The church that spends the exile grieving Christendom is looking back at the fire. The church that will live is the one that keeps walking.

Charles Taylor, whose great book on the secular age has been sitting under this whole argument, taught us that we cannot simply reason ourselves back into an older world by wanting it. The conditions of belief have changed, he says, and there is no unringing that bell, no route back to the age when faith was the assumed and effortless floor beneath everyone's feet. That sounds at first like the deepest possible discouragement, and every nostalgic instinct in me wants to argue with him. But hear what it actually does. It closes off the exit we keep clawing at, and in closing it, it turns us around to face the only direction hope was ever supposed to face, which is ahead. Taylor is not telling us the light is going out. He is telling us the way back is walled, so that we will finally stop throwing ourselves against the wall and turn toward the country we are actually being led into. Lesslie Newbigin, who came home from forty years as a missionary in India to find that his own Britain had become a harder mission field than the one he had left, understood the same thing from inside the ache of it. He did not spend his old age trying to resurrect the Christian England of his boyhood. He asked, instead, how the gospel could be made fresh and credible to a people who had heard it and moved past it, which is a

forward question, a question about what God is doing next among a post-Christian people, and not a backward question about how to reassemble what had fallen. That reorientation, from the lost past to the given future, is the whole difference between an exile who withers and an exile who plants.

And the faithful, when they have gotten this right, have always known how to plant what they will not harvest. There is no posture more foreign to a modern person, and none more necessary to recover, so I want to give it faces and not leave it an abstraction. Go and look at the monasteries in the long centuries after Rome fell, in the cold and the dark of what we used to call, with some arrogance, the dark ages. Picture the monk in the scriptorium at Lindisfarne or at Iona or at Monte Cassino, bent over a page in the failing light of a northern winter, copying the Scriptures by hand, letter by letter, line by line, the ink freezing, the fingers cramping, the eyes failing decades before their time. He is copying a book he did not write, in a world that is falling apart around him, for readers who have not yet been born and whom he will never meet. He does not copy because he can see the harvest. He cannot see it. The civilization his patience will one day seed is centuries past his own death, and he knows it. He copies because the word is true, and because the work is his to do, and because the seeing is God's business and not his. Alasdair MacIntyre, ending his great and troubling book in 1981, looked at those communities and drew from them the lesson the church has been chewing on ever since. What preserved the moral and spiritual life of Europe through the collapse of the old order, he said, was not the men who tried to shore up the dying empire. It was the men who quietly built new communities where a way of life could be sustained through the long darkness. We are waiting, he wrote, for another, doubtless very different, Benedict. He meant that we had better stop trying to

hold the empire up and start doing the patient, unglamorous, generational work of building things that will outlast us.

Or lift your eyes from the scriptorium to the cathedrals, because they teach the same lesson in stone. The men who laid the foundations of Chartres, of Cologne, of the great cathedral at Milan that took nearly six centuries to finish, the masons who quarried and dressed and set the first courses of stone, knew a mathematical certainty about their work. They knew they would be dead, and their sons would be dead, long before the spire rose, long before the last vault was closed, long before the finished building they were beginning would ever shelter a single worshipper. They would never once pray inside the thing their hands had started. And they built it anyway, cut every stone true anyway, gave their working lives to a glory reserved for faces they would never see, content to be one faithful link in a chain whose completion belonged to God and to generations unborn. That is gardening on the scale of centuries. That is exactly the posture the seventy years requires, the willingness to plant orchards whose shade will fall on strangers, to labor for a harvest that is not yours to gather, to build the cathedral you will not worship in and copy the book you will not see read.

Eugene Peterson gave this the name that has stuck to it, and it belongs here more than anywhere. He borrowed a phrase, by a strange route through Nietzsche of all people, and called the whole shape of discipleship a long obedience in the same direction. He wrote it against what he named an instant society, a culture of immediacy that has trained us to expect everything now and to abandon anything that does not pay off quickly, and he argued that following Christ is constitutionally the opposite of that. Not a burst. Not a campaign. Not a launch with a metric that has to move by the end of the quarter. A slow walk in a single

direction, sustained across a whole life, most of it uphill, most of it unphotographed, most of it in weather. The instant society has now thoroughly colonized the church, and we barely notice, because it is the water we swim in. We want revival by next year. We want a recovered culture by the next election. We want our own sanctification on a visible, reportable schedule. And so we plant nothing slow, because nothing slow shows up in the numbers, and we abandon the ground the moment it fails to produce, and then we stand around bewildered that the faith we are handing our children feels so thin and so anxious and so easily blown over. A garden cannot be hurried and cannot be faked and cannot be measured at the speed we measure everything else. A people that has forgotten how to do anything slowly has forgotten how to do the one thing the exile most requires.

The demand to win in our own lifetime is the root of every fast and ruinous answer the church keeps reaching for. It is not zeal. It is the refusal of the seventy years.

I want to steelman the objection, because it is a serious one and it deserves better than a brush of the hand, and I have felt its force. Someone will say, this counsel of patience is exactly how the church loses. This is quietism dressed up as wisdom. This is how you comfort people into surrender while the culture is remade around them and their grandchildren are catechized by other gods. If we plant slowly and wait on generations, the objection runs, we will be plowed under before the seed ever sprouts, and the long obedience will turn out to be a long capitulation, and the ones telling us to be patient will be the ones who lacked the courage to fight. I hear it. There is a real fear underneath it and the fear is not foolish. But look hard at what the seventy years actually asks, because it is not what the

objection thinks it is. It does not ask for passivity. It asks for endurance, which is the opposite. The monk copying in the dark was not surrendering. He was resisting, at a depth and on a timescale the barbarian could not reach, and the empire fell and his little sentence of faithful ink did not. Daniel serving in the court of Babylon for a lifetime was not quiet and was not passive. He was faithful in plain sight for seventy years and outlasted the kings who threatened him. The seventy years is not the counsel of the coward. It is the counsel that refuses the coward's shortcut, which is the demand for a fast win, because the fast win is the very thing that keeps producing false prophets and burnt-out believers and a church that spends its strength on a rescue that is not coming and has nothing left for the life it actually has. Patience of this kind is not the absence of struggle. It is struggle that has made its peace with not seeing the end, which is the only struggle that has ever actually held.

And this is finally where the famous verse belongs, the one on the coffee mug and the graduation card and the framed print in the foyer, restored at last to the sentence it was cut out of. For I know the plans I have for you, declares the Lord, plans for welfare and not for evil, to give you a future and a hope. We took that line and we made it the most personal promise in the Bible, a private guarantee that my particular dreams are on their way, that my future is bright, that God is arranging good things for me specifically and soon. We did that, every one of us who has ever leaned on it that way, by an act of quiet surgery, cutting the verse free of the four verses before it and the terrible number they contain. Read it now in its actual place, as the comfort strapped to the seventy-year sentence, and feel how much stronger and how much stranger it becomes. God is not saying your wishes will come true by spring. He is saying something to a people he has just told will spend their entire lives in exile. He is saying, I

know. I know it is long. I know most of you will not see the end of it. I know I have asked you to build houses you will die in and plant gardens whose fruit will feed your grandchildren and not you. And I have not forgotten you. My plans for you are plans of shalom and not of harm. There is a future, and there is a hope, on the far side of a darkness longer than your own life, for a people willing to settle in and trust me through the whole of it. That is not a good-luck charm. It is the promise of a God who does not evacuate his people out of the long dark but goes down into it with them and keeps them, all the way through, and brings them, in the end, home.

The word in that promise, the same Hebrew word that runs through the whole letter, is shalom, and it will not let itself be shrunk to the thin thing we usually make of it. It is not mere quiet, not the absence of trouble, not a private inner calm. It is wholeness, the way things are meant to be when they are finally right, a whole city at peace. And God attaches that word, that enormous word, not to a quick deliverance but to a long faithfulness. The plans of shalom are the plans of a God who is playing a longer game than the false prophet can stand to name, weaving a good out of the very exile the people wanted only to escape, working across three generations toward a wholeness that no two-year rescue could ever have produced. To believe that verse in its real setting is not to believe that God will make your life comfortable soon. It is to believe that God is good over a span of time longer than your ability to see, and that faithfulness inside that span, even faithfulness that dies with the promise still unfulfilled in your hands, is not wasted, because the God who keeps time in generations forgets none of it.

So the question the letter puts to us, before it ever tells us to build or plant or marry or seek or pray, is whether we can bear

the seventy years at all. That is the prior question, and everything else waits on the answer. Can we give our lives to a recovery we will not live to see, and call that faithfulness instead of failure. Can we be a link in a chain and be content not to be the clasp. The exiles who could bear the number became Daniel in the king's court and Esther in the palace and a people whose portable, durable faith outlasted Babylon and Persia and Greece and Rome and is being read from this morning in ten thousand rooms while the empires that despised it are dust in museums. The exiles who could not bear it spent their one life waiting for a homecoming that arrived, when it finally came, too late for them, and they missed the whole strange gift of the years they actually had, grieving forward toward a Jerusalem their eyes would never see and blind to the Babylon their feet were standing in. The number is seventy. That part is not up to us. The only thing up to us is what we will do with the single life we have been given inside it.

I said I would not lecture you from higher ground, and I meant it, so let me end where the rebuke lands on me. I do not naturally have the patience this chapter is about. I want the harvest, and I want to be there for it, and I have to be re-formed, season after season, into a man who can plant what he will not taste and count it joy. But I have come to believe that this re-formation is not a diminishment of hope. It is the purification of it. The hope that could only survive if I got to see the payoff was never really hope in God at all. It was hope in my own timeline wearing God's clothes. The hope that can plant an orchard, kiss the seed into the Babylonian dirt, and walk away knowing another set of hands will do the gathering, that hope is aimed at God himself and not at my need to witness the result, and it is the only hope that will still be standing when the sun comes up on the drought. We are early in something long. We are the first exiles, unrolling

a letter that names a number we do not like, and the whole of our faithfulness turns on whether we can hear that number and grieve it and then reach, anyway, for the tools the letter puts in our hands.

Because the letter does not stop at the number. It never does. Having taken away the fantasy of the quick rescue, having told the people the exile will fill their whole lives, the letter turns, in the very next breath, to verbs. It refuses to leave us in the paralysis of knowing only that the road is long. It moves immediately into the imperative mood, into the unglamorous and load-bearing business of how an exile actually builds a life on ground he did not choose. And the first of those verbs is the most ordinary and the most audacious of all, so ordinary that its sheer defiance can slip right past you. To a people straining west toward the first sign of home, sitting loosely on the land because surely, surely this is temporary, God says the one thing they cannot bear to hear and the one thing that will save them. Build houses. Build the kind of thing a man builds only when he has decided, in his bones, that he is staying. Put down foundations. Put down your weight. And live.

Chapter 8: Build Houses

When God finally tells the exiles what to do, the very first command is so ordinary that its sheer audacity can slip right past you. Build houses and live in them. Not pitch tents. Not throw up something temporary that can be struck and folded and loaded on a cart the moment the call to march home finally comes. Houses. With foundations, and load-bearing walls, and a roof that has to be pitched to shed the rain of many winters, the kind of thing a man builds only when he has decided, in his bones, that he is staying. To a people straining west toward the horizon for the first sign of rescue, sitting loosely on the land because surely this is temporary, surely we will not be here long, the God who sent them there says the one thing their grief could not bear to hear. Stay. You live here now. Build something you cannot carry with you when you go, because you are not going, not for a very long time, and the sooner your hands admit it the sooner your soul can follow.

We hurry past this command because it sounds like the easy one, the throat-clearing before the letter says something spiritual. It is the opposite. It is the hardest word in the whole letter, harder even than the seventy years, because the seventy years is a fact you can grieve from a distance and the house is a decision you have to make with your hands, in a particular place, this week. The number tells you how long. The house tells you where, and it tells you now, and it will not let you keep your options open. A number can be absorbed and set on a shelf. A house has to be built or not built, and either way your body has answered the prophet before your heart has caught up.

Consider what a built house actually is, before it is a shelter, because it is a confession first. A house says I am staying. It says I am exposed, I have decided that this particular patch of a pagan empire is worth the labor and the lumber and the risk of permanence. You cannot un-build a house quickly. You cannot slip out of a foundation the way you slip out of a tent. To lay a foundation in Babylonian ground is to put down a marker that your enemies can see and your children can inherit, a public and irreversible bet that you will be here when the mortar cures and here when the roof needs mending and here, most likely, when they lower you into the same ground you built on. The tent-dweller keeps faith with the road. The house-builder keeps faith with the place. And God, to a people who wanted nothing on earth so much as the road home, commanded the house.

Permanence, it turns out, is the precondition of every other thing the letter goes on to ask. This is the structural fact that organizes the whole middle of Jeremiah's instruction, and it is worth seeing plainly before we go any further, because if you miss it you will misread everything that follows. You cannot seek the welfare of a city you are about to abandon. You cannot love a neighbor you have walled out or written off as a temporary inconvenience. You cannot plant a garden, which we will come to, in ground you expect to leave by spring, and you cannot raise children into a place, or pray with any real weight for a place, that you are holding at arm's length, your weight on your back foot, your bags by the door, ready to leave the instant the door opens. Every command that comes after this one grows out of the soil of this one. Build houses is not the first item on a list of six equal things. It is the ground the other five are planted in. It is the command to put your weight down.

I want to be exact about what putting your weight down means,

because it is a spiritual posture before it is a matter of real estate, and the two get confused. It does not mean you will never move again. It does not mean God has chained you to a zip code. It means the end of living provisionally. It means the death of the reservation, the quiet withholding by which a person can be physically present in a place for years and never actually arrive there, never fully commit, always keeping one eye on the exit and one portion of the heart in reserve for the better place that is surely coming next. The exile who lives that way has technically relocated to Babylon and has never once lived there. His body is in the empire and his life is in a country that no longer exists. And God, with four plain words, forbids it. Build houses and live in them. Be here. All the way here. On purpose.

There are exactly two ways to refuse this command, and the modern American church has perfected both of them, and I have practiced both of them, so let me describe them from the inside rather than from above.

The first refusal is the suitcase. The suitcase Christian keeps his bags packed by the door, and he has a verse for it, and the verse is even true. This world is not my home, I am only passing through. The apostle Paul really did say our citizenship is in heaven, and the writer of Hebrews really did say these all died in faith, having acknowledged that they were strangers and exiles on the earth, and I believe every word of it and I will defend it against anyone who wants to make Christians too comfortable in the country they live in. But the suitcase Christian takes a true thing and puts it to a false use. He means it as piety and it functions as an excuse. Why should I pour myself into the schools of a city under judgment. Why invest in the civic life or the long slow repair of a place I am leaving anyway. Why sink roots into ground I do not expect to be standing on much longer.

The passing-through verse becomes a permission slip to skip the entire second half of Jeremiah's letter, to be present in a place without ever being committed to it, to hold the whole city at the arm's length of a traveler in a hotel who does not learn the names of the staff because he checks out Sunday. It looks spiritual. It is really a refusal to love what God has explicitly commanded us to love. And it is the more dangerous of the two failures precisely because it can quote Scripture while it commits it.

The second refusal is the bunker. The bunker Christian also knows he does not belong here, and on the surface that looks like faithfulness, and some of it is. But his answer to not belonging is not to travel light. It is to fortify. He builds a parallel everything, a walled world with its own schools and its own commerce and its own culture and its own carefully filtered air, and he pulls his family and his money and his attention behind the walls, and he waits for the barbarians to lose interest or die off or somehow go away. There is more wisdom mixed into this one than the church usually credits, and I will defend the part that is right when we come to formation, because the bunker at least takes seriously that the culture is catechizing us and that we need communities thick enough to resist. But pushed to its end the bunker is its own betrayal, because it abandons the central command of the letter as surely as the suitcase does, only from the opposite side. The suitcase will not invest in Babylon. The bunker will not touch it. One holds the city at the arm's length of a tourist and the other at the arm's length of a fortress wall, and neither one builds a house and lives in it as a neighbor among neighbors, exposed, present, committed to the actual ground and the actual people. God forbids them both with the same four words. Build houses and live in them.

The suitcase Christian will not invest in Babylon, and

the bunker Christian will not touch it, and God commanded neither the tourist nor the fortress but the neighbor, exposed and staying, who builds a house he cannot carry away on ground he does not own.

No one in our time has seen the cost of refusing this command more clearly, or named it more precisely, than the writer Wendell Berry, who has spent a long working life on a single hillside farm in Henry County, Kentucky, arguing against the entire momentum of the American economy for the radical and unfashionable act of staying put. Berry says there are two kinds of people, and the names he gives them have stayed with me for years because they are so exact. There are boomers and there are stickers. The boomer, he says, borrowing the term from his teacher Wallace Stegner, is the one who is always moving on, who treats every place as a resource to be used and a launching pad to somewhere better, who goes wherever the opportunity is and extracts what the place offers and leaves the moment it stops serving him, loyal to his own advancement and to no particular patch of ground under heaven. The sticker is the one who stays. The one who settles. The one who commits to a place and its people for the long haul, who is not driven by the fear of missing out on the next thing, who learns a place slowly, across seasons and decades, well enough finally to love it, and tend it, and be responsible for it, and be buried in it.

And Berry's hard insight, the one both the suitcase and the bunker are built to evade, is a sentence I think the whole American church needs written over its door. You cannot love a place in general. You can only love a place in particular. Love is not a broad benevolent glow you beam out over a region from a passing car. Love is the slow attention of someone who is not leaving, who has learned this creek and this fence line and this

failing family down the road, who knows which field floods and which neighbor drinks and which widow will need her walk shoveled before she asks. You cannot love your neighbor in the abstract. There is no such creature as the neighbor in the abstract. There is only this neighbor, on this street, whose name you have bothered to learn precisely because you are not going anywhere and neither, most likely, is he. The abstraction is easy and costs nothing and does nothing. The particular is hard and costs everything and is the only love there is.

The exiles were commanded, in effect, to become stickers in Babylon. Not stickers in Judah, which would have been easy, which was only nostalgia. Stickers in the pagan city that had blinded their king and burned their temple. They were told to love the particular place they had been planted in, not as a cause to be championed from a distance but as a place to be inhabited up close, with the patient, committed, un-glamorous love that only staying makes possible, the love that can only be learned by a body that has decided to remain. You do not get to that love by touring Babylon or by fortifying against it. You get to it exactly one way, which is the way the command prescribes. You build a house, and you live in it, and you stay long enough for the abstraction called Babylon to dissolve into the particular faces of the people who live on your street, and then, and only then, you can begin to love them the way God has commanded you to.

This is, when you follow it all the way down, a question of incarnation, and the church should have understood it better than anyone alive, because it is the pattern written into the center of everything we believe. Our God did not save the world from a safe distance. He did not love humanity from the far side of the sky, in general, as an abstraction, as a species he felt warmly toward. The Word became flesh and dwelt among us, and every

clause of that sentence is a scandal of particularity. He took on flesh, which is to say a body, which is to say a location, in a particular place, Bethlehem and then Nazareth, to a particular mother named Mary and a particular carpenter named Joseph, in a particular occupied province of a particular empire, at a particular and datable moment when Augustus was in Rome and Herod was in Jerusalem. He walked particular dusty roads between particular named villages and got tired at a particular well in Samaria at about the sixth hour and asked a particular woman for a particular drink. He did not love the world by hovering above it. He loved it by moving into it, into one body, one town, one carpenter's shop, one three-year ministry within walking distance of where he was born. That staggering particularity is not incidental to how God saves. It is the method. It is the pattern of everything he does.

And the church, forgetting this, has too often tried to follow a Christ who does not exist, an abstract, placeless, frictionless, everywhere-and-therefore-nowhere Christ, a spirit of general benevolence with no dust on his feet. We have wanted a faith of the abstraction, the region, the demographic, the movement, the platform that reaches millions of people we will never meet and cannot name. But the Christ of the Gospels keeps insisting, maddeningly, on the local. The particular. The embodied. The town. The table. The twelve. The neighbor you can actually touch, whose name you actually know, whose funeral you will actually attend. To build a house and live in it is to follow the incarnate God down into a real place and stay there long enough for your faith to take on flesh the way his did, to become not an idea you hold in your head but a life you live in a body among particular people who can watch you live it, and be persuaded, or not, by the watching. The incarnation is God refusing to love in the abstract. The command to build houses is God refusing to let

us love in the abstract either.

Now I have to say the thing this cuts against, because it cuts against the deepest reflex of the people I am writing to, and I feel it in myself so I will not pretend to stand outside it. We are the most restless people in the history of the world. America was built by movement and for movement, settled by people who pulled up stakes and crossed an ocean, then pushed by people who pulled up stakes again and crossed a continent, formed at the marrow to believe that the answer to almost any problem is a fresh start somewhere else, that the better job and the bigger house and the newer city are always just over the next ridge and that the free and admirable man is the one unencumbered enough to go and get them. We move, on average, more than eleven times in a life. We have built an entire economy that assumes it and rewards it and would grind to a halt without it, an economy that treats a rooted, settled, un-relocatable worker as a liability and a mobile, detachable, optimizing one as an asset. The word we use for all of this restlessness is a warm word. We call it opportunity. We call it freedom. We teach our children that staying is failure and leaving is arrival.

And the church, God forgive us, has largely gone along, and has produced its own version of the boomer, and given him a pew. We now have Christians who change churches as casually and as frequently as they change neighborhoods, shopping the congregations of a city for the better music, the better children's program, the better preaching, the better parking, the better fit, loyal to their own preferences and to no particular body of believers, treating even the body of Christ as one more place to boom rather than stick. The pastor of any church that has stood for a while knows this family. They arrive in a wave of enthusiasm, they serve for a season, they are fed and they are

known, and then a friend gets excited about the newer church across town with the better band, and they are gone, no wound, no conversation, no covenant broken because no covenant was ever made, off to the next thing the way a boomer is always off to the next thing, and the ground they were briefly planted in closes over the hole and does not remember them. We church-hop the way we job-hop and house-hop, and we have baptized the whole restless enterprise and called it finding where God is leading, and it is very often nothing but the American disease with a worship set, the sovereign consumer self exercising its sovereignty over the one place it was never meant to shop.

The command to build a house stands against every bit of that, gently and without apology. It says there is a kind of faithfulness that can only be learned by staying, a depth that only grows where roots are left undisturbed across years, a knowledge of God and neighbor and self that is simply not available to the person who is always about to leave. It says the rootless, mobile, endlessly optimizing life that our culture calls freedom is, for the soul, a species of homelessness that we have mistaken for liberty. The boomer is free the way a tumbleweed is free. He goes wherever the wind of opportunity blows him, and he is attached to nothing, and responsible for nothing, and known by no one, and he calls the whole hollow arrangement freedom because he has never tasted the other thing, the deep and costly and rooted joy of the man who stays, who is planted, who has given his one life to a particular place and a particular people and been given, in return, a home. There is a liberty on the far side of commitment that the tumbleweed will never know, and the command to build a house is the door to it.

Let me be careful and fair here, because a command can be turned into a cruelty by pressing it past its meaning, and I am not

preaching a law against ever again packing a truck. People must sometimes move, and the letter knows it, and I know it. Jobs end and are not replaced. Callings genuinely change and God genuinely leads. A dying parent in another state needs a child close. A marriage begins and one person's roots have to give way to make one home out of two. A church becomes something a family in conscience cannot stay in, and leaving is not consumerism but faithfulness. There are a hundred good and even holy reasons a household loads a truck, and the command to build houses is not a chain around anyone's ankle forbidding it. It is not, first, a policy about real estate at all. It is a posture of the heart, and the posture is this: wherever God has actually planted you, right now, in this actual place, be fully here. Do not live perpetually on the way to somewhere else. Do not hold your real life in reserve for the better place that is always just ahead. The exile who is always about to leave never really lives anywhere, no matter how many decades he stacks up in one town, because his heart has never once put its weight down. And the exile who builds a house has decided, whether he stays two years or forty, to live here, really here, with these neighbors, on this street, in this church, for as long as God keeps him, and to love the place as if he will die in it, because he might, and because that is the only way anyone has ever loved a place at all.

I feel the whole weight of this in my own life, and I will not preach it from a safe distance, because I have not lived it perfectly and the gap between the command and my obedience is where I actually live. I pastor a church in Fenton, Michigan, a particular town with a particular water tower and particular potholes and particular families whose stories I have been let into over years. And I can tell you that everything of any weight I have ever done as a pastor came from staying, from being the one still here when the season turned, from having sat at enough

hospital beds and graveside services with the same people that they finally trusted me with the things you only tell someone who is not leaving. None of that was available to me in my first year, when I was still a stranger, still an abstraction to them and they to me. It became available only through the slow accumulation of not going anywhere, which is the pastoral form of Berry's staying, the sticker's love applied to a congregation. And I can also tell you that the pull to boom is real even for a settled pastor, the private fantasy of the bigger church in the more interesting city where the ministry would finally be what I imagine it should be, and that fantasy is exactly the thing Jeremiah's first command puts to death. It says the ministry God has for you is not in the imagined elsewhere. It is in the house you are standing in, among the people whose names you already know, and it will only ever be as deep as your willingness to stay put and let it get deep.

So build the house. Lay the foundation you cannot slip out of, in the particular ground of the particular Babylon where God has actually set you down, among the particular neighbors he has actually given you, and stop living out of a suitcase and stop hiding in a bunker and stop shopping the city for a better fit, and put your weight down, all of it, on the ground under your feet. That is the first command, and it is the ground the rest of the letter is planted in, and until a people has obeyed it there is nothing else to say to them, because every other instruction assumes a people who have decided to stay.

But a foundation is not a home, and here the letter does something we are almost certain to miss, because we skim right over the second half of the very first command. It does not say only build houses. It says build houses and live in them. And the living in them is a harder and stranger command than the

building, because we are people who have gotten very good at constructing lives we do not actually inhabit, who know how to acquire and improve and manage a house and are slowly forgetting how to dwell in one, how to eat and sleep and rest and be known and simply be human under a roof that is ours. It is possible to build the house and never move in. It is possible, and it is common, to put your weight down on the ground and still hold your life at arm's length, to be a resident who is never quite at home. So having commanded us to stay, the letter turns immediately to the question of what it means to actually live in the place we have committed to, and that question runs straight into the two great arenas where a human life is either inhabited or squandered, the six days of our work and the seventh day of our rest. Build the house. Now learn, which is harder, to live in it.

Chapter 9: Live in Them

The command has a second half, and the second half is the one we skip. Build houses and live in them. We heard build, and we went to work, because building is the thing we know how to do. We are a people of the loading dock and the spreadsheet and the launch, and the imperative to construct something lands in us like a native tongue. But the sentence does not stop at build. It goes on, into a quieter and more difficult verb, and live in them, and that verb turns out to be the harder of the two, because building is doing and living is dwelling, and we have gotten very good at the first while slowly forgetting how to do the second at all.

I want to say at the outset that I am writing this chapter against myself, because the man least qualified to lecture anyone about dwelling is the man who cannot stop building, and that man is me. I know how to erect a life. I know how to add the project and the platform and the next thing, how to fill a calendar until it groans, how to measure a week by what came out of it. What I do not know, what I am learning late and badly, is how to inhabit the thing I built, to take up residence in my own life rather than merely maintaining it from the outside like a landlord who never moves in. So read what follows as one exile talking to another about a command we have both half-obeyed, having built the house and never quite moved in.

Because a house is not a worksite. It is not an investment vehicle and it is not a project to be optimized and it is not a monument to your industry. It is a place a human being is meant to live, to eat and to sleep, to rest, to be known and to be bored and to be

interrupted, to be a creature among creatures rather than a machine among machines. The exile who builds the house and never lives in it, who treats even his own shelter as one more asset to manage, has obeyed exactly half the command, and the unobeyed half is the half about being human. God did not send his people into Babylon to construct a monument to their own diligence. He sent them there to live. The building is for the sake of the dwelling, never the other way around, and a people who invert that order have missed the whole point of the command while congratulating themselves on their obedience to it.

The one life, and no seam in it

To live in the house means, first and most concretely, to work in Babylon, because a house has to be paid for, and the exiles were not handed a holy enclave funded by nostalgia and subsidized by heaven. They had to eat. They had to take their place in the ordinary economy of the city that had conquered them, learning its trades and keeping its accounts and building its buildings and farming its fields and serving the everyday needs of a pagan society, and being paid for it. And in doing so they ran headlong into the truth the church keeps discovering and keeps managing to lose, the truth that for a person who belongs to God there is no such thing as secular work.

Understand what that claim rules out, because it is more radical than it sounds. It rules out the seam. The exile does not have a sacred life on the sabbath and a secular life at the workbench, a religious self on Saturday and a merely economic self the other six days, a real Christian existence that happens at worship and a neutral zone of getting and spending where God has no particular stake. He has one life, lived before one God, and the workbench is as much the theater of his faithfulness as the synagogue, because the God who claims all of him claims his

Monday as surely as his Sabbath. There is no corner of an exile's week where he is off duty, no zone of his labor that God has agreed to consider profane, no forty hours he is permitted to write off as dead time to be endured for the sake of the few hours that count. The whole of it is his, because the whole of him is God's.

This is precisely where the Reformers landed a blow the medieval church never recovered from, and then, over the centuries, we managed to soften the blow into a cliché. Vocation. We use the word now to mean a career, or a job we happen to like, and in doing so we have amputated everything that made it dangerous. Martin Luther looked at the arrangement that had quietly built up over a thousand years, the arrangement that reserved the word calling for monks and priests and nuns, the people who did the supposedly spiritual work, while everyone else merely had an occupation, and he detonated it. He said that the monk at his prayers was not one inch closer to God than the farmer at his plow, and then he gave the image that has never lost its force. The milkmaid at her pail. The cobbler at his last. The magistrate at his bench. The maid sweeping the floor. Each of them, Luther insisted, serves God as truly and as fully as any monk in any monastery, because God is not waiting for them in the religious corner of life. He is already present in the work of their hands, feeding the world through the milkmaid, clothing it through the cobbler, ordering the city through the magistrate, using their ordinary labor as the very means by which he provides for his creatures.

Luther put it more sharply still. He said that God milks the cows through the milkmaid. Not that the milkmaid does her work and then, separately, prays, and the praying is the holy part. That the milking itself is the mask of God, the hands through which the

providence of God reaches a hungry world. Your work, however ordinary, however invisible, however far it sits from anything that looks religious, is a place where God is at work through you for the good of your neighbor. And to do it well, to do it faithfully, to do it as an offering, is not a distraction from your calling or a compromise with a fallen economy. It is your calling. It is the thing itself.

Tim Keller spent a whole book working this out for people like us, and the argument matters enormously for the exile, because work is where most of us spend most of our waking lives, which means work is where most of our actual discipleship either happens or quietly fails to. Keller argued that the gospel changes the why of our work, and the how of it, and the for-whom of it. It changes the why, because the Christian no longer works to justify his own existence, to prove his worth, to build a name that will outlast him, but works instead as one already loved, already named, already secure, and therefore free to work without the frantic self-interest that turns every job into a scramble for significance. It changes the how, because the work is now done with integrity and excellence and honesty even when no one is watching, because the audience that matters is always watching. And it changes the for-whom, because the work is no longer aimed at the self and its advancement but at the genuine good it does for actual people, the neighbor fed and clothed and healed and taught and housed by the labor of your hands.

So the Christian in Babylon does not clock in merely to fund the real Christian life that supposedly happens on evenings and weekends. He does not treat his forty hours as a toll to be paid for the privilege of the few hours that count. He offers the work itself, the spreadsheet and the loading dock and the classroom and the exam room and the sales call and the assembly line, done

with integrity and offered to God and aimed at the good of his neighbor, as one of the central ways he seeks the welfare of the city. Your cubicle is one of the houses Jeremiah told you to build. The work you do in Babylon, if it serves the real good of the city and is done as unto God, is not a detour from your faith. It is your faith, with its sleeves rolled up.

Made to make

This goes back much further than the Reformers, further than the exile itself, all the way to the first pages of the story, and it will not be understood until it is traced there. On the very first pages, before there is any such thing as sin to be redeemed from, the God who has worked for six days and pronounced it good places the human being in a garden and gives him a job. The Lord God took the man and put him in the garden of Eden to work it and keep it. Read that slowly, because everything hangs on where it falls in the story. This is before the fall. This is Eden, unbroken, the world exactly as God wanted it, and there is work in it. The man is set down in paradise and immediately given something to do, something to tend, something to cultivate and bring forth and order and keep.

Work, then, is not a result of the curse. Work is part of what it means to bear the image of a working God. We are creatures made in the likeness of a Maker, and so we are makers, born to fashion and tend and order and cultivate, to take the raw material of the world and bring something good out of it the way God brought a world out of the formless deep. The curse did not invent work. Go back and read what the curse actually did. It made work hard. Cursed is the ground because of you, in pain you shall eat of it all the days of your life, thorns and thistles it shall bring forth for you, by the sweat of your face you shall eat bread. The curse laid futility and frustration and sweat and thorns

across the good thing, so that the making now comes with resistance and the tending now comes with grief, but the thing itself, the dignity of the work, was there in the garden before any thorn ever grew.

And it will be there at the end. The picture the Scriptures give of the redeemed world is not a picture of endless leisure, of harps and clouds and eternal idleness. It is a city, the new Jerusalem, and a city is a place of culture and craft and commerce and construction, a place of work redeemed and restored to what it was always meant to be, the sweat wiped away but the making left standing. The kings of the earth bring their glory into it. The nations bring their honor. Whatever that means in full, it does not mean that human making stops. It means that human making is at last purified of its futility and offered whole. So the exile who works, even in Babylon, even under the curse, even at a task that will never be celebrated, is doing a deeply human and deeply God-imaging thing. He is participating, however dimly, in the vocation that began in Eden and does not end at the grave.

Which means the dignity of ordinary work has to be recovered, and recovered against a culture and sometimes against a church that quietly despises it. We have built a world that honors a tiny set of glamorous callings, the ones with a platform and a stage and a title and a following, and communicates to everyone else, in a thousand small ways, that their work is merely a job, a way to pay the bills until the real significance arrives from somewhere else. The teacher and the electrician and the nurse and the mother and the man who fixes the transmission are made to feel that they are in the waiting room of meaning, that the important lives are being lived elsewhere, on screens, under lights. And the church has too often blessed this lie by reserving its highest honor for those it calls into ministry, as though the

pastor's calling were a higher grade of calling and the plumber's a lower one, when Luther set them on level ground five hundred years ago and the Scriptures set them on level ground before that.

But most of what God calls people to will never be on any stage. It will be the faithful raising of children who will not thank you until they have children of their own, if then. The honest running of a small business that will never make the news. The patient teaching of a class that will forget your name. The repair of the things that break. The care of the bodies that fail. The ten thousand acts of ordinary competence and quiet service that hold a city together and will never be applauded by anyone. The exile who has understood vocation can do that ordinary work with his head up, because he knows the God he serves is not impressed by stages, that the milkmaid and the magistrate stand on level ground before the throne, and that a hidden life of faithful ordinary work is not a small thing to God even when it is invisible to everyone else.

Wendell Berry has spent a long writing life defending exactly this, the goodness of good work done well in a particular place for the sake of a real community, work that is not extraction but membership, not a means of escape from a place but a way of belonging to it. He has argued, against the whole momentum of an economy that treats labor as a cost to be minimized and workers as units to be moved, that there is a holiness in work that is proportioned to a place and answerable to the people it serves, that the man who does his work well because his neighbors will live with the result of it is doing something the abstract and mobile economy cannot understand. That is close to what the exile is called to. Not work as a ladder out of Babylon. Work as a way of loving Babylon, done among people who will have to live with how well or how badly you did it.

*Your work is not the toll you pay to fund your real life.
It is your real life, offered as worship, wherever your
hands happen to be.*

The idol and its shadow

And this is where the exile has to become watchful, because a thing this good is a thing that can turn on you, and work is so good and so God-given that it makes a particularly seductive idol. The same culture that despises ordinary work worships work in its prestigious forms, and the two errors are not opposites but twins, both of them refusing to see work for what it actually is, a good gift that is not God. We make our jobs our identity. We answer the question of who we are with the question of what we do, so that a stranger at a party asks what do you do, and we hear who are you, and we reach for our title as though it were our name. We pour ourselves into our careers as the source of our worth and our meaning, until the work that was meant to be a way of loving our neighbor becomes a way of justifying our existence.

And then it devours us. No job can bear the weight of being a person's god. Ask it to tell you that you matter, and it will demand more and more and more, and it will never say enough, because the thing was never designed to speak that word to you. The idol of work is the most respectable idol in America, the one we praise even as it eats us, the one we call ambition and drive and excellence while it hollows out our marriages and estranges our children and leaves us, at sixty, successful and unknown, having built a life we were too busy to live in. We did this. I have done this. I have felt the pull of the work becoming the whole of me, the slow substitution of what I produce for who I am, and I have watched what it costs, and I am telling you the truth about an idol I have knelt to.

The exile is called to work hard and to work well and, at the very same time, to refuse to let the work become the thing he lives for. Those two commands feel as if they cannot both be obeyed, as though hard work and freedom from work must trade off against each other, and the reason we cannot hold them together is that we have lost the discipline that makes holding them together possible. The antidote to the idolatry of work is not laziness. It is the practice built into the very command we are considering, the command to live in the house and not only to build it, the command whose deepest form the exiles carried into Babylon in their bones. Because the cure for the idol of work is rest. Not collapse. Not the exhausted stupor of a body that has finally run out. Rest, chosen, commanded, holy. The Sabbath.

The stopping that sets you free

To live in the house is to rest in it, and the exiles carried into Babylon the strangest and most countercultural practice their God had ever given them, the practice of stopping. One day in seven, they ceased. They laid down the work, closed the shop, left the field, stopped the getting and the spending and the producing, and remembered that the world was held up by God and not by their labor. Remember the Sabbath day, to keep it holy. Six days you shall labor and do all your work, but the seventh day is a Sabbath to the Lord your God. On it you shall not do any work. It was, and is, an astonishing command, and it becomes more astonishing the harder your world presses on you, because a defeated people in a foreign empire had every reason to work every hour they could, to claw back some security, to prove their worth to their conquerors, to never stop. And God told them to stop.

The Sabbath is the proof that work is not their god. It is the weekly declaration, written not in words but in an entire idle day,

that they are not slaves, that their worth was settled before they produced anything and would remain after they could produce nothing, that the God who made the world in six days and rested on the seventh was not exhausted but was showing them how a life is supposed to breathe. Notice which reason the Scriptures give. In one telling, you rest because God rested, because rest is woven into the fabric of creation itself, a rhythm as basic as day and night. In another telling, in Deuteronomy, you rest because you were slaves in Egypt and the Lord brought you out, and so you shall keep the Sabbath, and your son and your daughter and your servant and the stranger inside your gates shall rest too. Sabbath is the memory of liberation made into a weekly habit. A slave cannot stop. A slave works at the master's pleasure until the master is done with him. So a people who stop, deliberately, joyfully, one day in seven, are declaring with their whole bodies that they are not slaves, that they have a Master who commands them to rest, which is the one thing no earthly master ever commands.

And here is the diagnosis for the exile, and I feel it land on my own chest as I write it. A people that cannot stop has not been freed. It has only changed masters. The exile who builds and works and accumulates without ever resting has not actually moved into his life. He has only relocated his striving from Jerusalem to Babylon, carried his anxiety across a thousand miles and set it back up in a new city, still convinced that the world will fall apart if he lets go of it for a day, still believing, in the deep place beneath his theology, that it is his labor and not God's grace that holds everything together. The refusal to rest is not diligence. It is unbelief with a good reputation. It is the practical atheism of a person who says he trusts God and then behaves, seven days a week, as though the universe were resting on his shoulders and would crash the moment he set it down.

To keep the Sabbath, to actually stop, to let a whole day go by in which you make nothing and prove nothing and earn nothing and simply receive your life as a gift, is its own quiet rebellion against an empire that measures you by your output and would gladly consume every hour you have. Babylon does not want you to rest. The whole machinery of the modern economy is arranged to keep you producing and consuming without pause, to blur the days into one another until there is no seventh day at all, only an endless present of work and its accompanying anxieties, the phone buzzing on the nightstand, the email answered at the traffic light, the work that follows you home and into your bed and into what used to be your day off. In that world, to close the laptop and keep a day holy is not quaint. It is subversion. It is a small weekly insurrection against the lie that you are what you produce, and it announces, to yourself and to your children and to anyone watching, that you belong to a kingdom that does not run on the empire's clock.

The church that will survive the long exile is going to have to recover this, and not as a rule but as a gift, not as one more thing to fail at but as the mercy it was always meant to be. Because a people who have forgotten how to rest have forgotten how to be creatures, and a people who cannot be creatures cannot worship a Creator, since worship is precisely the act of a creature acknowledging that it is not God. The Sabbath is the hinge where the whole week turns from striving to trust, and a life with no such hinge grinds itself down, however faithful its intentions. We were not built for the endless week. We were built for six and one, for labor and rest, for the making that images God and the stopping that trusts him, and an exile who keeps only the first half of that rhythm is not more devoted than his resting brother. He is only more tired, and more afraid, and more deeply enslaved to a Babylon he thinks he is defying.

Dwelling, not only maintaining

So live in the house. Not maintain it, not manage it, not treat it as one more asset in the portfolio of a well-optimized life. Live in it. And I confess that I feel the weight of this command precisely where I am weakest, because I am far better at building than at living, far more comfortable producing than dwelling, and I suspect I am not alone, that a whole generation of us has gotten very good at constructing lives we do not actually inhabit. We build the career and the platform and the house and the calendar, and we live perpetually at the edge of our own lives, hovering over them, managing them, optimizing them, anxious about them, present in them the way a contractor is present at a site, checking the progress, never quite moving in. We are the most housed and least dwelling people in history, surrounded by everything we built and at home in none of it.

There is a difference, and the difference is everything, between a life you are maintaining and a life you are dwelling in. Maintaining is a posture of anxiety. It keeps one eye always on the thing that might go wrong, the ball that might drop, the plate that might shatter, and it experiences even its own good as a set of obligations to be kept from collapsing. Dwelling is a posture of trust. It receives the life as a gift, sits down inside it, lets the walls hold, and rests in the knowledge that the whole thing is upheld by a hand that is not your own. The exile who merely maintains his life in Babylon is exhausted by it, because he is carrying it, and it is heavy, and it was never meant to be carried by him. The exile who dwells in his life has set it down into the hands of God and moved in, and can therefore work without frenzy and rest without guilt and be genuinely present to the wife across the table and the child at his knee and the neighbor at his door, because he is not, in the deep place, holding everything

together. He knows who is.

The command to live in the house is God's mercy to people like me. It is an instruction to stop building long enough to be human, to take up residence in the one life we have been given, to work as those who are already loved rather than as those still earning their worth, and to rest as those who trust that the world will keep turning while they sleep. It is not a lesser command than build, tucked on as an afterthought. It is the point of the building. God did not tell the exiles to construct houses so that they could admire their construction. He told them to build houses so that they could live in them, and a people who master the first verb and neglect the second have missed the whole reason the first was given.

The exiles who learned this became something the empire could not account for, a people who worked among the Babylonians with visible excellence and integrity, and who then, one day in seven, simply stopped, and rested, and worshipped a God the empire could not see, and were not destroyed by the stopping but were held together by it. They were the ones who could give their labor to Babylon without giving Babylon their souls, because their souls had a Sabbath the empire could not touch. They worked the empire's fields and kept the empire's accounts and built the empire's buildings, and they were free the whole time, free because they knew the work was not their god and the empire was not their master and their worth was not up for the daily verdict of their productivity.

And having settled into a home, and a calling, and a rhythm of work and rest, the exile is ready for the slowest command of all, the one that will ask him, even more than the house did, to believe that he is really staying. Because a house you can throw up in a season, and a job you can begin on Monday, but the next

thing the letter commands cannot be hurried at all. Plant gardens, God says, and eat their produce, and a garden makes you wait. It asks you to put a seed in the ground and believe in a harvest you cannot yet see, to tend soil that shows nothing for a long time, to commit to a patch of Babylonian earth on a timescale that reaches past your own hands. It is the long faithfulness of a people who have stopped waiting to leave, and it is the truest test of whether the exile has believed the prophet at all.

Chapter 10: Plant Gardens, Eat Their Produce

A house you can throw up in a season. A garden makes you wait, and the waiting is the entire lesson. You put a seed in the ground and for weeks nothing happens, nothing you can see, and if you plant the slow things, the fig, the vine, the olive, the orchard, you wait not weeks but years, and some of what you plant you will not taste for a decade and some of it you will not taste at all. To tell a homesick people, straining west toward the road home, that they should plant gardens is to tell them a truth their grief cannot yet carry: that they are going to be here long enough for trees to reach their bearing, that this is not a layover but a life. A garden is a bet on staying made with seeds instead of stone. It is a harder bet than the house, because a house shelters you tonight and a garden asks you to believe in a future you cannot yet see, and to believe it enough to kneel down in a conquered field and put something living into the dirt.

That is why the garden, and not the house, is the truest test of whether a person has actually accepted the exile or has only endured it while privately waiting for it to end. The house can be built by a man who still expects to leave. He tells himself it is an investment, a thing he will sell when the call to march comes, a shelter he can walk away from. But no one digs an orchard into ground he intends to abandon by spring. The exiles who had believed Hananiah, who were certain the whole nightmare would be over in two years, would never plant a slow tree, because there is no colder waste of a man's labor than to nurse a sapling for the man who conquers you next. Only the exile who has

heard the word seventy years and let it land in his body, who has stopped waiting for the quick rescue and decided at last to live the actual life set in front of him, will bend down and press a slow seed into Babylonian soil. The garden is acceptance with dirt under its fingernails. It is the body finally agreeing with what the prophet said. We are here for a long time, and the long time is not a sentence to be served. It is a life to be planted and tended and, in the fullness of the seasons, harvested.

Notice what God does not say, because the omission is the whole point. He does not say, endure Babylon. He does not say, survive it, or wait it out, or hunker down until the deliverance comes. He says plant a garden, which is the most forward-leaning, the most hopeful, the most rooted thing a human being can do with a patch of earth. A garden is an argument against despair made in the grammar of the seasons. Every seed the exile drops into the ground is a small sermon preached to his own frightened heart, that the God who sent him here has not stopped being the God who makes things grow, that even in the country of his defeat the rain will still fall and the sun will still rise on the just and the unjust alike, and that the ancient covenant with the seasons, seedtime and harvest, cold and heat, summer and winter, day and night, has not been suspended just because the temple is a heap of ash a thousand miles behind him. To plant is to confess that God still governs the ground even here, in the land that does not know his name.

The long obedience against the culture of the instant

Eugene Peterson built an entire book on a phrase he borrowed, by way of a line from an unbelieving German philosopher, for exactly this kind of faithfulness, and he called it a long obedience in the same direction. He wrote it in 1980, against what he named an instant society, a culture of immediacy that

has trained us to expect everything now and to abandon anything that does not pay off quickly. Discipleship, Peterson argued, is constitutionally the opposite of that. It is a slow walk in a single direction sustained across a whole life, one foot in front of the other, through weather and boredom and the long stretches where nothing seems to be happening at all. The garden is the agrarian image of that long obedience made visible. It does not answer to your will, or your hurry, or your enthusiasm, or your metrics. It answers only to seasons. It answers to patience. It answers to the slow fidelity of someone who keeps tending ground that shows nothing for a long time, who waters and weeds and prunes through the months of apparent nothing, because he knows this is simply how living things grow, underground and unseen, root before shoot, long before there is any fruit to hold up as proof.

Peterson was naming a wound, and it has only opened wider in the decades since he named it. We are a people of the launch and the campaign and the quarterly number that has to move now. We have compressed the human sense of time down to the length of a notification, and we have imported all of it, every bit of it, into the life of faith. We want revival by next year. We want a recovered culture by the next election. We want our own sanctification on a schedule we can see, a straight line trending up, evidence this month that we are becoming holier than we were last month. And a garden will not give us any of that, and neither will God. The most important things grow on a clock we do not control and cannot read, and a people who have forgotten how to do anything slowly have forgotten how to do the one thing that exile most requires. We plant nothing slow, because nothing slow shows up in the numbers by the time we need the numbers. We abandon the ground the moment it fails to produce. And then we stand around the frantic, shallow, perpetually

disappointed thing we have made and wonder aloud why the church feels so thin.

There is a deeper diagnosis underneath the impatience, and Charles Taylor supplied it. The modern self, he argued, lives inside what he called the immanent frame, a world experienced as closed and flat, a universe of matter and mechanism with the transcendent pushed out to the far edge or out of the picture altogether. And a self that lives in a flattened world will inevitably flatten its sense of time along with everything else, because if this life is all there is, then every hour that does not visibly pay off is an hour lost forever, and waiting becomes not a discipline but a kind of theft. The instant society is not merely a bad habit. It is the natural liturgy of a people who no longer believe the world is deep enough to reward patience. The garden refuses that whole frame. To plant a slow tree is to declare, with your hands, that time is not a flat line running out but a deep field held by God, that the years you will not live to see are as safe in his keeping as the ones you will, and that a life spent on a harvest you will not gather is not a life wasted but a life rightly aimed.

The deepest thing the garden teaches is how to plant what you will not harvest, and there is no posture more foreign to a modern person, or more necessary to an exile. Go and stand, in your imagination, before one of the great cathedrals of Europe, Chartres or Cologne or Salisbury, and think about the men who laid the foundations. The masons who quarried and dressed and set the first stones of Cologne in 1248 were laying the base of a building that would not be finished until 1880, more than six hundred years later. Not one of them, not their sons, not their sons' sons for twenty generations, would ever worship in the completed thing their hands had begun. They carved gargoyles

that no living eye would see for centuries, tucked into heights that would not be reached until long after every man who cut them was dust. They set stone knowing with total certainty that they would die inside the scaffolding, that the spire was a rumor they would never live to confirm. And they built anyway. They gave their working lives to a glory they would not see, content to be one faithful link in a chain whose completion belonged to God and to the unborn. That is gardening on the scale of centuries, and it is the exact posture the seventy years demands: the willingness to plant orchards whose shade will fall on the faces of people you will never meet, to labor with everything you have for a harvest it is not yours to gather.

The Scriptures know this cathedral logic long before there were cathedrals. Abraham was promised a land and a people as numerous as the stars, and Hebrews tells us the truth about how he held it. These all died in faith, not having received the things promised, but having seen them and greeted them from afar, and having acknowledged that they were strangers and exiles on the earth. He greeted the promise from afar. He waved at it across a distance he knew he would not cross in his own lifetime, and he called himself a stranger, and he kept walking toward a country he would only ever see over the horizon. The whole patriarchal narrative is a story of men who planted what they would not harvest, who buried their wives in fields they bought but would not keep, who died holding a deed to a homeland their descendants would not enter for four hundred years. The exile did not invent this pattern. The exile only stripped away the illusion that had let a comfortable people forget it, the illusion that the harvest comes in the lifetime of the one who plants.

A garden is a bet that God, not you, will be here for the harvest, and the whole of faithfulness is learning to

make that bet with your hands and not just your mouth.

I know this impatience from the inside, because it is mine, and I will not pretend to preach it down from some height I have already reached. I want to see the fruit. I want the work of my hands to show a result I can point to within a span of time I can stand to wait, and the garden rebukes that want every single season, reminding me that the most important things grow on a timeline that has nothing to do with my need to watch them grow. I have measured my own faithfulness by what I could see, the way the world measures everything, and the seventy years stands over all of it and says, no, that is not how my kingdom keeps time. To plant a garden in Babylon is to make peace, in the body and not just the theology, with not being the one who harvests. It is to give my one life to a slow and faithful tending and to leave the increase, as every farmer since the first farmer has had to leave it, to God. This is the discipline the whole exile turns on, and it is the discipline our age has most completely lost, and the church cannot recover its nerve until it recovers its patience.

The command that corrects the pious

The command is not only plant gardens. It is plant gardens and eat their produce, and the second half is aimed like an arrow at an error the pious are especially prone to, the assumption that faithfulness in a hostile land must mean only labor and self-denial and grim endurance, and never, ever, enjoyment. God tells the exiles to eat. To sit down at a table in the middle of Babylon and taste the fruit of the trees they planted. To enjoy the good that even an exile's life produces, to receive the ordinary pleasures of food and harvest and home as gifts and not as guilty compromises smuggled out of a fallen world. The God who sent his people into exile did not send them into a joyless one, and the

exile who has learned to plant but never to eat, who treats every pleasure as a distraction pulling him away from the real and serious work, has misread the command as badly as the man who never plants at all. Both of them have refused the life God actually gave.

There are two ways to fail at eating the produce, and the exile is pulled toward both. The first is the failure of the suitcase Christian, the one who keeps his bags packed by the door, who is too busy waiting to leave to ever really live where he is. He holds the goods of this life at arm's length, because they are not the goods of home, and he cannot taste the bread of Babylon because his heart is always somewhere over the western horizon. He is so spiritual about his exile that he refuses its legitimate joys, and he calls the refusal holiness, when very often it is nothing more than a failure to receive what God has actually handed him. He has decided that because this is not the country he wanted, he will not permit himself to be glad in it, and he mistakes his own sourness for devotion. The second failure is the exact opposite, the failure of the glutton, who consumes without end and tastes nothing, who is so busy reaching for the next thing that he never once enjoys the thing already in his hand. His overconsumption is its own strange kind of inability to eat, because real eating requires presence, and gratitude, and a capacity for the word enough, and the glutton has none of the three. One man is too pious to enjoy the produce. The other is too greedy to taste it. And both have failed the simplest command in the letter, which is to sit down and eat.

The cure for both failures is the same, and it is gratitude: the settled, unhurried, grateful enjoyment of ordinary good as the gift of God. Paul wrote it to Timothy in a letter that could have been addressed straight to an anxious exile. For everything

created by God is good, and nothing is to be rejected if it is received with thanksgiving, for it is made holy by the word of God and prayer. Read the setting of that verse, because it makes the point sharper than the verse alone. Paul is warning against teachers who forbid marriage and require abstinence from foods, a false spirituality that treats the created world as an enemy to be starved rather than a gift to be received. Against that grim asceticism Paul plants a flat, unembarrassed declaration: everything God made is good, and the way you honor the Giver is not by refusing the gift but by receiving it with thanks. Gratitude is what makes the difference between the glutton and the saint at the very same table. The glutton grabs. The saint gives thanks, and in the giving of thanks the food stops being mere fuel and becomes something closer to a sacrament, a daily sign that the God who provides in Jerusalem provides just as surely in Babylon.

And then there is the Preacher in Ecclesiastes, who is the last witness anyone would expect to call on the side of joy, and precisely for that reason the most convincing. Here is a man who has stared into every vanity under the sun, who has tasted every pleasure and built every great work and accumulated every possession and pronounced all of it a chasing after wind, who knows better than anyone in Scripture how quickly the light fails and how completely death levels the wise man and the fool. And from inside that hard clarity, having seen through everything, he keeps circling back to the same stubborn counsel, not once but again and again, like a refrain he cannot leave alone. There is nothing better for a person than that he should eat and drink and find enjoyment in his toil. This also, he says, I saw, that it is from the hand of God, for apart from him who can eat or who can have enjoyment. Go, eat your bread with joy, and drink your wine with a merry heart, for God has already approved what you

do. This is not a lesser, fleshly wisdom set against the higher spiritual life. It is the spiritual life, arrived at the hard way, on the far side of disillusionment. The man who has seen that nothing under the sun can bear the weight of ultimate meaning is set free, at last, to receive the bread and the wine and the work of the day as exactly what they are, small daily gifts from the hand of God, to be enjoyed with a merry heart and not squeezed for a significance they were never meant to carry.

Put those two witnesses together, Paul and the Preacher, the apostle and the disillusioned king, and they say the same startling thing from opposite ends of the Bible. The way of holiness is not the refusal of the world's ordinary goods. It is the grateful reception of them from the right hand. The exile is not being told to numb himself to pleasure until the homecoming, gritting his teeth through a joyless captivity as though sourness were a spiritual achievement. He is being told to set a table, and to eat the fruit of his own garden, and to bless God over it, right there in the heart of the empire that burned his temple. That grateful table is not a betrayal of his grief. It is the answer to it.

The feast Babylon cannot manage

Sit with the strangeness of that for a moment, because it is here that the whole chapter turns from a lesson about patience into a description of two entirely different ways of being alive in the world. Babylon is the great consumer. That is what an empire is, at bottom, an engine of consumption, a machine built to take, to extract, to acquire, to devour the goods and the labor and the bodies of everyone within its reach and turn them into more of itself. Babylon eats without end. And yet, for all its endless eating, Babylon cannot manage a feast, because a feast is not the same thing as consumption, and the empire has never once understood the difference. Consumption grabs and swallows and

reaches immediately for the next thing, and is never full, and never satisfied, and never present to what it holds. A feast receives. A feast pauses. A feast gives thanks before it takes a bite, and lingers over what it has been given, and knows the meaning of the word enough, and rises from the table not craving but content. The empire consumes the whole world and tastes none of it. The exile plants one small garden and tastes everything.

This is why the grateful table of a faithful household is, all by itself, a witness so pointed that a watching pagan cannot account for it. Robert Bellah gave us the woman he called Sheila, whose entire religion was her own little voice, and that self-authored faith is the water the whole late-modern world now swims in, a world in which the sovereign self is the final court and the only question worth asking of anything is whether it works for me. A self like that cannot feast, because the feast requires two things the sovereign self does not possess. It requires a Giver to thank, and it requires a limit to honor, a place where you say enough and mean it. The autonomous self, answering to no one and satisfied by nothing, is condemned to consume, to reach and grab and scroll and swipe and acquire, forever hungry in the middle of unimaginable plenty, because it has cut itself off from the only posture that can turn plenty into gladness, which is gratitude, and gratitude requires a Someone to be grateful to. The exile who bows his head over a plate of ordinary food and thanks the God of heaven for it is doing something the empire, in all its power, is structurally unable to do. He is enjoying his life. And an empire that consumes everything and enjoys nothing has no answer to a man who has almost nothing and enjoys it all.

There is more here than a contrast, though. There is a foretaste, because the produce of the exile's garden is never only a present

pleasure. It is a downpayment on a coming one. Every harvest the exile gathers in Babylon is a small pledge of the great harvest at the end of all things, a sign that the God who gives fruit now will give the fuller fruit at the last, that the table set in exile is a rehearsal for the feast in the kingdom. Isaiah, prophesying to this very people, painted the end of the story as a banquet. On this mountain the Lord of hosts will make for all peoples a feast of rich food, a feast of well-aged wine, of rich food full of marrow, of aged wine well refined. And he will swallow up on this mountain the covering that is cast over all peoples, and he will swallow up death forever, and the Lord God will wipe away tears from all faces. The end of exile, in the mouth of the prophet, is not an escape into a bodiless heaven. It is a feast, on a mountain, with rich food and aged wine and every tear wiped away, and the thing that gets swallowed up at last is death itself, the great consumer consumed. To eat the produce of your garden with joy, here and now, in the middle of Babylon, is to practice for that feast, to taste in the ordinary fruit of an ordinary tree a small sure sample of the goodness that waits at the far end of the seventy years. The exile does not have to survive until the return to learn that God is good. He can taste it now, at the table he has set in the heart of the empire, and the tasting is itself an act of faith, a body rehearsing a hope it cannot yet see.

The early church understood this, and made the meal the center of everything it was, which is why the empire found it so difficult to explain and so impossible to stop. Where Babylon consumed, the church feasted, and it feasted in a way that turned the whole social order of the ancient world upside down at a single table. Rome sorted its meals with ferocious care, the good couches for the important guests, the lesser food for the lesser people, everyone seated exactly according to rank and blood and wealth, the banquet itself a diagram of who mattered and who

did not. And the church sat the slave down beside the master and called them both brother, and passed the same bread and the same cup to both, and gave the seat of honor to the widow and the stranger and the poor. Paul had to rebuke the Corinthians precisely because they were letting the empire's way of eating creep back into the Lord's table, the rich eating their fill while the poor went hungry, and he told them that to eat that way was not to eat the Lord's supper at all. The gathered meal of the Christians was a contrast society compressed into an hour around a table, a feast the empire could not produce because the empire could only ever sort and consume, and the church, gathered around bread and wine and thanksgiving, could do the one thing the empire never learned. It could receive. It could give thanks. It could be full.

Rodney Stark, running the arithmetic on how a powerless minority grew into half an empire across three hostile centuries, kept arriving at answers the modern church does not want to hear, because none of them involve power or platform or cultural standing, and one of them is exactly this. The Christians lived, together, in a way that was visibly more full of life than the world around them, and the exhausted people of a brutal age came to see if it was real. When the great plagues emptied the cities and the pagans fled their own dying by the roadside, the Christians stayed and nursed the sick, and the ones who lived did not forget who had sat by their beds. But it was not only the crisis that drew people. It was the ordinary, daily, unforced gladness of a community that ate together and thanked God together and welcomed the children no one else wanted and cared for the widows no one else would feed. The Letter to Diognetus, written by some anonymous Christian in the second century to a puzzled pagan, put the strangeness of it exactly. They are in the flesh, he wrote, but they do not live according to

the flesh. They pass their days on earth, but they are citizens of heaven. It is the paradox of the feast in exile: a people entirely at home in the goodness of created things, and entirely unowned by the empire that produced them, tasting the world more deeply than the consumers who possessed it, precisely because they had received it as gift rather than seized it as spoil.

What this asks of us, on a Tuesday

I have to preach this one to myself from the harder side, and it is worth confessing which side that is. My temptation has never been the glutton's. It is the striver's, the inability to stop laboring long enough to enjoy what the labor produced, the low and constant suspicion that rest and pleasure are indulgences I have not yet earned and probably never will. I can plant. What I cannot easily do is sit down and eat. I am far better at building than at living, far more comfortable producing than dwelling, and I suspect I am not alone in this, that a whole generation of us has gotten very good at constructing lives we do not actually inhabit and gardens we never sit down in. We plant the career and the ministry and the reputation, and we live perpetually at the edge of our own harvest, managing it, worrying over it, measuring it, never once resting in it and never once giving thanks for it with a merry heart. And the command to eat the produce is God's specific mercy to people built like me. It is an instruction to stop laboring long enough to be a creature again, to receive the one life we have been given instead of endlessly auditing it, and to trust that the God who grows the garden will keep growing it while we rest.

So make this concrete, because a chapter about tasting that never touches a Tuesday has failed its own argument. To eat the produce of your Babylonian garden is, first and most simply, to keep a table. It is to guard the family meal against the thousand

forces that would dissolve it into separate screens and staggered schedules and food eaten standing up on the way to the next thing, and to make it instead a place where the household actually stops, and looks at one another, and gives thanks out loud before anyone lifts a fork. That thanksgiving is not a formality. It is the whole difference between the empire's way of eating and the exile's, a small daily act of defiance against the consumer's reflex to grab and swallow and rush on. It is to recover the sabbath not as a rule but as a feast, one day in seven when you make nothing and prove nothing and simply receive your life as the gift it is, a whole day organized around the scandalous idea that the world will keep turning while you sit still. It is to notice the ordinary goods that the striver and the glutton both race past, the taste of good bread, the light through a window in the late afternoon, the particular faces around your own table, the produce of a year's slow work, and to receive each of them as what it is, a gift from a hand that has not stopped giving even in the country of your exile. And it is, hardest of all for the striver, to let the enjoyment be a form of faithfulness rather than a break from it, to believe that a father laughing at his own table is preaching the gospel to his children as surely as a father teaching them the catechism, because he is showing them, in the only language a child fully trusts, that the God his family serves is a God worth being glad about.

This is not the escape from exile. It is the way through it. The suitcase Christian will not eat because his heart has already left, and the glutton cannot eat because his heart is never present, and the striver forgets to eat because his heart is always three fields ahead, and all three have missed the strange gift buried in the second half of the command. God did not plant his people in Babylon merely to labor there. He planted them to live there, and living includes the table, the harvest, the feast, the grateful

tasting of ordinary good that declares, more loudly than any argument, that God is present and generous and good even here, even now, even in the land that does not know his name. Plant the garden, the letter says, and plant the slow things, the fig and the vine and the long obedience whose fruit you may never taste. And then, having planted, do the thing the same command requires in the same breath, the thing the pious keep forgetting and the empire has never once managed. Sit down. Give thanks. Eat.

And now the letter turns to the deepest planting of all, the one beside which the orchard is a passing thing, the slowest seed and the longest obedience and the boldest bet any exile ever makes on a future he will not live to see. Because a fruit tree is a bet on a decade, but a marriage is a bet on a lifetime, and a child is a bet on a world you will be dead before you can see. The exile is about to be commanded to plant not in the soil but in the flesh, to take wives and raise children in the middle of Babylon, and that is a harder and more defiant garden than any orchard, and it is where the letter goes next.

Chapter 11: Take Wives, Raise Children

The next command in the letter is the most defiant thing God says to the exiles, and it does not look defiant at all, because it wears the most ordinary clothes a human life can put on. Take wives and have sons and daughters, God tells them through Jeremiah, take wives for your sons and give your daughters in marriage, that they may bear sons and daughters. Multiply there, and do not decrease. Marry. Have children. Raise those children to marry and to have children of their own, so that the line does not thin out and vanish in a foreign land. To a defeated and demoralized people sitting in the wreckage of their nation, a people who had every reason to believe their story was over, God commands the most stubbornly hopeful act a human being can perform, the founding of a household, and he commands it precisely as an act of defiance against despair.

You have to understand what defeat does to a people before you can hear how strange this command is, because the command is set against a natural gravity, and the gravity is real. Conquered people stop having children. It is one of the most reliable patterns in the whole record of human sorrow. When a nation is broken, when the future has been foreclosed, when the story a people told about itself has collapsed, the birthrate falls, and it falls not by decree but by a thousand quiet private calculations made in the dark. Why bring a child into a lost cause. Why marry into the exile that broke me. Why give my daughter to face the captivity I can barely endure myself. Why pour a life into a future I have stopped believing in. The natural posture of

the defeated is contraction, a slow folding-in on itself, a refusal of tomorrow that begins in the refusal to make more people to inhabit it. And it is against exactly that contraction, that quiet giving-up dressed as realism, that God speaks his most pointed word in the whole letter. Multiply there, and do not decrease. Do not let the line die in Babylon. The exile is not the end of the future. It is the soil the future will now be grown in, and the growing begins in households that refuse to concede that the story is finished.

I want to be honest about how counterintuitive this is, because the letter has just spent its opening lines taking away every reason for optimism. God has told them seventy years. He has told them most of them will die here. He has told them the popular prophets promising a quick homecoming are liars. And then, having removed the fantasy of rescue, having handed them a shovel where they wanted a ticket home, the very next thing he tells this grieving people to do is to fall in love, and marry, and make children, and give those children away in marriage so that the whole vulnerable business can happen again. It is not what despair would counsel. Despair would counsel the closed womb and the empty cradle, the defensive crouch of a people who have decided the safest thing is to make nothing that can be taken from them. God counsels the opposite. He commands the exiles to bet on a future they will not live to see, and to make that bet with the most irreversible wager available to a human being, which is a child.

The home as the first outpost

The reason God can command this, and the reason it is not cruel, is that the household is the first and most durable outpost of the people of God in any foreign land. It is the smallest and the strongest unit of the faith's survival. Before there was a temple to

lose, before there was a nation to conquer, before there was a king or a court or a priesthood, there was a family at a table, and the faith was carried there. This is not a sentimental point. It is the actual architecture of transmission that God built into his people from the beginning, and the exile does not invent it. The exile only strips away everything else until this is all that is left, and forces the people to see that it was always the load-bearing thing.

Go back to the passage that stands behind this whole command, the one every faithful Jew in Babylon would have carried in his body, the words of the Shema in Deuteronomy chapter six. Hear, O Israel: The Lord our God, the Lord is one. You shall love the Lord your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your might. And then, immediately, before anything is said about temples or priests or sacrifices, comes the command about how this is passed on. And these words that I command you today shall be on your heart. You shall teach them diligently to your children, and shall talk of them when you sit in your house, and when you walk by the way, and when you lie down, and when you rise.

Notice where the transmission happens. Not in the sanctuary. In the house, and on the road, and at the table, and at the edge of sleep, and in the first grey minutes of waking. Notice who does the transmitting. Not the priest. The parent. The central command for handing the faith to the next generation was given not to religious professionals in a holy building but to fathers and mothers in the ordinary texture of a domestic day, and the medium of transmission is not a lecture or a curriculum but conversation, repetition, the constant low pressure of a life lived in front of a child who is always watching. You shall teach them diligently. The Hebrew word carries the sense of sharpening, of

honing, the way you would work an edge onto a blade by repeated patient strokes. The faith is meant to be worked into a child the way an edge is worked into steel, not in one dramatic session but in ten thousand ordinary ones, when you sit and when you walk and when you lie down and when you rise.

This is the wisdom the exile recovers and Christendom let us forget. Under Christendom the home could afford to be lazy about formation, and most homes were, because the whole surrounding culture carried the faith alongside the parents and reinforced at every turn what was taught, or not taught, at the table. The school opened in prayer. The town closed on Sunday. The stories in the air were the Bible's stories. The very calendar bent around the Christian year, so that a child absorbed the shape of the gospel from the shape of his own days without anyone deliberately teaching it to him. A parent could be almost entirely passive and still watch the faith pass to his children, because the water carried it. The home did not have to be strong because the culture did the heavy lifting.

In Babylon the culture carries something else, and this is the hinge on which everything in this chapter turns. Your children are being formed all day long, relentlessly, by forces that never rest and are far better funded than you are, and the only question is whether anything happening at your own table is strong enough to compete. The school forms them. The screen forms them. The feed forms them, hour after hour, with a catechesis so constant and so seductive that most parents do not even recognize it as catechesis, because it does not announce itself as religion. It simply forms desire. It teaches a child, below the level of argument, what a good life looks like, what is worth wanting, who he is, whose approval matters, what will make him happy. James K. A. Smith has spent a career insisting that we are

not primarily thinking things who believe our way into a way of life. We are loving things, formed by what we do over and over, by liturgies, and the secular age is thick with liturgies of its own, the scroll and the screen and the store, and they are working on your children every single day whether you have noticed or not. A liturgy does not need your consent to form you. It only needs your repetition.

So the family that does not deliberately, actively, relentlessly form its children in the faith is not remaining neutral. There is no neutral. The screen does not wait for permission and the feed does not observe a truce. The passive Christian home in Babylon is not keeping its options open for the child to choose later from a clean slate. It is conceding the field. It is handing the child to Babylon's catechesis by default, and then, years on, when the grown child believes what Babylon believes and wants what Babylon wants and cannot see why anyone would want otherwise, the parents wonder what happened, when what happened is the most ordinary thing in the world. The child was catechized. Just not by them.

Your children will be catechized by the screen and the feed unless they are catechized at the table. There is no third option, and the table has to be louder.

Marriage as covenant, not contract

None of this holds if the marriage underneath it will not hold, and so before the children there is the question of the thing that makes the home possible at all. Take wives, God says, and the taking of a wife or a husband in Babylon is asked to bear a weight the surrounding culture can no longer imagine carrying. Because a home that forms children across decades, and a marriage that witnesses to a watching city across decades, both

require the one thing the age has quietly abolished, which is permanence. And permanence is only possible where marriage is understood as a covenant and not a contract, and that distinction is not a technicality. It is the whole difference between two ways of being human.

A contract is a deal. It is an exchange of goods and services between two parties, entered into for the benefit of each, and it lasts precisely as long as it serves the interests of both. When it stops delivering, when the cost outruns the benefit, when one party finds a better deal elsewhere, the contract is dissolved, and this is not a betrayal of the contract but the fulfillment of its logic, because a contract was always conditional, always a means to the ends of the individuals who signed it. A culture organized around the sovereign self, the self as the final authority that Robert Bellah watched being born in the woman he called Sheila, can only understand marriage as a contract, because it can only understand any relationship as a contract, as one more arrangement that exists to serve the individual and may be exited when it ceases to. The self is the point, and the marriage is the instrument, and an instrument that stops working is discarded.

A covenant is a different kind of thing entirely, and the difference is the difference between the world and the kingdom. A covenant is a binding of persons that creates an obligation deeper than the benefit either party receives from it. It does not last as long as it serves me. It lasts because I have given my word, and my word does not bend to whether the arrangement is currently rewarding. This is the shape of every covenant God makes, and it is not accidental that the Scriptures reach again and again for marriage as the picture of God's covenant with his people, because the covenant is the thing marriage is supposed to be. When God binds himself to Israel he does not say I will be

your God as long as you meet my needs. He says I will be your God, full stop, and then he keeps saying it across centuries of Israel's faithlessness, through the exile itself, which is the covenant tested to its absolute limit and holding anyway. The prophet Hosea was told to marry a woman who would betray him and to keep loving her through the betrayal, precisely so that his marriage would preach in the flesh what God's covenant love actually costs and actually endures. A contract could never survive Gomer. Only a covenant could, and only a covenant does.

This is why the recovery of marriage as covenant is not a private matter of personal happiness but a central act of the exile's witness. The exiles were told to build their marriages into Babylon as a permanent presence, and permanence is exactly what the surrounding culture can no longer produce or even picture. In an age of the provisional, where vows are understood from the start as revisable and the exit is always kept in view, a marriage that actually keeps its vows in plain sight, across decades, through the long stretches when it costs far more than it returns, is one of the loudest sermons a Christian household can preach. The neighbor who watches two people stay, and stay well, and stay tenderly, through the seasons when staying is hard and the culture would have long since counseled leaving, is watching something he cannot account for out of the resources of his own world. He is hearing the gospel preached in a language older and deeper than words, the language of a love that does not quit, which is the only language that can carry the news of a God who did not quit on us.

I want to steelman the contract, because it is not held only by the shallow or the selfish, and a pastor who cannot feel its pull has not been honest. The move from covenant to contract came dressed as compassion, and often it sincerely was. It came as a

rescue for people trapped in marriages that were crushing them, women with no power and no recourse, homes where the covenant language had been used as a cage and a weapon, where a demand for permanence had become a demand that the abused stay and suffer. Those were real evils, and the church too often defended the evils in the name of defending the vow, and the loosening was in part a righteous refusal to keep sacrificing human beings on the altar of an institution. I will not pretend the old arrangement was innocent. But name what was lost when we let the whole thing slide from covenant to contract, because the cost fell hardest on exactly the people the loosening was meant to protect. It fell on the children, who need the ground under them to hold. It fell on the poor, who cannot buy their way out of the instability the affluent can absorb. A culture of the disposable vow does not liberate the weak. It exposes them, because the strong were always going to be fine and the covenant was the one thing standing between the vulnerable and the full weight of the storm. To recover the covenant is not to recover the cage. It is to recover the shelter, and to insist, this time, that it never again be turned into a cage.

Catechized at the table

So the marriage holds, and out of a marriage that holds comes the home, and the home is where a child is either formed in a truer story than Babylon's or handed over to Babylon by default. And the forming happens less through instruction than through liturgy, less through what is said than through what is repeatedly done, because a child is a body before he is a mind, and the body learns what it practices.

Think concretely about what this means, because the letter is not asking for a mood. It is asking for practices, and the practices are ordinary to the point of seeming too small to matter, which is

precisely why they matter. The family meal, guarded and unhurried, a table where the phones are gone and the faces are present and the same people show up night after night to eat and talk and be known, is a liturgy, and it teaches a child, below the level of anything he could articulate, that he belongs to a body that gathers, that he is not a free-floating individual optimizing his own experience but a member of a household that eats together and therefore lives together. The world is teaching him the opposite all day, teaching him that he is a consumer alone with a screen, and the guarded table is a small daily contradiction of that lie, repeated until it is in his bones.

The prayers said together at the hinges of the day, in the morning and at the meal and at the edge of sleep, are the Shema's when you lie down and when you rise made into an actual practice, and they teach a child that time itself is held by God, that the day opens and closes in his presence, that we do not seize our hours but receive them. The reading of Scripture in the home, the family gathered around the actual words, not a devotional about the words but the words themselves, is the single most direct obedience to Deuteronomy six available to a parent, and it is the thing most Christian homes have quietly stopped doing, having outsourced it to a program at the church for one hour a week, which under Christendom might have been enough and in Babylon is not remotely enough, because one hour cannot compete with the thousand hours of the feed.

Family worship is the old name for this, and it is worth recovering the name along with the thing, because the thing has nearly died among us. For most of the church's history, and with particular seriousness among the people who took the covenant most to heart, it was simply assumed that a Christian household would gather, daily or near to it, to sing and to read the

Scriptures and to pray, that the father especially bore the responsibility to shepherd the souls under his roof, that the home was a little congregation and the table a little altar. This was not thought to be extraordinary piety. It was thought to be the ordinary shape of a Christian family, the baseline, the least a home could do. We have let it collapse into nothing, or into a hurried grace before a meal eaten in front of a television, and we have let it collapse in exactly the era when the surrounding culture stopped doing the work for us, which is a catastrophe of timing. The exile cannot afford it. In Babylon the family altar is not optional decoration on a faith carried by the culture. It is the front line of the faith's transmission, the place where the story is handed down or lost, and a household that will not gather to worship has already begun, quietly and with the best intentions, to hand its children to the empire.

I say all of this as a father, and I will not pretend to stand outside the undertow I am describing, because I feel the same current every Christian parent in this country feels, the pull to outsource the formation of my children to people and devices better funded and more relentless than I am, the exhaustion at the end of a day that makes the screen so easy and the gathered table so hard, the private hope that somehow the faith will pass to them the way it passed under an arrangement that no longer exists. I have handed my sons to Babylon's catechesis in a hundred small tired moments and called it giving them a break, called it giving myself a break, and the confession is not incidental to the argument. It is the argument. We did this. I did this. The formation of a child does not fail in one dramatic act of apostasy. It fails in the accumulation of ordinary surrenders, in the slow ceding of the table to the screen, one tired evening at a time, and the recovery of it will not come through one dramatic act of devotion either. It will come the same way it was lost, one

ordinary evening at a time, reclaimed.

The home as contrast society in miniature

What this builds, when it is built, is a home that is itself a small contrast society, and this is where the chapter connects to everything else the book has argued. Gerhard Lohfink gave the church a phrase for what it is meant to be in the world, a contrast society, a people whose common life is so unlike the surrounding culture that the life itself becomes the argument, and the household is that contrast society in its smallest and most fundamental form. A Christian home in Babylon should run on a visibly different physics than the world outside its door, so that a child grows up having tasted, in the most formative place there is, the shape of another kingdom before he ever has words for it.

A home where people are not consumed by their devices in a culture drowning in them. A home where the vows hold in an age that treats vows as provisional. A home where children are received as gifts and not as burdens or accessories or projects, in a civilization increasingly unsure whether they are worth the trouble. A home where forgiveness is practiced, actually practiced, parents asking children for forgiveness and children learning that reconciliation is possible, in a world that knows only grudges and cancellation. A home where the poor and the stranger are welcomed at the table, where hospitality is not entertaining but the actual opening of the household to people who cannot repay it, in a society organized around the closed door. A home like that does not need to lecture its children about the kingdom. It has let them live in the kingdom, in the one place a small child can be reached, and the child carries out into Babylon not merely a set of beliefs he was told to hold but a memory in the body of a way of life that was real, that he ate at, that held him, so that when he meets the kingdom again in

adulthood he recognizes it, because he was raised in a rehearsal of it. The home is not the delivery mechanism for a message about the faith. The home is where the faith is first lived, or first betrayed, and the child knows the difference long before he can name it.

Multiply and do not decrease

Which returns us to the sharp end of the command, the phrase that unsettles modern ears, multiply there and do not decrease, because it must be rescued from a counterfeit before it can be received as the gift it is. There is a politics loose in the church right now that hears multiply and do not decrease as a demographic strategy, a call to outbreed the opposition, to win the future by sheer numbers, to turn children into ammunition in a culture war and the family into a front line. That reading turns the womb into a weapon and the household into a factory for producing partisans, and it is not what the letter means and it is not what I mean, and it must be named and refused, because it poisons the very thing it claims to defend.

What God commands the exiles is not a demographic weapon. It is an act of hope. It is the refusal of a defeated people to give up on the future, the quiet defiance of households who keep believing the story is worth handing on even when the surrounding world has written that story off. The point is not to win Babylon by outnumbering it. The point is to refuse the despair that stops a conquered people from believing there should even be a next generation, to insist that a child is not a strategic asset and not a burden but a bearer of the image of God and a sign that we have not surrendered to the story that says tomorrow is not worth making. The natalism the letter commands is not the natalism of the culture warrior counting his troops. It is the natalism of hope against contraction, the

fruitfulness of a people who believe, against all the evidence their exile could muster, that the future belongs to God and is therefore worth populating with people who will love him.

And the earliest church understood fruitfulness in exactly this hopeful and not strategic way, and it is worth remembering how the church actually grew, because we have absorbed a false picture of it. The early church did not grow mainly by argument, and it certainly did not grow by conquest, because for three centuries it had no power to conquer anyone with anything. Rodney Stark ran the arithmetic and found that the astonishing growth of the church across its first three centuries, from a few thousand to something near half the empire, required no miracles of mass conversion at all, only a steady rate of increase sustained across generations, the kind of patient compounding growth that comes not from crusades but from ordinary faithfulness reproducing itself year over year. The church grew, in large part, the way the exiles were told to grow, through families, through the steady patient transmission of the faith from parents to children, one household at a time, unglamorous and decisive.

But it grew by something more than birth, and this is the detail that ought to stop us, because it shows what the command looks like when it is fully obeyed. The Roman world into which the church was born practiced the exposure of unwanted infants as a matter of course. A child not wanted, most often a girl, most often for being a girl, would be carried out and left on a hillside or a rubbish heap or beside a road to die of cold or hunger or to be taken by whoever might use her. This was not a scandal in that world. It was ordinary. It was legal. It was the assumed right of the father to decide which of his children would live, and the philosophers who wrote about the good life saw nothing wrong with it. Into that world came the Christians, and they went out to

the hillsides and the rubbish heaps and gathered up the infants the empire had thrown away, and they carried them home and raised them as their own children. They multiplied their households not only by birth but by mercy, refusing to let a child be discarded, treating every exposed infant as a bearer of the image of God whom the empire had failed to recognize. The Letter to Diognetus, written by some anonymous Christian in the second century to explain his strange people to a puzzled pagan, put the whole ethic in a line. Christians marry, he wrote, as all others do, and they beget children, but they do not expose their offspring. They do not throw away their young. In a world that discarded children, the church gathered them, and its fruitfulness was inseparable from its reverence for exactly the lives the empire counted as garbage.

I want the church to feel the full weight of what that did, because it is the pattern for us. The Christians did not save the abandoned infants as a political program to shift the demographics of the empire. They saved them because they served a Lord who had said let the little children come to me, because they could not look at a discarded child and see anything but a person God had made, and their inability to look away, multiplied across a hundred thousand households over three hundred years, quietly rebuilt the moral imagination of an entire civilization. The empire had taught the world that a child's life was the father's to spend or discard. The church taught the world, not by argument but by the sheer accumulated weight of gathered children raised in love, that every child belonged to God and could not be thrown away. That is what multiply and do not decrease looked like when the church actually did it. Not a strategy to win. A refusal to let a single life be counted as worthless, repeated until the world could no longer count lives the old way.

What decrease actually is

And there is a hard lesson buried in do not decrease that the exile church cannot afford to miss, which is that the church most often shrinks not through persecution from outside but through failed transmission within. We imagine our decline as something done to us, the pressure of a hostile age, the mockery of the cultured, the withdrawal of the culture's old support, and all of that is real. But the church does not mainly die of persecution. Persecution, historically, tends to concentrate and purify the church rather than kill it, because the blood of the martyrs, as Tertullian threw at the empire around the year two hundred, is seed. What actually decreases the church, quietly and without any drama, is a generation that holds the faith and fails to hand it on.

We have watched this happen in our own lifetime, and we have mostly refused to see it for what it is. We built congregations that kept their children endlessly busy with programs and entertainment, that mistook amusement for formation and attendance for discipleship, that assumed the faith would pass to the next generation automatically the way it had under Christendom, requiring no deliberate effort, no family altar, no catechism, no thick practice, only a nice youth room and a good band and a positive experience. And we watched those children grow up and walk away, not in rebellion mostly, not with any drama, but simply because they had been catechized far more deeply by the culture than by the church that had only entertained them, and when the two stories came into conflict the deeper formation won, as it always will. The child raised on a thousand hours of the feed and one hour of a games night in the church basement was formed by the feed. This was not mysterious. It was arithmetic.

The exile cannot afford that complacency, and the letter forbids

it. In a hostile age the faith passes to the next generation only where it is deliberately, lovingly, relentlessly transmitted, worked into a child by repeated patient strokes the way an edge is worked into steel, in the home first and most of all. A church that does not take the formation of its own children with deadly seriousness will not need to be persecuted out of existence. It will simply fail to reproduce. It will decrease, not with a bang and not with a purge, but one unformed child at a time, a slow quiet hemorrhage of a generation that was amused instead of catechized, and it will blame the culture for a wound it inflicted on itself by neglect. Do not decrease is not mainly a command about birthrates. It is a command about transmission, about whether the story survives the handoff, and the handoff happens at the table or it does not happen at all.

So the home is the seedbed of everything else the letter commands. It is not a retreat into the family and it is not the bunker, because the family formed rightly is not formed to hide but to send, to raise children who will carry a different story out into Babylon as the next generation of faithful exiles, the ones who will build the houses and plant the gardens and keep the vows in the decades after we are gone. Babylon is downstream of ten thousand kitchen tables, and so is the church that will outlast it. The letter knows this, and it grounds the whole vocation of exile in the humblest possible place, in a marriage that holds and a table that gathers and a child who is taught diligently when he sits and when he walks and when he lies down and when he rises.

But a home is not a fortress, and it was never meant to be, and the child who is formed rightly at the table is formed there precisely in order to be sent out from it. The family that turns inward, that pulls the walls close and forms its children only to

protect them, has misread the letter as badly as the family that hands its children to the screen, because the exiles were never told to build their households as bunkers against Babylon. They were told to build them, and then to open the door. The same letter that says take wives and raise children says, in the very next breath, seek the welfare of the city where I have sent you into exile. The home is the first outpost, but it is an outpost, which means it faces outward, toward a city that does not yet know the God who formed the people at that table. And so the question the letter asks next is the question that turns the whole household inside out. The children are being raised. The vows are being kept. The story is being handed down. For whose sake. Not only for the family's own. For the city's. And to that city, and its welfare, and the strange command to seek the good of the very empire that burned the temple, we turn now.

Chapter 12: Seek the Welfare of the City

Everything in the letter has been leaning toward this line, and now we stand under it. Build houses. Plant gardens. Take wives and raise children. Those were the preparations. This is the hinge on which the whole letter turns, the command that gathers the others up and gives them a direction, and it should still be able to knock the wind out of us the way it must have knocked the wind out of the first exiles who heard it read aloud in a foreign room. Seek the welfare of the city where I have sent you into exile, and pray to the Lord on its behalf, for in its welfare you will find your welfare. Not your own welfare. The city's. The flourishing of Babylon, the empire that broke the walls of Jerusalem and burned the house of God and marched you a thousand miles from everything you loved. Seek its good. Work for its thriving. Want it, actually want it, to prosper. This is not a thing anyone has ever said to a conquered people. It is the opposite of what every conquered people in the history of the world has wanted to hear. And it stands at the dead center of the Christian life in exile like a sun the other commands orbit.

We have to feel how scandalous it is before we have any hope of obeying it. The natural posture of an exile toward the city that took everything from him runs in one of two directions, and we have met both of them already in this book. Either he wants Babylon to fall, and he nurses the coming judgment like a coal in his chest, refusing to lift a single finger for the good of the place that humiliated him, waiting for the day the empire gets what it has coming. Or he wants into Babylon, and he envies it, and he is

quietly ready to trade his strange and costly identity for a comfortable seat at its table. Resentment or assimilation. The clenched fist or the open hand of surrender. God forbids both and commands a third thing that neither the bitter man nor the assimilated man can even picture. Pour yourself out for the good of the city. Make it more just, more whole, more flourishing, and do it precisely as a people who belong entirely to someone else. The exile is to be the best citizen Babylon has, not in spite of belonging to another kingdom but because of it, seeking the earthly city's welfare with a freedom that only those whose deepest hope lies somewhere the city cannot reach could ever manage.

The word translated welfare is shalom, and the whole command lives or dies on whether we hear that word at full strength or in the shrunken form we have handed down to each other. We have made shalom mean quiet. We have made it mean the absence of trouble, a private inner calm, the feeling of a candle and a soft chair after a hard week. That is not the word. Shalom is wholeness. It is the way things are supposed to be when they are finally right, a dense and textured flourishing that reaches into every corner of a common life and leaves nothing untouched. A city has shalom when the hungry are fed and the worker is paid what he is owed and the stranger can walk its streets without fear and the sick are tended and the old are not abandoned and the child is safe and the weak are not ground down under the heel of the strong. Shalom is the field where justice and mercy and truth and peace have all sat down together and refused to leave. To seek the shalom of a city is to seek all of that, the full flourishing of the actual place, for the good of the actual people who live in it, and not merely to carve out a quiet corner where you can practice your private religion undisturbed while the city rots around you. It is a public word. It is a demanding word. It sends

the exile out of his house and into the life of the city as an agent of its wholeness, and there is no way to keep it and stay behind the wall.

Walter Brueggemann spent a career reminding the church that the prophets never let shalom stay a feeling. He read it as a social vision, a picture of the whole community made right, and he insisted that the Bible measures shalom not by the contentment of the comfortable but by the security of the vulnerable. Where he is right, and he is right, the command to seek shalom cannot be satisfied by anything private. It reaches past the individual soul into the shape of a shared life. And so the exile who hears seek the welfare of the city and reduces it to keep your own head down and your own family safe has not obeyed a smaller version of the command. He has refused it, and dressed the refusal in the clothes of prudence.

James Davison Hunter gave this whole posture a name a generation ago, in a book that landed in 2010, and the name has stuck because it is exactly right. He called it faithful presence. He set it against the three failed postures the church keeps reaching for in a culture it no longer controls, and it is worth naming all three, because most of us are quietly living inside one of them without ever having chosen it. There is the defensive posture, the church that defines itself by what it is against, always braced, always at war, reading the city as a threat to be repelled. There is the relevant posture, the church so desperate to be accepted by the age that it files itself down until there is nothing left the age could object to and nothing left worth accepting. And there is the purity posture, the church that wants only to withdraw, to get clean and stay clean, to pull back from the contamination of the city and wait behind the wall. Defensiveness, relevance, and withdrawal. The fist, the mirror,

and the bunker. Over against all three Hunter set faithful presence, the slow, patient, committed labor for the genuine good of the actual place, carried out by people whose hope is anchored somewhere the place cannot touch and who are therefore free to love it without needing it to save them.

That last clause is the whole thing, and it is easy to read past it. Faithful presence is only possible for a people whose ultimate hope is not riding on the city. The moment your deepest security is bound up in Babylon getting better on your timeline, you cannot love Babylon. You can only use it, or fear it, or try to seize it. You will love it the way a man loves an investment, which is to say not at all. But the exile whose real city is elsewhere, whose foundations are somewhere no Alaric can sack, is freed from needing anything back from Babylon, and that freedom is the precondition of actually seeking its good. You have to stop needing the city to save you before you can spend yourself on saving it. This is the paradox that runs under the whole letter. The people least dependent on Babylon turn out to be the people most able to bless it.

Faithful presence is the freedom of a people who no longer need the city to be their salvation, and so are finally free to be its neighbor.

And then, having handed the exiles the hardest command in the letter, God attaches to it a promise so strange that it turns the whole thing from mere altruism into something surer and deeper. In its welfare you will find your welfare. He binds the flourishing of the exiles to the flourishing of the city so tightly that the two cannot be pried apart, so that when they seek Babylon's good they are, in the deepest sense available to them, seeking their own. This is not a bribe and it is not selfishness

with a halo painted on. It is a statement about how God has actually ordered the world he made. The people who pour themselves out for the good of the place they live in will find their own lives caught up in its flourishing, and the man who schemes to secure his own welfare while ignoring the welfare of the city is not only being disobedient, he is being a fool, because his welfare was never a thing separable from the welfare of the place God planted him. Seek the city's good and you will find your own waiting for you inside it. Hoard your own behind a wall and you will lose both, the city's and yours, because they were one welfare all along and you tried to split what God had joined.

I have watched the church make this exact split, and I have made it myself, and it is worth confessing before I go on, because the diagnosis in this chapter falls hardest on us. The American church, taken as a whole, has not been seeking the welfare of the city. It has been seeking its own welfare. Its own market share. Its own political muscle. Its own comfort and protection and the preservation of its institutions. It has too often looked at the actual city, with its actual poor and its actual strangers and its actual lonely people, and seen either a threat to be defended against or a mission field to be harvested, rarely a neighbor whose flourishing we were simply commanded to want. We built our buildings and guarded our budgets and fought our fights, and the one thing we were plainly told to do, to seek the good of the city and pray for its peace, we quietly left undone, and then we stood around wondering why our witness rang hollow and why the city did not believe for one minute that we loved it. The answer is not complicated and it is not comfortable. For the most part we did not love it. We used it, or we feared it, or we tried to rule it. And a city can always tell the difference between being loved and being managed.

Because the second half of the command exposes what the church actually does when it is only seeking its own survival. A church seeking its own welfare gathers. It draws people in, it grows the crowd, it fills the room, it counts. A church seeking the welfare of the city scatters. It sends people out, into the schools and the shops and the hospitals and the neighborhoods, to spend themselves for the good of people who will never join, never give, never show up on any tally the church keeps. The whole logic runs backward from what our metrics reward. And this is why the command is so hard for an institution to obey, because institutions are built to preserve themselves, and this command asks the church to spend itself on a city that offers nothing back except, in the mysterious economy of shalom, everything.

The command has a shape, and this is where the false comfort has to end, because the welfare of a city is never an abstraction and Scripture never once lets it stay one. When God tells the exiles to seek the shalom of Babylon, he is commanding something with a particular direction, something that leans, and it leans the same way the whole law and the prophets lean, which is down. The entire witness of the Scriptures insists that the health of a community is not measured at its top but at its bottom, not by the comfort of the powerful but by what is happening to the people who cannot defend themselves. Read the law God gave his people and you find him circling back, again and again, with a kind of holy stubbornness, to the same four figures. The poor. The stranger. The widow. The orphan. He names them as the test of whether a society is whole, the ones by whose treatment the whole edifice is weighed. You shall not wrong a stranger or oppress him, he tells them, for you were strangers in the land of Egypt. You shall not mistreat any widow or fatherless child. When you reap the harvest of your land you

shall not reap your field to its very border, but you shall leave the corners for the poor and for the stranger. The corners of the field belong to the people who have no field. That is what shalom looks like when it touches the dirt. And so to seek the welfare of the city is to seek, first and most particularly, the good of exactly the people the city is most tempted to overlook.

The God who wrote this letter is the same God who heard the cry of slaves in Egypt, and he has never once stopped bending toward the bottom of the world. That is not a sentimental add-on to his character. It is close to the center of how he has revealed himself. He is the God who hears the cry, and a people who claim that God while remaining deaf to the very cry he is famous for hearing have not understood the welfare they were told to seek. Seeking the shalom of Babylon means feeding its hungry, and defending its weak, and tending its sick, and welcoming its strangers, not as an optional program that the really committed church might get around to after the important work is done, but as the concrete form the command takes the moment it stops being a sermon and touches the ground. There is no version of seek the welfare of the city that skips the people the city has forgotten. The bias is not a suggestion. It is built into the word.

The early church understood this with a clarity that shamed an empire, and the way it sought the good of the very city that hunted it is the pattern the exile is handed. Rodney Stark, the sociologist who spent his career running the arithmetic on how a powerless minority conquered Rome from underneath, kept returning to the plagues, because the plagues are where the pattern shows plainest. When the great sicknesses swept the Roman world, the Antonine plague in the 160s and the plague that carries Cyprian's name in the 250s, and the cities filled with the dying, the pagan response was the rational one, the ancient

one, the one any of us might have chosen. You fled. You left the sick by the road, even your own, and you got out of the city, because to stay was very likely to die. And the Christians stayed. They nursed the sick, their own and their pagan neighbors alike, at appalling cost, and many of them caught the sickness and died doing it, because they served a Lord who had touched lepers and because they did not believe death got the last word in the story. A nursed body sometimes lives. And a pagan nursed back from the edge of death by a Christian who had no earthly reason on the ledger to sit by his bed does not forget who sat there. The city's welfare was served by exiles who had every reason to let it die and chose instead to spend themselves for its life, and the seeking was the loudest sermon the ancient world ever heard, louder than any argument, because you cannot argue with a person who is dying for you and does not hate you.

There is a particular poverty the exile is positioned to address in our own moment, and it is not the kind that shows up first when we hear the word poor, though that kind is real and pressing and never leaves. It is the poverty of isolation, the slow fraying of the bonds that once held neighbors to one another, the emptying out of the ordinary fabric of a shared life. Robert Putnam wrote the book that named this, *Bowling Alone*, published in 2000, and the image in the title has outlived the statistics because it caught something true. Americans still bowled, he found, more of them than ever, but they had stopped bowling in leagues. They bowled alone. And the leagues were only the visible edge of a vast withdrawal, the emptying of the clubs and the unions and the lodges and the congregations and the simple neighborly habits that had once knit the country together, all of it draining away until we live and age and increasingly die among strangers. The decades since Putnam counted have only cut the seam deeper. We are lonelier than our grandparents could have imagined

being, surrounded by more people and connected to fewer, and the loneliness is not a private sadness but a public sickness, one that hollows out the health of a whole society from the inside. Physicians now measure its cost in the body, in years taken off a life, in a mortality that rivals the older and more obvious killers. A city can be well fed and well housed and still be dying, and ours is dying of exactly this.

Into that fraying the command to seek the city's welfare drops with a fresh and almost embarrassing concreteness, because the remedy for isolation is not a policy the exile has to wait on the government to pass. It is a table. Be the neighbor Babylon forgot how to be. Learn the names on your own street, the ones you have lived beside for years and never asked. Open your table to people who have nowhere to be on a Tuesday night. Tend the lonely and the elderly and the overlooked, the widow three doors down, the old man whose children moved away, the young family drowning and too ashamed to say so, not as a program with a name and a budget but as the ordinary and unglamorous fabric of a life lived for the good of the actual place. The church, of all the institutions left standing in a country that has come apart at this seam, is almost the last one built to do this, a body organized around a shared table and a shared meal and the strange claim that strangers can become family. A city dying of isolation is a city whose shalom is precisely the thing the exile was sent to seek, and the exile who cannot be bothered to learn his neighbor's name has missed a mission field lying open on his own doorstep while he looked past it for something that felt more important.

Gerhard Lohfink argued that the church was meant to be a contrast society, a community whose common life is so unlike the world around it that the life itself becomes the argument, and

nowhere is that contrast more available right now than here, at the seam of loneliness, because the world has forgotten how to make what the church was built to make. The world can assemble a crowd. It can produce an affinity group in its sleep, a room full of people the market already sorted together because they were already alike. What the world can no longer produce is a room where people who have nothing in common but Christ sit down at one table and call each other family and mean it across decades, the old and the young, the rich and the poor, the ones the algorithm would never have put in the same room. That room, when it actually exists, is a miracle in a lonely age, and it is the most persuasive thing the exhausted world could stumble into, and it costs nothing but the willingness to stay long enough to become a real neighbor to a real person.

And this seeking belongs to neither political tribe, and it will be captured by neither, and that is precisely why the church has to recover it as its own before both sides finish tearing it in half. One tribe has taken the care of the poor and the stranger and made it a partisan program, a plank in a platform, until Christians who lean the other way learned to hear the whole biblical command as the language of the enemy and quietly set it down. The other tribe has taken the same care and made it a partisan suspicion, a soft-headedness to be guarded against, a thing that decent hard-nosed people are right to be skeptical of, until Christians who lean that way learned to feel righteous about their coldness. Between the two of them they have handed the whole church a permission slip to ignore half of what God plainly commands while feeling justified about the half it kept, each side pointing at the other's blind spot and never once at its own. The exile refuses the whole arrangement. He takes the entire command, the poor and the stranger and the neighbor and the widow and the lonely and the weak, not because a party told

him to and not against the party he distrusts, but because the God who sent him into the city told him to seek its shalom, and shalom has always had this shape and this bias, toward the bottom, toward the edges, toward the people the powerful look past. Seek the welfare of the city, honestly and with the whole Bible open, and you will find yourself, every single time, drawn first toward the very people the city has forgotten, and you will find that neither of the tribes was ever going to lead you there, because both of them had a reason not to.

I feel the pull of the tribes in my own chest, and I will not pretend I stand above it, because the man who thinks his politics have never once edited his Bible has simply not looked closely enough at the edits. I have caught myself reading past commands because they sounded like the other side, and reaching for commands because they flattered mine, and calling the whole compromised operation faithfulness. We did this. I did this. And the letter cuts under all of it, because Jeremiah was not writing to a party. He was writing to a people, and he told that people to seek the good of a pagan empire, which means the command was never going to line up neatly with any faction inside that empire or any faction inside ours. It sits above the whole quarrel and judges both halves of it, and the exile who has actually heard it will find himself politically homeless in exactly the way the gospel has always made its people homeless, too generous for one tribe and too demanding for the other, belonging finally to a city that does not appear on any ballot.

So the command has weight and it has direction and it has a bias built into its bones, and it asks the exile to do the one thing the resentful cannot and the assimilated will not, which is to spend himself for the flourishing of a city he does not control and will never own, bending first and always toward the people that city

forgot. But there is a danger in a command this active, and the letter knows it, which is why it does not stop with our hands. A man can seek a city's good for a while out of grim duty with the old bitterness still simmering underneath, doing the right thing with a poisoned heart, and that poison will eventually curdle everything it touches. The activism alone cannot save the one who does it. Something has to go to work not only on the city but on the exile himself, on the resentment he carries, on the heart that is tempted to serve Babylon while secretly hoping it burns. And the letter names that something in the very next breath. Seek the welfare of the city, and pray to the Lord on its behalf. The command does not end with our hands. It ends on our knees, in the hardest prayer in the whole Old Testament, the prayer that dismantles the exile's bitterness from the inside, the prayer for the peace of Babylon. That is the work that comes next, and it is the work that makes all the rest of it possible, because you cannot seek the welfare of a city for a lifetime that you have not first learned, on your knees and against every instinct you own, to love.

Chapter 13: Pray for the City

There is a second half to the sentence that we almost never reach, because the first half is so large that it uses up all our attention. Seek the welfare of the city where I have sent you into exile. We have spent a whole chapter on that, on the shalom of Babylon, on the strangeness of a God who commands the deported to want the good of the empire that deported them. And then, without a pause, in the same breath, the sentence keeps going, and adds a second command that we treat as a kind of pious appendix to the real work, a spiritual echo of the practical instruction. And pray to the Lord on its behalf. Seek the welfare of the city, and pray to the Lord on its behalf, for in its welfare you will find your welfare. Two commands, not one. Seek, and pray. And the second is not the decoration on the first. It is the engine of it.

I want to say plainly what I think we have done with that second command, because I have done it myself for most of my ministry. We have read it as the softer half. Seeking the welfare of the city sounds like work, and prayer sounds like the thing you do when the work is done, the closing benediction over the real labor, hands folded after the sleeves are rolled back down. And so we have quietly demoted the prayer to an afterthought, the spiritual seasoning on the practical meal, and in doing that we have gotten the whole letter exactly backward. Because the prayer is not the seasoning. The prayer is the fire under the pot. It is the interior practice without which the exterior seeking curdles, every time, into something the letter never authorized, into either the fighter's contempt or the assimilator's flattery, into

a seeking of the city's welfare that is secretly a seeking of my own. The command to pray is God's provision for the danger hidden inside the command to seek. He knew what would happen to a people told to seek the good of their enemy if that were the only thing he told them. So he told them a second thing. Pray for the city. And the praying is what makes the seeking possible at all.

Let me start with the thing I have found to be true and have found nowhere stated as bluntly as it deserves. You cannot go on hating a city you pray for by name every day. It is not possible. The hatred does not survive the praying. Set them side by side in the same soul and one of them dies, and if the praying is real and daily and specific, it is the hatred that dies, slowly, the way a fire dies when you stop feeding it. This is not a sentiment. It is a mechanism. It is one of the oldest and best-attested facts of the spiritual life, and it works whether you want it to or not, which is precisely why it is dangerous, and precisely why God commanded it to a people who had every earthly reason to want Babylon to burn.

Think about what it actually costs to pray for someone. Not to pray about them, which is easy, and which is mostly complaint dressed in religious clothing, the practice of informing God of the failures of people we have already condemned. To pray for them. To stand before God and ask him, sincerely, for their good. You cannot do that and keep the person at the safe distance that hatred requires, because prayer for another person is an act of the imagination before it is an act of the will. To ask God for someone's welfare you have to picture their welfare, and to picture their welfare you have to picture them, not as a category, not as the enemy, not as the empire, but as a person, or a street, or a family, a particular human good you are asking a particular

God to give. And the moment you picture them that way the abstraction cracks. The enemy stops being the enemy and becomes the neighbor two doors down whose son is sick, the coworker whose marriage is failing, the official whose fear you can suddenly see under his cruelty. Hatred needs the category to survive. Prayer dissolves the category into faces. And you cannot hate a face you are holding up to God and asking him to bless.

Prayer for Babylon is not first a way of changing Babylon. It is the way God changes the one who prays, until he can no longer tell his enemy from his neighbor, because before God they were never two different things.

This is the thing about the second command that the first command alone could never accomplish, and it is why God gave both. James K. A. Smith, reading Charles Taylor and the long tradition behind him, has spent a career reminding us that we are not primarily thinking things that occasionally act. We are loving things, formed by what we do repeatedly, shaped from the outside in by practices that work on us below the level of our conscious argument. He borrows the old word for those practices. Liturgies. A liturgy is a repeated action that trains a love, that forms the heart in a direction over time, that makes us into a certain kind of person not by convincing us but by rehearsing us. And Smith's whole point, the one the church after Christendom cannot afford to miss, is that the secular age is full of liturgies of its own, the scroll and the screen and the store, catechizing us all day into a certain vision of the good life, and that the only thing strong enough to resist a rival liturgy is a truer one. Prayer for the city is a counter-liturgy. It is the daily rehearsal that forms an exile into someone who can actually seek the welfare of an enemy, because it works on him underneath his politics, underneath his grievance, underneath the contempt the

culture war has trained into him, and slowly makes him into a person whose reflex toward the city is not the clenched fist but the open hand. You do not argue yourself into loving Babylon. You pray yourself into it, one day at a time, until the love is simply there, formed in you by the practice, and you find you cannot remember exactly when the hatred left.

I have watched this happen in my own chest, and I will not pretend it was theory to me before it was experience. There is a version of the pastor I was a decade ago who prayed about the country the way a man reads the news, scanning for confirmation of what he already believed, arriving at God with a list of the enemy's crimes and a request that God deal with them. That is not intercession. That is grievance with the head bowed. And what I have found, slowly, over years of trying to actually do what the letter says, to actually pray for the welfare of the specific city I have been planted in, is that the practice will not let you stay there. It keeps forcing the abstraction back into a face. You cannot pray daily for the schools without beginning to see the exhausted teachers instead of the ideology. You cannot pray daily for the officials without beginning to feel the weight they carry instead of only the harm they do. The prayer does not make you naive about the harm. It makes you unable to reduce the person to the harm, which is a completely different thing, and it is the exact thing the fighter has lost and the exact thing the letter is trying to protect.

Now I have to hold the other half of this up, because if I stop here I will have written a chapter that the letter does not license, a chapter about prayer as a technique for making us nicer to Babylon, and that is not what the exiles were commanded and it is not what the prophets modeled. Because the same Scriptures that command prayer for the city are full of prayer against the

city, prayer that names the city's evils and asks God to end them, prayer that does not soften the horror but holds it up to God at full volume. The exiles who were told to seek Babylon's shalom are the same exiles who sat down by the rivers of Babylon and wept, and wrote one of the most terrible prayers in all of Scripture, a psalm that begins in unbearable homesickness and ends in a curse so violent that we skip the last verses when we sing it. By the waters of Babylon, there we sat down and wept, when we remembered Zion. And a few lines later, addressed to the daughter of Babylon, doomed to be destroyed, blessed shall he be who repays you with what you have done to us. The prayer for the city and the prayer against the city are in the same book, sometimes in the same mouth, and any account of exile prayer that keeps one and loses the other has flattened the thing God actually asked for.

So let me say what I think intercession for Babylon really is, and why it takes both, and why the loss of either one produces a distortion. Intercession that holds blessing and resistance together is the only kind the letter authorizes, and it is much harder than either half alone, because each half is easy on its own and the difficulty is entirely in the holding. Blessing without resistance is flattery. It is the prayer of the assimilator, the exile who has decided that seeking the city's welfare means never naming the city's sin, who blesses Babylon so thoroughly that he can no longer see anything in it worth grieving, and whose prayers for the city are finally indistinguishable from Babylon's prayers for itself. That is not intercession. It is capitulation with the eyes closed. But resistance without blessing is contempt. It is the prayer of the fighter, the exile who names the city's sin so relentlessly that he forgets the city is also full of the beloved and the lost and the bearers of the image of God, whose prayers against Babylon have no warmth in them anywhere, only the

cold satisfaction of the prophet watching the fire fall. And that is not intercession either. It is hatred with a religious vocabulary. The letter forbids both by requiring both at once. You bless the city and you pray against its evils, and you do the two in the same breath, and the doing of them together is the whole discipline, because a heart that can hold real blessing and real resistance toward the same city at the same time is a heart that has been made, by long practice, to love the way God loves, who so loved the world that he grieved it, and so grieved it that he came to die for it, and never once for a moment pretended it was other than it was.

Consider how the prophets actually did this, because they are the masters of the thing, and they will not let us make prayer for the city into either sentimentality or spite. Jeremiah himself, the man who wrote the letter commanding the exiles to seek Babylon's welfare, is the same man who wept over Jerusalem until his eyes failed, the weeping prophet, the one who cried oh that my head were waters and my eyes a fountain of tears, that I might weep day and night for the slain of the daughter of my people. He did not weep because he approved of the city. He wept because he loved a city he had spent his whole life indicting. His tears and his indictments came from the same place. That is the pattern. The prophet is not the man who has chosen between loving the city and telling the truth about it. He is the man who has refused to choose, who loves it enough to tell the truth and grieves the truth enough to keep loving, and whose prayers therefore carry both the blessing and the resistance without either one canceling the other. Walter Brueggemann spent much of his life teaching the church to recover exactly this, the prophetic imagination that can hold grief and hope together, that can criticize the dominant order and energize an alternative one in the same act, and he was right that we have mostly lost it, that we have split the prophet in

two and kept the half we prefer. The comfortable church kept the blessing and lost the resistance. The angry church kept the resistance and lost the blessing. And the letter to the exiles will not let us keep either half alone.

I want to slow down on the mechanics of this, because it is one thing to say the exile must hold blessing and resistance together and another to actually do it on a Tuesday morning with a cup of coffee and a country that grieves you. What does it look like, concretely, to pray for a city that is also under judgment. It looks like naming the good you want for it and the evil you want ended, in the same prayer, without collapsing either one. It looks like asking God for the flourishing of the schools and the healing of the marriages and the peace of the streets, and in the same breath asking him to break what is breaking the poor, to expose what is being done to the vulnerable in the dark, to bring down the arrogance that grinds the weak. It looks like praying for the conversion of the very people whose policies you are praying against, holding their eternal welfare and your resistance to their present harm in the same hand, refusing to let your opposition to what they do curdle into a wish for their destruction. The Sermon on the Mount made this the specific test of whether you belong to the Father at all. Love your enemies and pray for those who persecute you, so that you may be sons of your Father who is in heaven. Notice that Jesus did not say stop calling the persecution persecution. He called it persecution in the same sentence. He named it as evil and commanded prayer for the ones committing it, and he made the two commands one, and he said that the doing of both together is what marks a person as a child of God, because it is what God himself does, who makes his sun rise on the evil and on the good and sends rain on the just and on the unjust. God's blessing falls on the city that crucified his Son. That is the pattern the exile is being formed into.

Blessing and resistance, held together, because that is how the Father loves a world that hates him.

Now I have to steelman the objection, because it is a serious one and I have felt its full weight, and it is not the objection of the lazy or the cynical. The objection goes like this. Is this not a recipe for passivity dressed up as piety. If I am praying for the city instead of fighting for it, am I not just baptizing my own retreat, comforting myself with the feeling of doing something while the actual evils go unopposed. The activist looks at the praying Christian and sees a man who has traded the picket line for the prayer closet and calls the trade holiness. And the objection has teeth, because it is true that prayer can be a hiding place, that we can and do use the language of intercession to excuse ourselves from the cost of action, that there is a false prayer which is really only a way of handing God our responsibilities and going back to sleep. I will not pretend that danger is not real. It is real, and I have used prayer that way, and so have you.

But here is what the objection misses, and it is everything. The letter does not offer prayer instead of seeking. It commands both, in the same sentence, and it puts them in an order that the objection reverses. Seek the welfare of the city, and pray to the Lord on its behalf. The prayer is not a substitute for the seeking. It is the interior life that feeds the public one, the root system beneath the visible tree, the hidden thing that determines whether the visible thing is alive or dead. Eugene Peterson spent his whole pastoral life resisting the reduction of the minister to a manager, the trading of the interior work of prayer for the exterior work of running a religious organization, and he understood that the two are not competitors but a single organism, that the public work of the church is only ever as deep

as the private prayer beneath it, and that a public ministry with no interior life is a cut flower, bright for a few days and already dying. The person who prays for the city is not the person who has stopped working for it. He is the only person whose work for it will not eventually poison him, because his public seeking is being continually purified by his private praying, drained of its self-interest and its contempt and its need to win, and returned to him each morning as something closer to love. Take away the prayer and the seeking does not become more effective. It becomes more dangerous, because now it is unwatered by the interior life, and a public zeal with no private prayer beneath it is precisely the thing that has produced every Christian atrocity in history, the crusade and the pogrom and the auto-da-fé, faithful men doing terrible things to the city in the name of God with no interior life left to tell them they had become the very evil they set out to fight.

That is the deepest reason for the second command, and it is worth saying as clearly as I can. The interior life is the guardrail on the public life. A church that seeks the welfare of the city without praying for it will, sooner or later, seek the city's welfare on its own terms, according to its own vision, by its own methods, and will end by imposing on the city a good the city never asked for, which is how the seeking of shalom becomes the machinery of coercion, how the love of neighbor becomes the tyranny of the improvers. The prayer is what keeps the seeking humble. It is the daily admission that I do not finally know what is best for this city, that its welfare is in the hands of a God who is not me, that I am an instrument of a shalom I did not design and cannot control. The one who prays for the city every morning is reminded every morning that he is not the city's savior. And that reminder is the only thing that has ever kept the church's love for the world from turning into the church's

domination of it.

So the captive becomes something the empire never expected and could not produce, and it is the deepest thing this chapter has to give you. The captive becomes a priest for the city. Think about what a priest is, in the oldest sense, the sense the whole Old Testament is soaked in. A priest is a person who stands in the gap, who represents the people to God and God to the people, who carries the community before the Lord in intercession and carries the Lord's word back to the community, who bears the names of the people on his heart into the holy place. The high priest of Israel wore the names of the twelve tribes on his breastplate, twelve stones engraved with twelve names, so that he carried the whole people over his heart every time he entered the presence of God. And the astonishing thing the exile discovers, the thing that turns the whole catastrophe inside out, is that the deported people of God become, in Babylon, the priests of Babylon. Not the priests Babylon appointed, worshipping Babylon's gods. The priests Babylon never knew it had, carrying the pagan city on their hearts before the God the city did not worship, standing in a gap the city did not know existed, interceding for a people who would have laughed at the idea that these particular captives were praying for them by name.

This is the vocation Peter names when he writes to the exiles of his own day, the Christians scattered across Asia Minor, and calls them a royal priesthood, a holy nation, a people for God's own possession. He is not handing out an honorary title. He is describing a function. The whole people of God, the entire scattered dispersion of resident aliens, has become a priesthood, which means every one of them stands in the gap for the world around them, carries the neighbors and the city and the empire

before God in intercession, does for the watching pagans the one thing the watching pagans cannot do for themselves, which is to be prayed for by someone who knows the living God. The captive is not a victim of Babylon. The captive is Babylon's priest, its intercessor, the hidden reason the wrath is held back and the mercy runs, standing between the city and the judgment it has earned, asking God for a welfare the city has done nothing to deserve. Abraham stood before the Lord and bargained him down over Sodom, will you sweep away the righteous with the wicked, suppose there are fifty righteous within the city, and God let a doomed city's fate hang on the intercession of one man who loved it enough to argue with God for it. That is the priestly vocation of the exile. To be, in Babylon, the Abraham who stands before the Lord and pleads for a city that does not know his name is being spoken over it in the dark.

And this priesthood is not glamorous and it does not photograph and it will win no election and it will draw no crowd, which is exactly why it is the work the church after Christendom is being handed back. When the water held us up we did not need to be priests for the city, because the city was more or less us, and the intercession went unnoticed because it seemed unnecessary. Now the city is not us, and the gap has opened wide, and into that gap the exile is called to stand, not with a lever, not with a vote, not with a program, but with a name on his heart and a prayer in his mouth, doing for the city the deepest thing that can be done for it, which is to hold it before the God who made it and loves it and grieves it and has not yet given it up. Rodney Stark spent years working out why the early church grew through three centuries of powerlessness, and the answers he found were the visible ones, the nursing of the plague-stricken, the rescue of the exposed infants, the honor given to women and the poor. But beneath every visible mercy there was an invisible one, the

church at prayer for the very empire that was killing it, the intercession that no historian could measure because it left no record except the changed lives of the ones who prayed and, over three hundred years, the changed empire that could not finally withstand a people who kept asking God to bless it.

I have to be honest about where this leaves me, and where I suspect it leaves you, because the demand of it is enormous and I do not stand over it. To pray for the city daily, by name, with blessing and resistance held together, as a priest standing in the gap for people who despise the God I am pleading to, is not a thing I do naturally or do well. My prayers still curdle into grievance more often than I want to admit. I still catch myself informing God of the enemy's crimes when I meant to intercede for the enemy's soul. The interior life is the hardest work there is, precisely because no one sees it and no one applauds it and there is no metric that will ever tell you it is working, and a man formed by an age of platforms and numbers is starved for exactly the kind of confirmation the prayer closet will never give him. But I have come to believe that this hidden and unglamorous and unmeasurable work is the actual foundation of everything else the letter commands, that the building and the planting and the marrying and the seeking are all cut flowers without it, bright for a season and already dying, and that the church that will still be here in a hundred years will be the church that recovered the interior life, that learned again to be a priesthood for a city that does not know it is being prayed for, that stood in the gap and refused to leave it.

So pray for the city. Not about it. For it. Pray for the actual streets you drive and the actual schools your neighbors send their children to and the actual officials whose names you know and whose policies you resist, and pray for their welfare and against

their evils in the same breath, and let the praying do to you what only praying can do, which is to make you, slowly and against your will, into someone who can no longer hate what he has been asking God for years to bless. The interior life will feed the public life or the public life will die. The priest will stand in the gap or the gap will stand empty. And the exile who learns to pray for Babylon discovers, somewhere in the years of doing it, that he has been changed more than the city has, that the command to intercede was God's mercy to him before it was ever God's mercy to Babylon, that he set out to bless a city and was himself blessed in the blessing, exactly as the letter said he would be, for in its welfare you will find your welfare.

But there is a hard edge waiting here that this chapter has kept its distance from, and I have to name it before I hand you off, because the prayer for the city has a limit, and the limit is the whole subject of what comes next. You can seek Babylon's welfare and pray for Babylon's good with your whole heart, and there will still come a day when Babylon asks you for the one thing you cannot give it, when the city that you have blessed and prayed for and served commands you to bow. And on that day the priest who has loved the city has to become the confessor who defies it, and the two are not in tension, they are the same faithfulness meeting a different demand. The man who prayed toward Jerusalem with his windows open, three times a day, in the very administration of the empire he served so well, was the same man who would not stop when the law commanded him to stop, and he took the lions' den as the price of the open window. Daniel is the exile who shows us where the prayer for the city ends and the refusal to bow begins, and how a single life can hold both, and how the interior life we have been describing is the only thing that makes the coming defiance possible, because a man who has not been praying in secret will not have the

strength to refuse in public. We have learned to pray for Babylon. Now we have to learn the one thing we will never do for it.

Chapter 14: Do Not Bow

Everything in this book so far has been an argument for staying. Build the houses. Plant the gardens. Take the wives, raise the children, seek the welfare of the city, pray for the empire that burned your temple. Every one of those imperatives pushes the exile deeper into Babylon, further into the life of a place that is not his home, closer to neighbors who worship other gods. And a reader who has followed the argument this far, who has felt the pull of the whole letter toward involvement and rootedness and love of the city, ought to be feeling, right about now, a certain vertigo. Because if you push seek the welfare of the city far enough, and give yourself to the place with enough of your heart, there comes a point where seeking its welfare and belonging to it become hard to tell apart. There is a line out there somewhere, past which faithful presence quietly becomes assimilation, past which loving Babylon becomes bowing to Babylon, and the letter has not yet told us where it is. This chapter is the guardrail. It is the one command that keeps all the others from carrying us over the edge.

The letter does not contain the guardrail explicitly. It is the whole rest of the exile story that supplies it, and it supplies it in a single man, in two scenes, one at the top of an empire and one at the bottom of a furnace. His name was Daniel, and he is the exile who did both of the things this book keeps insisting can be done at once. He served Babylon brilliantly, and he would not bow. Not one without the other. Not the withdrawer who keeps his soul by keeping his distance, and not the assimilationist who joins the city by losing his soul, but the third and harder thing,

the man who poured his whole competence into the running of a pagan empire and, at the exact same time, drew a line he would die before he crossed. Daniel is the answer to the vertigo. He is what it looks like when seek the welfare of the city and do not bow are held together in one life, for a lifetime, without either one canceling the other.

Watch the serving first, because we tend to rush past it to get to the dramatic part, and the serving is half the point. Daniel was a teenager when the Babylonians tore him out of Jerusalem and dropped him into the imperial capital. They gave him a Babylonian name, Belteshazzar, named for a Babylonian god. They gave him a Babylonian education, the entire curriculum of the empire that had destroyed his nation, the literature and the language of the Chaldeans. They groomed him for the administration of the very regime that had ended his world. And he took it. He learned the curriculum. He entered the service. He became, over the course of a long life, one of the most effective public servants in the empire, so gifted at the actual work of governing that king after king, dynasty after dynasty, promoted him. Nebuchadnezzar raised him up. Belshazzar reached for him in a crisis. When the Persians conquered Babylon and everything should have changed, Darius the Mede kept him and set him over the whole kingdom, and the text says the reason was not his religion but his competence. An excellent spirit was in him, and he was faithful, and there was no error or fault found in him. Daniel was so good at serving the empire that the empire could not do without him across three regime changes and the better part of seventy years.

This is not a footnote to Daniel's faithfulness. It is Daniel's faithfulness, the seek-the-welfare-of-the-city half of it, lived out at the highest level of the pagan state. He did not serve

grudgingly, with one foot out the door, doing the minimum required to survive. He served with excellence, the way Jeremiah's letter and the whole theology of vocation demand, because for the person who belongs to God there is no such thing as secular work, and the administration of Babylon was as much the place of Daniel's obedience as the temple in Jerusalem would have been. He sought the shalom of an empire that was not his, and he sought it with everything he had, and the empire was genuinely better for having him in it. That is the man the second scene has to be read against. The refusal to bow, when it finally comes, does not come from a resentful outsider looking for a fight. It comes from the most loyal and competent servant the kingdom had.

Then comes the line. Daniel is an old man now, at the top of the Persian administration, and his rivals cannot find a single thing to accuse him of, because there is nothing there, no corruption, no negligence, no fault in his public work at all. So they do the only thing left. They go to the king and they get a law passed, a beautiful trap, that for thirty days no one in the empire may petition any god or man except the king himself, on pain of the lions' den. They have found the one place where the loyal servant will not comply, the seam between serving the empire and worshipping it, and they have written a law that forces him to stand on one side of it in public. And watch exactly what Daniel does, because the precision of it is the whole lesson. When Daniel knew that the document had been signed, he went to his house where he had windows in his upper chamber open toward Jerusalem. He got down on his knees three times a day and prayed and gave thanks before his God, as he had done previously.

Read that slowly, because every phrase is load-bearing. The

windows were open. He did not go to a back room and pray in secret, hedging, keeping the letter of his faith while avoiding the cost of it. He did not, on the other hand, march into the public square and pray in the king's face as a provocation, staging a confrontation, making a spectacle of his defiance. He simply went home and did what he had always done, on his knees, at the window, toward Jerusalem, in plain sight, three times a day, exactly as before. The phrase as he had done previously is the hinge of the entire scene. Daniel does not escalate and he does not retreat. He keeps the practice he already had. The empire has drawn a line through the middle of his ordinary devotion and told him to stop, and he does not stop, and he does not put on a show of not stopping either. He just keeps praying, with the windows open, and lets the law do to him what the law is going to do.

This is the shape of the refusal, and it is worth naming precisely because the American church gets its shape so badly wrong. Daniel's no is embedded inside an enormous yes. He says yes to Babylon in ten thousand ways, yes to its work and its service and its welfare, faithfully, competently, for decades. And then, at one point, on one thing, he says no, and the no is total, and it costs him the lions' den, and he does not flinch. The vast yes is what gives the small no its weight. A man who says no to everything about Babylon is just a malcontent, and the empire can dismiss him. A man who says yes to everything is just assimilated, and he has nothing left to refuse with. Daniel is neither. He is the servant who has earned the right to be believed when he finally will not comply, because everyone who has watched him for forty years knows he is not looking for a fight, and knows that if this man will not bow, the thing he will not bow to must be a genuine god.

Serve the city with everything you have, and worship it

with nothing. The line between those two is the whole of faithfulness in exile, and Daniel is the man who walked it for seventy years without once losing his footing on either side.

The other scene is his three friends, and it hands us the sentence that is, I think, the deepest thing exile ever taught the people of God about faithfulness. Nebuchadnezzar has set up a golden image on the plain of Dura and commanded that when the music plays, everyone in the empire fall down and worship it. Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego, Daniel's companions, three more brilliant young administrators of Babylon, will not fall down. The king, enraged, hauls them in and gives them one more chance and adds his taunt, and who is the god who will deliver you out of my hands. Their answer is one I want to render exactly, because it is one of the few places in Scripture where you can watch faith and uncertainty stand in the same breath without either one canceling the other. If this be so, our God whom we serve is able to deliver us from the burning fiery furnace, and he will deliver us out of your hand, O king. But if not, be it known to you, O king, that we will not serve your gods or worship the golden image that you have set up.

But if not. Three words, and they contain the entire structure of costly faithfulness. Our God is able to deliver us, they say, and we believe he will. And then, without a pause, without softening the first claim, but if not, if he does not, if the furnace takes us, we still will not bow. The refusal is not conditional on the rescue. They do not say we will not bow because we are sure God will save us, which would make their courage a calculated bet on the outcome. They say we will not bow whether God saves us or not, because the bowing is wrong regardless of what it costs, and our obedience is not a wager on being spared. That is the difference

between faith and its counterfeit. The counterfeit obeys God because it expects a payoff and would reconsider if the payoff failed to arrive. The real thing obeys because God is God, and holds the obedience steady even into the fire, even if the fire is the last thing it ever feels. But if not is the sentence that makes a martyr, and it is the sentence the comfortable church has almost entirely forgotten how to say.

Now I have to turn the whole thing around and let it fall on us, because we have read Daniel for generations and we have gotten him precisely backwards. We have made Daniel a hero of personal purity, a man who kept himself clean, and we have used him to justify exactly the withdrawal the letter forbids. But Daniel did not withdraw. Daniel was up to his elbows in the governance of a pagan empire, seeking its welfare with everything he had, and refusing only to worship it. The American church has managed, with real ingenuity, to reverse both halves of him at once. We bow to the very things Daniel would not bow to, and we refuse the very city Daniel gave his life to serve. We got Daniel backwards, and getting Daniel backwards is a fair summary of what has gone wrong with us.

Consider what we bow to. We bow to the nation, first and most obviously, in the parts of the church that have fused the cross with the flag so completely that they can no longer tell which one they are actually worshiping, that end their prayers asking God to bless the country and mean, by the country, something very close to the kingdom itself. That is the golden image on the plain of Dura, and a great many of us fall down when the music plays and do not even notice we have knelt, because the image is draped in enough of our own history and our own affection that bowing to it feels like piety. We bow to the market, next, in the parts of the church that have quietly accepted the whole logic of

consumer capitalism as the water we swim in, that measure a ministry by its growth the way a business measures a quarter, that have let the categories of the brand and the platform and the market share colonize the imagination of the people of God until we can barely think a thought about the church that a marketing department would not recognize. And we bow, most of all and most invisibly, to the self, to the sovereign little voice that Robert Bellah heard in the woman he called Sheila back in 1985, the self that has become the final court of appeal, so that even our faith has quietly reorganized itself around the question of whether it works for me rather than the question of whether it is true. Nation, market, self. Three golden images, and the church that will not stop talking about how the culture is bowing to false gods has, in many rooms, fallen down before all three.

The reversal completes itself in the part that indicts us most. While we are busy bowing to the things Daniel refused, we have refused the thing Daniel did. We have declined to seek the welfare of the city. Whole segments of the church have decided that the neighbors are the enemy, that the city is Babylon in the worst sense, a thing to be feared and fought and walled off, and have pulled back their investment and their love and their labor from the common good, seeking the welfare of the church and letting the city fend for itself. We have inverted Daniel entirely. He served the empire and would not worship it. We worship the empire, in the forms of nation and market and self, and will not serve it. He gave Babylon his competence and withheld his knee. We give Babylon our knee and withhold our competence. If you wanted to design the exact photographic negative of a faithful exile, you could hardly do better than a large part of the contemporary American church, and I say that as a member of it, implicated in the diagnosis, having caught in my own chest the reflex to bow to at least two of those three images while telling

myself I was standing up straight.

So the practical question presses in, and it is the question this chapter exists to answer. If the line between serving the city and worshiping it is the whole of faithfulness in exile, and if the line is not always obvious, how does the exile actually see it. How does Daniel know that administering the empire is faithful service and bowing to the image is idolatry, when both of them, from a distance, look like cooperation with Babylon. What is the faculty that tells the difference, and can it be learned. Because the honest truth is that the line does not announce itself. The golden image on the plain of Dura was obvious, a single dramatic moment with music and a furnace, but most of the bowing the modern exile is asked to do is nothing like that. It is gradual, ambient, dressed as ordinary participation, a thousand small accommodations no one of which feels like idolatry, which is exactly how assimilation actually happens, not in one apostasy but in ten thousand unnoticed concessions that add up, over a generation, to a church indistinguishable from the world it was sent to serve.

The faculty that sees the line has a name, and the name is discernment, and discernment is not a mood or an instinct but a skill, and it is a skill the church cannot survive after Christendom without. In Christendom you did not need much of it, because the culture did your discerning for you. The water ran in a roughly Christian direction, so a person could drift with the current and end up more or less where a Christian should be, and the sharp work of telling the kingdom from the world could be left mostly undone, because the gap between them was narrow and the culture kept nudging you back toward the right bank. That is over. The current now runs the other way, and a church that drifts will drift straight into the sea, and the only thing that

will keep an exile oriented is the deliberately trained capacity to tell, in a specific situation, the difference between serving the city and bowing to it. That capacity does not come naturally and it does not come cheap. It has to be built, and the building of it is one of the central tasks of the long after.

What has to be discerned, most urgently, is the set of lenses we did not choose and cannot see, the ones the culture ground and slipped over our eyes so early that we mistake them for our own vision. Charles Taylor spent eight hundred pages describing one of them, the immanent frame, the way the modern person experiences the world as closed and flat and disenchanted, a universe of matter and mechanism with God pushed out to the edges, and his point that lands hardest is that this is not a belief we hold but a lens we see through, and that it shapes the believer as much as the unbeliever. James K. A. Smith, reading Taylor for the rest of us, keeps pressing the same uncomfortable point, that we are all breathing this air, that even our faith has gone thin and buffered and immanent, that we believe in God the way we believe a fact rather than dwelling in him the way the saints did. The lens is invisible precisely because it is a lens and not an object. You do not see your glasses. You see through them. And an exile who has never once taken his glasses off and examined them has no way of knowing which of his convictions are the gospel and which are simply the shape the immanent frame pressed his faith into. Discernment begins there, in the strange and difficult act of catching your own inherited lenses in the act of distorting, of asking, of a given assumption you have always taken for granted, whether it came from Scripture or whether it came from the water.

This is why theological depth is not a luxury for the exile but a survival skill, and I mean survival in the plainest sense. A

shallow faith cannot discern. It has nothing to discern with. It knows a few slogans and a worship set and a handful of convictions it absorbed from its subculture, and it has no way of telling which of those convictions are the faith once delivered to the saints and which are the residue of the last political cycle or the ambient assumptions of its class, because it has never gone deep enough into the tradition to have a standard by which to measure. The exile who wants to see the line between serving and bowing needs to know the Scriptures, the whole arc of them, well enough to be corrected by them where his culture has bent him. He needs the creeds, the long memory, the company of the dead that Chesterton called the democracy of the dead, the two thousand years of the faithful who were not buffered and can therefore see what we cannot. He needs enough theology in his bones that when the golden image is set up, in whatever draped and plausible form it takes in his moment, something in him recognizes it as an image and refuses to kneel, even when everyone around him is kneeling and calling it common sense. Depth is not decoration on the faith. In exile, depth is the thing that keeps you from bowing, and a church that neglects the formation of deep disciples is not staying neutral. It is training its people to kneel before every image the age erects, one undiscerned assumption at a time.

And this is finally why the two halves of Daniel have to stay together, because either one without the other collapses into a failure the exile cannot afford. Serving the city without the refusal to bow is straightforward assimilation, the church dissolving into the world it was sent to bless, so busy seeking Babylon's welfare that it forgets it belongs to Someone else and ends up worshiping what Babylon worships. But the refusal to bow without the serving is its own catastrophe, and it may be the more seductive one for the frightened church right now. It is the

posture of the exile who keeps his purity by keeping his distance, who draws his lines and defends his boundaries and refuses every accommodation, and in the process refuses the city itself, withdrawing his love and his labor and his prayers from the common good in the name of not being contaminated. That exile has kept his knee unbent and his hands empty, and he has disobeyed the letter as surely as the assimilationist, because the letter did not send him into Babylon to stay clean. It sent him to seek the welfare of the place, which cannot be done from behind a wall. Daniel is the rebuke to both. He would not bow, and he would not withdraw. He held the no and the yes in the same life, the total service and the total refusal, and it is the holding of both at once, the impossible-looking union of deep involvement and unbending distinctness, that is the actual vocation of the church in exile, and the reason it is so rare is that it is so hard.

I want to leave you standing where Daniel stood, at the open window, because that image carries the whole of what this chapter has tried to say. The windows are open toward Jerusalem, which means his heart is fixed on a city that is not this one, a home he belongs to that Babylon cannot touch. But the man at the window is not looking out at a place he refuses to serve. He is the second most powerful man in the empire, on his knees, in the middle of his ordinary life of governing a city he has poured himself into, praying toward his true home three times a day exactly as he always has, and about to pay for it in the den of the lions and not caring what it costs. That is the exile the whole book has been building toward. Present, fully, in the life of the place. Faithful, completely, to the God of the home he actually belongs to. Serving Babylon with everything, and bowing to it with nothing, and holding both until the day he dies old and honored in a foreign land with his soul entirely intact.

Which raises the last question, the one that carries us into the final part of this book. Daniel could do it because Daniel was formed to do it, because there was something in him deep enough and rooted enough to recognize the golden image and refuse it while everyone else knelt. Where does a people like that come from. Not a person, a people, because the three in the furnace did not stand alone, they stood together, three of them refusing at once, and Daniel himself came out of a community that had been forming exiles for generations before he was born. A single heroic individual is not a strategy. The question is how you grow a whole people who can serve the city and will not bow to it, a community formed deeply enough that its members recognize the images the age erects and decline to kneel, not by their own private strength but because they belong to a body that has trained them to see. That people has existed before. It existed for three centuries in the heart of an empire far more hostile than ours, with no power and no standing and nothing but the strange irresistible quality of its common life, and it did not merely survive there. It converted the empire that was killing it. Before we can be that people again, we have to go back and look at how they did it the first time, the church before the empire, the powerless minority that out-lived and out-loved the Rome that fed it to lions, because everything the exile needs to know about how to live in the long after was already worked out, at cost, by the people who lived it before us.

Chapter 15: The Church Before the Empire

There is a fact about the church that ought to reorganize how the frightened American Christian thinks about the future, and almost no one says it out loud, because it embarrasses the whole model of power we have been operating on for sixteen centuries. The most explosive growth in the entire history of Christianity happened when the church had no political power at all. Not a little. None. It could not pass a law. It could not seat a magistrate. It could not close a shop on the sabbath or open a school with a prayer or count on a single institution in the known world to defer to it or even to leave it alone. It was illegal for most of three hundred years, and slandered the whole time, and periodically hunted, and its people met in borrowed houses and in the tunnels under the city and were burned in gardens and thrown to animals in front of crowds who had paid to watch. And across three centuries of exactly that, it went from a few thousand terrified followers of an executed Galilean laborer to something near half the population of the Roman Empire. It conquered Rome from underneath, before Constantine ever lifted a finger, and it did the conquering with nothing that we would recognize as strength.

We do not want this fact, and I understand why. It indicts us. Because if the church grew fastest with the least power, then the power we have spent a generation grieving was never the engine we told ourselves it was, and the loss we are mourning is not the loss of the thing that made us fruitful. It is the loss of the thing that let us be lazy. We did this, and I did this, and I want to say it

plainly before I say anything else. We looked at the receding water and concluded that the church could not live without it, and the first three centuries stand up in the record and tell us, quietly and without heat, that we are wrong, and that we have the story of our own family exactly backward.

Let me start where the honest historians start, which is with the arithmetic, because the numbers turn out to be less miraculous and more sobering than either the triumphalist or the skeptic wants them to be. The sociologist Rodney Stark sat down late in the last century and did something the pious rarely bother to do. He ran the math. The question is simple. How do you get from a handful of Jewish believers in the year 40, a movement so small it could have fit in a large room, to the tens of millions of Christians that the empire plainly contained by the early 300s, on the eve of Constantine. And the answer, Stark showed, does not require a single mass conversion, not one stadium filled, not one emperor's decree, not one of the sudden spectacular ingatherings we imagine when we picture the ancient church exploding across the world. It requires a growth rate of around forty percent a decade. That is the same rate sociologists have measured, in our own time, in vigorous new religious movements that spread person to person, household to household, with no advertising and no state behind them. Forty percent a decade, which is to say something close to three or four percent a year, sustained without a break for almost three hundred years. That is all. That is the whole engine.

Sit in how ordinary that number is, because the ordinariness is the point. Forty percent a decade is not a revival. It is not a wave. It is what happens when a community grows the way a family grows, when a group of people so loves one another and so welcomes the stranger that the group is a little larger every year

than it was, and it keeps being a little larger, patiently, relentlessly, for ten generations. The early church did not detonate. It compounded. And compounding, unlike detonation, cannot be faked and cannot be hurried and cannot be produced by a platform or a program. It can only be produced by a kind of life, sustained over a very long time, that keeps drawing people in faster than death and hostility can carry them out. So the real question is not the arithmetic. The arithmetic is settled. The real question is the one Stark spent his career on, the only one that matters. Why. Why did this odd, powerless, hunted minority keep compounding through the worst an empire could do to it, when by every worldly measure it should have been stamped flat a dozen times over.

The answer is not the one we would choose for ourselves, and that is exactly why it is worth hearing. It was not strategy, because they had no strategy in any sense we would recognize. It was not messaging, because they controlled no channel and every channel that existed was against them. It was not cultural power, because they had less than any group in the empire. It was that they lived in a way the empire could not explain, and they died in a way the empire could not explain, and the inability to explain them was itself the most persuasive thing the ancient world had ever run into. When you cannot account for how a people lives, you begin, against your will, to want the thing that accounts for it. The church did not win the argument of the ancient world. It became the argument. And the two great proving grounds where it became the argument were the plagues and the discarded children, so let me take you into both, because they are where the abstraction turns into blood.

Twice in those centuries a pestilence came through the empire that broke it, and the historians who study the ancient world now

think these plagues did more to remake Rome than most of its wars. The first arrived in the 160s, carried home, the sources suggest, by soldiers returning from the eastern campaigns, and it is called the Antonine plague after the emperor whose reign it wrecked. It burned through the cities for fifteen years and killed, by the careful estimates, somewhere between a quarter and a third of the population wherever it fully landed. The physician Galen, the most famous doctor in the world, fled the city of Rome when it came, which tells you all you need to know about what the finest medical mind of the age thought could be done. Then, in the 250s, it came again, worse, a second great mortality that the sources describe in a way that makes your stomach turn, bodies in the streets, whole households emptied, the living too few and too frightened to bury the dead. It is called the plague of Cyprian, after the bishop of Carthage who lived through it and wrote about it, and Cyprian described a disease that came on with fever and bleeding and rotting extremities and a stench that emptied the houses of everyone who could still walk.

Now understand what the ordinary, rational, decent response to such a thing was, because the Christians did not do it, and the not-doing is the whole story. When the plague came to a city, you left. If you had means, you fled to the country and waited for it to pass. And if you could not leave, you did the other rational thing, which was to put distance between yourself and the sick, even the sick in your own house. The pagan sources and the Christian sources agree on this with a rare and terrible unanimity. People threw the half-dead into the roads while they were still breathing and left them there. They abandoned parents. They abandoned children. Not because they were monsters, but because everyone knew that to nurse a plague victim was very often to catch the plague and die, and self-preservation is the oldest law there is, and the old gods offered no reason to break it

and no hope on the far side of breaking it. To stay was to die, and so, sensibly, terribly, the ancient city in a plague evacuated its own compassion along with its own bodies.

And the Christians stayed. That is the fact around which everything else in this chapter turns, and it is not legend, because we have it from the mouths of the men who watched it happen, some of them hostile witnesses. When the sickness filled the cities, the Christians did not flee. They stayed, and they nursed the dying, their own first, and then, unforgettably, their pagan neighbors, the very people who on a normal day despised them and on a bad day might inform on them. They carried water to the fevered. They cleaned the filth of the dying. They held the hands of strangers whose own families had run. They buried the dead that no one else would touch. Bishop Dionysius of Alexandria, writing in the middle of the third century in the teeth of the second plague, described his own people going to the sick without a thought for the danger, taking the illness into their own bodies from the ones they were tending, dying in the place of those they nursed, and he called it, without a flicker of irony, the equal of martyrdom, this drawing of another's death onto oneself. A century and more later the emperor Julian, who hated the church and spent his short reign trying to revive the dying paganism against it, wrote a bitter letter to a pagan priest complaining that the Galileans, as he called them, had grown so strong precisely because they cared for everyone's sick and everyone's poor and everyone's dead, while his own side cared for no one's, and he ordered the pagan temples to start copying the Christians, and it did not work, because you cannot decree the thing that only love produces.

Consider what that steady, stubborn nursing actually did, not spiritually but arithmetically, because it did something

arithmetical that folds right back into Stark's numbers. Basic care, even without medicine, even without any understanding of what caused the disease, saves lives in a plague. A person with a raging fever who is given water and kept clean and simply not abandoned will survive at a far higher rate than a person left alone in a doorway. So the Christians, by staying, did not only witness. They lowered their own death rate below their neighbors', because they cared for their sick instead of running from them, and they raised the survival rate of every pagan they nursed, and every one of those nursed pagans got up from a bed they should have died in and walked back into a city that had thrown them away, carrying in their body a debt they could not stop thinking about. A pagan nursed back from the edge by a Christian who had no earthly reason to sit at his bed, who by every law of self-interest should have been miles away in the clean country air, does not forget who stayed. He wants to know what kind of God makes a person do that. The plagues, which should have thinned the church faster than anything, instead filled it, because in the exact hour when the old gods proved they were nothing, the followers of the crucified one proved that their God was real by dying for people who were not even their own.

They had no power, so they had only their lives. And in a plague, when everyone else was saving theirs, the church spent its lives, and the spending was the sermon the empire could not answer.

Then there were the children, and this one is harder to look at, but it belongs in the record, because it is the second great place where the church's ordinary life indicted the empire's. The Roman world practiced what it called exposure, and we should not soften the word. When a child was born that the father did not want, most often a girl, or a child that was sickly, or simply

one more mouth in a poor house, the child was carried out and left. Left on a hillside, at a crossroads, on a rubbish heap outside the city walls, to die of cold or hunger or animals, or, and this is worse, to be gathered up by someone who collected exposed infants to raise for the slave markets and the brothels. This was not a crime and it was not a scandal. It was legal, it was common, it was assumed. We have a letter, preserved in the dry sand of Egypt, from an ordinary husband away on business, writing home to his pregnant wife with casual affection about the household accounts, and in the same breath, in the same untroubled tone, he tells her that if the child she is carrying turns out to be a girl, she should expose it. That is the water the ancient world swam in. The discarding of unwanted children was so normal that a man could mention it between a greeting and a grocery list.

And the Christians went out and gathered them up. In a world that threw its infants away, the church walked out to the hillsides and the refuse heaps and the crossroads and took the abandoned children home and raised them as its own sons and daughters. It refused, absolutely and from the beginning, to expose its own children, so that Christian households did not thin out the way pagan households did, and it took in the children the pagans had discarded, so that Christian households grew by mercy on top of growing by birth. The earliest Christian writings outside the New Testament say this flatly, as a mark of the faith. The document we call the Didache, a little manual of the faith from very near the apostolic age, lists among the plain commands of the two ways, you shall not murder a child by abortion, nor kill it when it is born. The Letter of Barnabas says the same. This was not a fringe position or a later development. It was there at the root, a bright and immovable line, and it had a demographic consequence that fed straight back into the forty percent, because

a community that welcomes every child and discards none, in a world that discards its children as a matter of course, will simply grow faster than the world around it, generation over generation, even if it never converted a single adult. The church out-loved the empire at the very edges of life, where the empire was cruelest, and the love was fruitful in the most literal way there is.

It ran further than the plagues and the infants, into the whole ordinary shape of a life together that the empire had no category for. In a world that treated women as property to be handed between fathers and husbands and used and set aside, the church gave women honor, and gave widows a real place and a real support instead of destitution, and gave marriage a dignity and a permanence and a mutuality it had not had, so that even hostile observers noticed how the Christians treated their women, and women came into the church in numbers that alarmed its enemies. In a world sorted with brutal precision by class and blood and legal status, the church did the thing that no one else in antiquity did. It sat the slave and the master down at one table, gave them the same bread and the same cup, called them both brother, and meant it, and a slave could rise to lead a congregation that contained his own master in the pews. There is nothing else like this in the ancient world. The empire had its clubs and its guilds and its associations, but every one of them gathered people who were already alike, sorted by trade or class or city of origin. Only the church gathered people who had nothing in common but the crucified Lord, the freedman beside the senator's wife beside the dockworker beside the runaway slave, and made of them a single family, and that room, which the empire could not produce and could not explain, was a kind of miracle sitting in plain sight in a hundred cities.

Someone put all of this into words near the middle of the second

century, an anonymous Christian writing to a puzzled pagan official named Diognetus who wanted to understand what these people actually were, and the little letter he wrote is one of the loveliest things to survive from the early church, and it names the exile condition with a precision that could have been written this morning. Christians, he wrote, are not distinguished from the rest of humanity by country or language or custom. They do not live in cities of their own or speak a strange dialect or follow an eccentric way of life. They live in their own countries, but only as sojourners. They share in all things as citizens, and they endure all things as foreigners. Every foreign land is to them a homeland, and every homeland a foreign land. They are in the flesh, but they do not live according to the flesh. They pass their days on earth, but their citizenship is in heaven. They obey the established laws, and in their own lives they surpass the laws. They love everyone, and by everyone they are persecuted. And then the line that ought to be carved somewhere every anxious Christian will see it. What the soul is to the body, the writer says, Christians are to the world. The soul is spread through all the members of the body, and Christians through all the cities of the world. The soul dwells in the body but is not of the body, and Christians dwell in the world but are not of the world.

Resident aliens. Sojourners. That is not a metaphor the church invented in a season of decline to comfort itself. It is the settled self-understanding of the church at the very height of its powerlessness and the very height of its growth, and it is drawn straight from the apostles, who assumed it as simply the truth of what the church now was. Peter opens his first letter by addressing the Christians scattered across the provinces of Asia Minor with a phrase that yokes two words we would never dare to yoke. He calls them elect exiles of the dispersion. Chosen, and homeless, in a single breath. Not chosen and therefore

comfortable. Not chosen and therefore in charge. Chosen precisely as exiles, elect precisely as strangers, and a few lines on he tells them how the elect exile is to live in a hostile city, and it is the whole strategy of the church before the empire compressed into a sentence. Beloved, I urge you as sojourners and exiles to abstain from the passions of the flesh, which wage war against your soul. Keep your conduct among the Gentiles honorable, so that when they speak against you as evildoers, they may see your good deeds and glorify God on the day of visitation. There it is, exactly what the plagues and the infants and the one table actually accomplished, prophesied by an apostle before it happened. They will slander you. Let them watch you live. Let the life be so plainly good that the slander cannot survive the watching, until the very people speaking against you are driven to glorify the God who makes people live like this.

That is the whole method, and it has a name in the New Testament, and the name tells you everything about what kind of method it is. The Greek word is *martyria*, witness, and you can hear our word martyr sitting inside it, because in those centuries the two words became one thing. Witness is what you do when you cannot coerce. You cannot make a watching world believe. You cannot legislate the kingdom into a human heart. You cannot conquer your way to a single genuine conversion, because a forced faith is not faith at all. So you do the only thing left to a people with no lever, which is to live the truth out loud, in public, at whatever cost it exacts, and to trust God with a result you can no longer manufacture. Witness is the weapon of the powerless. It was the only weapon Jesus ever actually authorized, and it turned out to be, by an enormous margin, the most effective force in the history of the world, because it converted an empire from the floor of its own prisons.

And so we come to Tertullian, the fierce North African lawyer who became one of the church's first great Latin voices, writing around the year 197 while the persecutions were still very much on, addressing the Roman authorities directly in a defense of the faith, and throwing at them a single sentence that has never once lost its edge. The blood of the martyrs, he wrote, is seed. He meant it as a taunt and as a fact, and it was both. Every time you kill us, he was telling the empire, you plant us. We multiply the more you cut us down, because the watching world cannot look away from the way we die, and it cannot stop asking the question our dying forces on it. What could a man possibly possess that would let him go to the animals like that, singing, without hatred for the crowd and without fear of the beasts. In the ordinary economy of the world, killing a movement kills it. The empire understood killing. It was superb at killing. And it discovered, to its bafflement, that this particular movement grew from its own executions, that the arena where it meant to end the church became the church's most persuasive pulpit, because a Roman who came to jeer at the deaths of the Christians sometimes went home unable to stop thinking about them, and some of those went looking, quietly, for the thing that could make a human being die that way, and found it, and were baptized, and in time died that way themselves. The blood was seed. Tertullian was not being poetic. He was reading a demographic fact off the floor of the Colosseum.

I have to stop here and steelman the objection, because there is a serious one, and the church that quotes these stories at itself for comfort usually refuses to hear it, and it deserves better than that. The objection goes like this. You are romanticizing weakness. You are telling a frightened church a bedtime story about the powerless early days in order to make it feel noble about its losses, and you are quietly leaving out the part where power,

when it finally came, brought real and enormous goods. When Constantine and then Theodosius made the faith legal and then established, the killing stopped. The exposed infants eventually became illegal to expose, because Christians with power outlawed the thing that Christians without power could only rescue people from one child at a time. The gladiatorial games were ended, the hospitals were built and endowed at scale, the universities were founded, slavery was, over long and shameful centuries, finally named as the evil it was and abolished, and none of that was done by a powerless minority nursing the sick in a plague. It was done by a church that had gotten its hands on the levers and pulled. So do not stand there, the objection concludes, and tell me powerlessness is the church's true condition, when the greatest and most lasting mercies in the history of the West were purchased precisely by the power you are teaching me to despise.

I hear that, and I will not wave it away, because most of it is simply true, and a church that pretends power did no good is telling itself a different lie in the opposite direction. Power did real good. The end of exposure was a mercy no amount of private rescue could equal. The hospital, an institution the ancient world did not possess, is a Christian invention made possible by Christian resources and Christian influence, and it has saved more lives than every plague nurse of the third century combined. I am not going to insult the memory of those goods. But look hard at the sequence, because the sequence is the whole answer to the objection. The church did not earn its moral authority by holding power. It earned its moral authority by three centuries of powerless love, and then it spent that authority, once power came, to write mercy into the laws. The witness came first. The lever came second, and the lever only did good to the exact degree that the witness had already formed a people who

knew what mercy was for. When the sequence reverses, when a church reaches for the lever before it has done the long, costly, unglamorous work of witness, before it has become the kind of people the plague and the hillside would have proven them to be, the lever does not produce mercy. It produces a Christianity indistinguishable from a voting bloc with a worship band, a tribe that has learned to command obedience and forgotten how to compel by love. The objection is right that power did good. It is wrong about which came first, and getting the order right is the difference between the church that converted Rome and the church that, some centuries later, would need converting itself. Witness earns the authority. Authority, if it comes at all, is meant to be spent, not hoarded, and it is only ever safe in the hands of a people who did not need it to be faithful.

And that is precisely the church that is being handed back to us, whether we wanted the gift or not. We are being returned, after a very long detour, to the condition in which the church has always been most fully itself, the condition it was born in, the condition of the elect exile with no lever and no deference and no water underneath, holding nothing but the truth and a life visibly bent by it and a willingness to bleed if the bleeding comes. We have been so afraid of losing our power that we forgot the plain fact of our own origin, which is that the power was never the thing that made us fruitful, and the first time around we did not have it, and its absence was not the wound the church overcame. It was the soil the church grew in. A church that cannot coerce has to convert. A church that cannot buy loyalty has to earn it. A church that cannot call down the magistrate on its enemies has to call down nothing on them but the sheer unanswerable weight of its own astonishing life, and then trust God with what that life does in the watching heart. This is not the emergency setting of the church. Look at the arithmetic. Look at the plague. Look at the

hillside. This is the church running at full strength.

I do not say any of this from a safe distance, and I will not end the chapter pretending I stand outside the fear I am describing. I came up in the era of platform and reach and metrics, and I wanted every bit of it, and I told myself the wanting was zeal for the kingdom when a good deal of it was only the cultural Christian in me grieving the water he was raised to assume. I have caught myself, more times than I want to confess, measuring the health of the church by exactly the instruments the empire uses to measure everything, the size of the room, the reach of the message, the standing in the culture, the access to the levers, and calling that stewardship. And the early church stands over the whole of it and asks me the question I do not enjoy. When the plague came to your city, would they have found you at the bedside or on the road out of town. When the child was on the hillside, would you have gone out into the cold to gather it up, or would you have decided, sensibly, that it was not your problem and not your risk. Those are the only questions that ever built anything, and no amount of power answers them, and no amount of powerlessness excuses me from them. We spent so long assuming the water that we let the muscles of witness go slack, and now the water is gone and we are discovering how weak we let ourselves become, and the discovery is a mercy, because a church cannot begin to recover a strength it still believes it does not need.

So the fact stands where I began, and it will not be argued away. The most explosive growth in the history of the faith happened with no political power at all, among a hunted minority that nursed its enemies in the plagues and gathered its enemies' children off the hillsides and sat slave and senator at one table and went to the animals without hatred, and grew forty percent a

decade for three hundred years on nothing but the unanswerable argument of a life the empire could not explain. That church did not need Christendom. Christendom did not exist yet. That church needed only to be itself, exposed and powerless in the heart of a pagan world, and to be itself was enough, more than enough, enough to bury the empire that fed it to lions. We are being handed that church back. We should take it like the gift it is.

But the story does not end with the church rising through the empire, and I would be lying to you if I let this chapter close on the triumph, because the triumph is where the danger begins. The church that had no power got power, at last, in the fourth century, and then it did the thing the exiles were always warned against. It began to confuse the two cities. It began to believe that a Christian empire was the point of the whole story, that God had crowned history with a baptized Rome, that the kingdom and the empire had fused into one glorious and permanent thing that could never fall. And then, in the year 410, the unthinkable happened, and the eternal city was sacked in three days of fire, and a whole civilization went into shock, and the church's faith buckled, because if a Christian Rome could fall, then what exactly had God promised, and what exactly had we been standing on. Into that grief an aging bishop in North Africa sat down to write the book that pried the two cities apart with both hands, while the ash was still falling and the barbarians were already moving toward the walls of his own town. We turn now to him.

Chapter 16: Augustine Watches Rome Fall

In the year 410, in the third week of August, the impossible happened. Alaric and the Goths came over the walls, and for three days the city of Rome burned, and the civilized world went into the kind of shock you go into when a parent dies, even an old and failing parent, even one you have watched decline for years, because some part of you had quietly believed they would always be there. Rome was the eternal city. Rome was more than eleven hundred years old, counting from the founding the Romans themselves dated to 753 before Christ, and in all that time no foreign enemy had breached her walls. Eight hundred years earlier a band of Gauls had gotten in, and the memory of it had haunted the Roman imagination ever since as the one great humiliation, and now it had happened again, and this time it was worse, because this time Rome was supposed to be under the protection of a different and higher God. For thirty years the empire had been officially Christian, ever since Theodosius made the faith the religion of the state in 380. The cross flew over the legions. The old temples were shuttered or converted. And then the barbarians were in the forum, and the churches were the only buildings Alaric ordered spared, and the grief was total, and out of the grief came two accusations, and the church is still answering both of them.

The first accusation came from the pagans, and it was the more obvious one. This is your fault. Rome was strong, they said, when Rome honored the old gods, when the sacrifices were offered and the temples were kept and the ancient rites that had

guarded the city for a thousand years were performed on schedule. Then you Christians came, and you talked her out of them, and you closed the temples and silenced the augurs and told the whole world that the gods who had made Rome great were nothing but demons and stone. And now the gods have withdrawn their protection, exactly as anyone might have predicted, and the barbarians are in the streets, and the blood is on your hands. It is a coherent argument. It has the shape of every argument that has ever blamed a catastrophe on the abandonment of the old ways, and it was persuasive precisely because it fit what everyone already half-believed, that the health of a city and the favor of its gods were the same thing, and that to change the second was to gamble with the first.

The second accusation is the one we forget, and it is the one that ought to concern us more, because it came from inside the church. A great many Christians in 410 were privately devastated for the opposite reason, and their faith was buckling under the weight of it. They had come to believe that a Christian empire was the point of the whole story. They had watched the faith go from the catacombs to the throne in a single century, from Nero's torches to Constantine's basilicas, and they had drawn the natural conclusion, which was that God had been building toward this all along, that the entire arc of history had bent toward a baptized Rome, that the kingdom of God and the Roman empire had fused into one glorious permanent thing that would carry the gospel to the ends of the earth and the end of time. The Christian poets had said as much. Eusebius, the great historian of the church, had all but crowned Constantine as the earthly image of the divine, had written of the Christian empire as if it were the visible arrival of the promises. And now the permanent thing was on fire. And if a Christian Rome could fall to a pack of Arian barbarians, then what exactly had God promised, and what

exactly were they standing on, and had they believed a lie.

Into that double grief, an aging bishop in a provincial North African port sat down and wrote the book that should be the constitution of every Christian who has ever lived after Christendom.

Augustine of Hippo was fifty-five years old when Rome fell, and he had been a bishop for thirteen years already, and he was, by any measure the world uses, a small figure in a small place. Hippo Regius was a working harbor town, not a capital. Augustine was not in Rome, had spent only a few years of his life there decades before, and he learned of the sack the way everyone in the provinces learned of it, from refugees, from rumor, from the ships that came into the harbor carrying people who had lost everything and wanted someone to tell them what it meant. He had come to the faith late and hard, out of a young manhood he would spend the rest of his life confessing, out of the fashionable philosophies and the ambitions and the appetites of a clever man who had wanted every good thing except the one that mattered. He knew from the inside what it was to build a life on things that could not bear the weight. And when the whole world came to his door asking why the eternal city had proven not to be eternal after all, he did not offer them comfort. He offered them a book, and the book took him thirteen years to write, from 413 to 426, twenty-two volumes of it, and it is called *The City of God*, and the argument at the heart of it is one idea that cuts the panic off at the knees.

There are, Augustine said, two cities. They have been intertwined since the very beginning, since Cain and Abel, since before there was a Rome or an Israel or any nation at all, and they will stay intertwined, tangled together in the same families and the same streets and sometimes the same heart, until the end

of the age when God finally sorts them out. And what makes them two cities is not their borders, because they have no borders, and not their citizens' passports, because their citizens carry the same passports as everyone else. What makes them two cities is two loves. The line is one of the most quoted sentences the man ever wrote, and it deserves to be quoted in full. Two loves have made the two cities. The earthly city was made by love of self reaching even to contempt of God. The heavenly city was made by love of God reaching even to contempt of self. That is the whole taxonomy. Not Christian nation against pagan nation. Not West against barbarian. Two loves, running through the middle of everything, building two cities that will not be untangled until the end.

And this is what that did to the grief in the harbor. Rome, Augustine said, was the earthly city. Rome had always been the earthly city. Rome had been built, gloriously and impressively and with real virtues that Augustine was careful to honor, by the love of self and the lust for glory and the will to dominate that he called the *libido dominandi*, the drive to rule, which had made her great and would in the end unmake her as it had unmade every empire before her. And this was true, Augustine insisted, even after 380, even with the cross over the legions, even when the emperor knelt at the altar. Baptizing an empire does not change the love that built it. Rome was never the City of God. Not for one day. Not even at the height of the Christian empire, not even when Theodosius did public penance before Ambrose and the whole world marveled that a bishop could bring an emperor to his knees. The earthly city can be improved, restrained, made less cruel, and Augustine thought it should be. But it cannot be converted into the City of God by an edict, because the City of God is not a territory that can be conquered or a government that can be reformed. It is the whole company

of all who love God, across every nation and every century, most of whom Rome had never heard of and never would.

Do you see what he is doing. Do you see that it is exactly our problem. The Christians of 410 had made precisely the mistake we have made. They had fused the faith with its political and cultural establishment so completely, so unconsciously, that when the establishment fell they could not tell it apart from the falling of God. And Augustine pried the two apart with both hands, while the ash was still falling, while the refugees were still weeping in his church, and he told them the hardest and most freeing thing anyone could have told them. The thing that has fallen is not the thing you were promised. The empire was the scaffolding. The City of God is the building. The scaffolding was never load-bearing for the faith, it only ever looked that way, and now that it has come down you can finally see the building underneath it, which no Alaric can breach, because it is not made of walls.

Rome was never the City of God. So the fall of Rome is not the fall of God. Learn that lesson now, while it is only your country shaking, and you will not lose your faith when it finally gives way.

I want to be honest about how strange and how brave this was, because we read Augustine through sixteen hundred years of him having won the argument, and we forget what it cost to make it in 413. It would have been so much easier to give the people what they wanted. He could have told the pagans they were wrong on their own terms, that Rome fell because she had not been Christian enough, that a purer Christian empire would have held. He could have told the grieving Christians that this was a temporary setback, that God would restore the empire greater

than before, that the barbarians were a chastisement to be endured before the glory returned. Both of those were available. Both of those were, in a sense, more pious, more patriotic, more comforting. And Augustine refused both, because both of them made the same error, the error of tying God's promise to Rome's survival, and he had come to see that this error was not a small mistake at the edge of the faith but a poison at its center, a thing that would make the faith unlivable the moment the empire failed. So he took the harder road. He told a grieving people that the city they were mourning had never been their true city, and that their true city was safe, and that the difference between those two things was the difference between a faith that could survive history and a faith that history could kill.

I have to name the objection at its strongest, because the objection is old and it has teeth. Was Augustine not simply teaching people to abandon the world. Was this not the beginning of a long Christian indifference to the actual welfare of actual cities, a spiritualized retreat that let believers watch the empire burn with their arms folded because their real city was elsewhere. There have been serious people who read him that way, and the charge cannot be waved off, because the withdrawal we warned about in an earlier chapter can quote Augustine as easily as the suitcase can quote Paul. But read him closely and the charge collapses. The same Augustine who said Rome was not the City of God also insisted that the two cities, for now, share a common life, use a common peace, and that the citizens of the heavenly city are to make use of the earthly peace and even to work for it, to want Babylon's welfare precisely because their own pilgrimage runs through it. He was not telling the church to stop loving the city. He was telling the church to stop worshipping it. He was severing the idolatry, not the love. And those are opposite operations, though the frightened heart

confuses them, because it is only when you stop needing the city to be your salvation that you become free to love it without terror, to seek its good without staking your soul on its survival. Augustine did not teach the church to watch Rome burn with folded arms. He taught it to watch Rome burn without losing its faith, which is a completely different thing, and the only posture from which anyone has ever been able to help a burning city instead of merely dying with it.

This is the deep continuity between the man in the harbor and the letter we have been reading for sixteen chapters, and it is worth saying out loud, because Augustine is Jeremiah's student even though nine hundred years lie between them. Jeremiah told the exiles that Babylon was not their home and never would be, and in the same breath told them to seek its welfare and pray for its peace. Augustine told the Romans that the empire was not the City of God, and in the same breath told them to use its peace and labor for its good. Both men are doing the identical thing. Both are refusing the two easy answers at once. Both are severing the false hope, the fantasy that the earthly city is the ultimate thing, and in severing it, freeing their people to love the earthly city rightly, as a place and not as a god, for as long as God keeps them in it. The exile who has learned Jeremiah's lesson and the Roman who has learned Augustine's are the same person, and the freedom they share is the freedom this whole book has been trying to describe, the freedom of a people whose deepest hope is fixed somewhere no barbarian can reach.

The Scriptures were saying this long before Augustine gathered it into a system, and he knew it, and he leaned on them at every turn. The writer of Hebrews had said it with a kind of ache, of the patriarchs who died still waiting. These all died in faith, not having received the things promised, but having seen them and

greeted them from afar, and having acknowledged that they were strangers and exiles on the earth. And then the sentence that Augustine might as well have taken for his title. Here we have no lasting city, but we seek the city that is to come. There it is, the two cities, sitting in the New Testament three centuries before the bishop was born, the settled conviction of the whole people of God that we are travelers here, that our papers are provisional, that no city built by human hands has foundations that will hold. Paul had said the same to the Philippians, writing from a prison in the empire whose citizenship he legally held and did not finally trust. Our citizenship is in heaven, and from it we await a Savior, the Lord Jesus Christ. Not our citizenship will be in heaven someday. Is. Already. Now. While Rome still stood and Paul still carried its papers, his true city was elsewhere, and he knew it, and it made him free in a Roman jail in a way his jailers could not comprehend.

And behind all of it stands the oldest word, the one the exiles heard from Jeremiah and the Romans heard from Augustine and we are hearing now. The word to a defeated people that their defeat is not the end of their God. When Jerusalem fell in 587 before Christ and the temple burned, the natural theological conclusion, the one the surrounding nations drew about their own defeated gods, was that the God of Israel had lost, had proven weaker than the gods of Babylon, had been dragged off in chains with his people. And the prophets said no. They said the fall of the temple was not the fall of God, that God had not been defeated but had used Babylon as the rod of his own purpose, that he was as present in the ashes of Jerusalem as he had ever been in its glory, and more. The whole theological achievement of the exile was learning to say that sentence and mean it. Our city has fallen and our God has not. Augustine said it again in Latin in 413. We are saying it in English now. The

building is not the scaffolding. The kingdom is not the country. The fall of the one is not the fall of the other, and the people who cannot tell them apart will lose their faith on the day the scaffolding finally comes down, and the people who can tell them apart will not.

There is a detail at the end of Augustine's life that I cannot get out of my head, and I have saved it for the end of the chapter because it carries the whole weight of everything I have been trying to say. Augustine did not die in a peaceful old age in a stable world. He died in the year 430, twenty years after the sack of Rome, and by then the barbarians were no longer a distant rumor from the capital. They were at his own gates. The Vandals, another Arian Germanic people, had crossed from Spain into North Africa and swept across the province burning as they came, and in the last months of Augustine's life they laid siege to Hippo itself. The old bishop lay dying inside a walled city with an enemy army camped outside it, watching, in his final weeks, the visible undoing of the entire Roman order he had lived his whole life inside. Refugees crowded the town. The countryside was in flames. Everything he had ever known was coming apart within sight of his deathbed, and this time it was not a story carried by ships from far away. It was outside the wall.

And he died in peace.

His biographer Possidius, who was there, who knew him, tells us that Augustine spent his final days having the penitential psalms of David written out and hung on the wall where he could see them from his bed, and that he wept over them, and prayed, and asked to be left alone with God in the last stretch, and that he died on the twenty-eighth of August in 430 with the Vandals still at the gates and the fever taking him and his mind entirely his own. He was not calm because he was too old to understand

what was happening. He understood it better than anyone alive. He was calm because he had spent thirteen years teaching himself and everyone who would listen that his city, his real city, was not the one under siege. The Vandals could take Hippo. They could burn his church and scatter his people and reduce the whole province to ash, and they very nearly did, and within a year of his death the city fell. But they could not touch the city he actually belonged to, because that city has no walls for an army to breach and no gates for a siege to close, and its walls, in the words of the psalm he loved, are salvation, and its gates are praise. The man who had told the whole world that Rome was not the City of God got to prove, on his own deathbed, with the barbarians in sight of his window, that he had believed it all along.

That is the freedom on offer to us. I want to be careful how I say this, because it is not the freedom the frightened church keeps asking for. It is not the freedom of a church that wins, that turns it all around, that gets the water back and the deference back and the old central seat at the table. Augustine did not get any of that. He died and his city fell and the empire he was born into passed out of the world within a lifetime. The freedom on offer is a stranger and better thing than winning. It is the freedom of a church that has stopped confusing the burning empire with the indestructible kingdom, and can therefore watch the smoke without despair, and can keep loving a city that is dying without dying inside when it dies, and can get back to the only work that was ever actually ours, the work of loving the God whose city has no walls to breach. A church that has that freedom cannot be defeated, because the one thing that could defeat it, the loss of the earthly city it had mistaken for the kingdom, has already happened, and it turned out not to be fatal after all.

We should learn this now, on purpose, before we are forced to. That is the whole reason to look at Augustine in a book about the American church. He learned the lesson in the hardest possible school, with the actual barbarians at the actual gate, and he had the seventeen years between the sack of Rome and his own death to work it all the way down into his bones so that when the siege came he was ready. We are not, most of us, being besieged. We are watching a slower thing, a draining rather than a burning, the quiet withdrawal of a cultural establishment rather than the sudden arrival of an army. And that slowness is a mercy, because it gives us time Augustine barely had, time to do the pulling-apart now, calmly, while it is still only our country shaking and not the last hour of our lives, so that we sever the idolatry before the crisis instead of during it. Learn to tell the empire from the kingdom now, while the telling is a matter of study and not of survival, and you will not have to learn it in a panic later, when the scaffolding is coming down around you and there is no time left to figure out that it was only ever scaffolding.

Because the temptation, once the scaffolding is gone and the fear has passed, is to rush immediately to rebuild something. To gather the survivors and count them and ask how we make our numbers strong again, how we build a tribe sturdy enough to hold its ground against the world that no longer holds us up. And that instinct is not wrong to want strength. It is only wrong about where strength comes from, and about what kind of strength the church was ever meant to have. Augustine, having watched two cities fall, did not spend his last decades trying to make the church into a stronger version of the empire that was dying. He spent them making disciples, writing to individual souls, forming a people whose depth did not depend on the walls that were failing all around them. That is the pattern, and it is the pattern the next chapter has to make plain, because the question that

faces a church after its Rome has fallen is not finally the question of how to build a stronger tribe. It is the question of how to build a deeper people. And those are not the same project. They pull, as we are about to see, in opposite directions, and everything depends on which one we choose.

Chapter 17: Deeper Disciples, Not Stronger Tribes

Everything in this book has been leading to one sentence, and I am going to say it plainly and then spend a chapter earning it. The future of the church in America does not belong to stronger tribes. It belongs to deeper disciples. Those are not two roads to the same country. They run in opposite directions, and the years ahead will make everyone in the church choose which one they are actually building, and most of us will choose without ever noticing there was a choice, because the tribe is louder and the tribe is faster and the tribe will let you feel like you are winning while your roots die underneath you.

I have to start with a confession, because I have no standing to say this from a distance. I came up in the era of platform and metrics and reach, and I wanted all of it, and I told myself the wanting was zeal for the kingdom. I have measured a ministry by the size of the room. I have felt the small ugly lift that comes when the numbers move and the deflation when they do not, and I have called that lift the presence of God when it was only the presence of a crowd. When I say the future belongs to depth and not to dominance, I am not scolding a movement I stand outside of. I am naming a sin I know from the inside, the sin of a man who wanted the church to be strong in exactly the way the world is strong, and who is learning, late and against his instincts, that the two are not the same, and that the church has almost always been most alive at the precise moment it had the least of what the world calls strength.

So understand first why depth was optional under Christendom and is not optional now, because the whole argument turns on this. When the culture is carrying you, you can be a mile wide and an inch deep and survive just fine, because the water holds you up no matter how shallow your roots. A nominal faith, a Sunday faith, a faith of vague assent and inherited habit, works perfectly well in a world that assumes it. It costs nothing because the culture subsidizes it. It never has to be tested, because nothing in the surrounding air is pressing against it, and so it can go a whole lifetime looking healthy without ever once being asked to stand on its own. That kind of faith does not fail in fair weather. It only fails when the weather turns.

The sun comes up on the American church

Jesus told a parable about exactly this, and we have been mishearing it for generations, softening it into a gentle lesson about being receptive when it is actually a warning about the drought that is coming for every shallow thing. A sower went out to sow, and some seed fell on rocky ground, where it did not have much soil, and it sprang up quickly, because it had no depth of earth. And when the sun rose it was scorched, and because it had no root it withered away. Read the parable slowly and notice what it does not say. It does not say the rocky-ground plant was sickly. It says the opposite. That plant came up first. It came up fastest. In the early weeks it may well have looked like the healthiest thing in the whole field, greener and taller than the seed that fell on good soil and was still spending its strength underground on roots that no one could see. Everything visible favored the shallow plant, right up until the morning it died.

And notice, too, what the parable refuses to blame. It does not blame the sun. The sun is not the villain of the story, and neither is the drought that Luke names in his telling, the season of

testing when the moisture is gone. The sun is just the weather. The sun does what the sun has always done. The problem was never the heat. The problem was the rock an inch below the surface, the shallowness that let the plant look magnificent in the cool of the morning and killed it by noon. The sun did not cause the death. It only revealed a death that was already certain the day the seed landed on ground with no depth to it.

The sun has come up on the American church. That is the whole of our situation in a single image, and it is why I keep returning to it. For a long time the water held us and the sky was mild and the shallow and the deep looked more or less the same, all of it green together in the assumed Christian morning of this country. And now the sun is up. The drought is here. The cultural moisture that kept the nominal faith looking alive has evaporated, and all across the country the rocky-ground plants are withering in the heat, and we are watching congregations that looked robust a generation ago brown and curl and blow away, and we are calling it a crisis. It is not first a crisis. It is a revelation. The drought did not create the shallowness. It exposed it. And the only thing that has ever lived through a drought is a root that went down long before the sky turned to brass.

The drought does not create shallow faith. It exposes it. And the only answer to a drought has ever been roots that were put down long before the sun came up.

This is the mercy hidden inside the hard providence of our moment, and the church will not find it until it stops grieving the drought as a disaster and starts receiving it as a clarification. A faith that only ever grew in subsidized soil never knew whether it was real. It could not know. Nothing tested it. The end of

Christendom is the sun coming up on a field that has been growing untested for centuries, and the sun is a brutal and honest thing, and it is going to tell us the truth about what we planted, and the truth is going to be that a great deal of it had no root. That is unbearable to watch and it is the most useful thing that could possibly happen to us, because you cannot go down to the root until you have admitted you do not have one, and the drought is the thing that finally makes the admission impossible to avoid.

Waiting for a very different Benedict

There was a philosopher named Alasdair MacIntyre who ended a famous book in 1981 with an image the church has been chewing on ever since, and it belongs to us more than it belonged to him, because he was not writing as a believer when he wrote it. He had spent the whole book, called *After Virtue*, arguing that the moral fabric of the West had come apart past the point of ordinary repair, that we were living among the fragments of a moral language whose meaning we had lost, arguing about good and evil with words we no longer had the framework to use. And at the very end he turned to the question of what a person who saw this clearly ought to do, and he reached back, as this whole book has kept reaching back, to the last time the West fell apart.

In the collapse of the Roman order, MacIntyre wrote, men and women of good will turned aside from the task of shoring up the imperium and instead set themselves to the construction of new forms of community within which the moral life could be sustained through the coming ages of barbarism and darkness. What saved the moral and spiritual life of Europe was not the people who spent their strength trying to prop up a dying empire. It was the ones who quietly built small communities where a whole way of life could be kept alive through the long night.

And then came the sentence everyone remembers. We are waiting, he wrote, not for a Godot, but for another, doubtless very different, Saint Benedict.

Sit with what he is and is not saying, because it is easy to hear it as a call to retreat and it is not that. Benedict of Nursia, around the year 529, walked away from a Rome that was visibly finished and founded a monastery at Monte Cassino, and wrote a rule for common life so wise and so durable that communities are still living by it fifteen centuries later, and those communities became, without anyone planning it that way, the arteries through which the faith and the learning of the West flowed across the dark centuries. MacIntyre is not telling the church to flee. He is telling it to build. He is saying that the strategy of the long night is not to hold the empire up but to construct communities deep enough and thick enough to carry the true thing through the winter, the way the monasteries carried it through the last one. And he adds the crucial word, doubtless very different, because the new Benedict will not wear a habit or copy manuscripts by candlelight. The form will be strange to us. But the pattern is the same, and the pattern is depth built to outlast collapse.

This is why formation has to replace mere reach as the central strategy of the church, and this is the hinge of the whole chapter, so let me say it as directly as I can. Under Christendom the goal could be reach, because belief was assumed, and the work was mostly a matter of getting people into a building the culture had already half filled for you. You did not have to form them deeply, because the surrounding world was doing the forming, catechizing your people in a broadly Christian direction all week long so that the church only had to top up on Sunday what the culture had already poured in. After Christendom, reach without

depth is worse than useless. It is a trap. You gather people into a shallow faith that the secular age will evaporate by Thursday, and you count the gathering as success while the drought does its quiet work, and you produce, in the end, a great crowd of rocky-ground plants, green in the morning and gone by noon. The church that survives the drought will not be the church with the biggest room. It will be the church that formed people deeply enough to stand when the room emptied out.

We are what we love, and we are formed by liturgies

The reason formation is harder than reach, and the reason we underestimated it for so long, is that we misunderstood what a human being is. We assumed, without quite saying it, that people are brains on legs, that they believe their way into the kingdom, that if you get the right information into their heads the right life will follow. James K. A. Smith has spent a career telling us this is false, and that the church's whole approach to formation has been built on the error. We are not primarily thinking things. We are primarily loving things. We are creatures of desire and habit, and our loves are shaped far more by what we do over and over, with our bodies, than by what we are told, and the things we do over and over are liturgies, whether we call them that or not. A liturgy, in Smith's sense, is any ritual practice that aims our love at a vision of the good life and installs that vision below the level of our conscious thought, so that we come to want it without ever deciding to.

And the secular age, Smith insists, has liturgies of its own, and they are catechizing us all day long whether we notice or not, and they are extraordinarily good at their work. The scroll is a liturgy. You pick up the glass rectangle a hundred times a day, and each time you perform the same small ritual of thumb and glance and hunger, and the ritual is forming you, teaching your

body that satisfaction is always one more swipe away and that you are the center of a feed arranged entirely around you. The store is a liturgy, and Smith has famously read the shopping mall as a kind of cathedral, with its images of the good life in every window, its promise that you are one purchase away from becoming the person you were meant to be. The screen is a liturgy, and the stadium, and the endless scroll of outrage that trains you to find your identity in what you are against. None of these announce themselves as formation. That is exactly their power. They feel like leisure, like convenience, like harmless habit, and all the while they are reaching down past your thinking and bending your loves toward a vision of the good life that has no God in it at all.

Once you see this, you cannot unsee it, and it changes what the church is for. If we are formed by liturgies, and the secular age is running its liturgies on us every hour of every day, then a church that offers only information, a weekly download of correct beliefs into people who spend the other hundred and sixty-seven hours being formed by the store and the scroll, is bringing a pamphlet to an artillery duel. The only thing that forms a person deeply enough to stand against a rival liturgy is a stronger, truer, more beautiful liturgy of its own, a set of practices that reach down past the thinking and bend the loves back toward God, repeated across years until they are in the body and not just the head. This is why the recovery of practice is not a matter of taste or nostalgia. It is a matter of survival. The church that will make deep disciples in a secular age is the church that recovers its own liturgies, its fixed-hour prayer and its Christian calendar and its fasting and its confession and its real Sabbath, and lets them do to its people what the mall and the feed are doing to everyone else, only truer, and toward a better country.

A contrast society

Suppose the church does this. Suppose it stops chasing reach and gives itself to depth, and forms disciples by practice and not just by information, and slowly becomes a people with roots. What is such a people for? Here the New Testament gives an answer that is not the answer the American church usually gives, and the gap between the two answers explains a great deal of our present weakness. We tend to think the church exists to deliver religious goods and services to individuals, that it is a place you go to get your spiritual needs met, a vendor of meaning with a worship band, and that the community is the delivery mechanism for the message. The New Testament thinks the community is the message. It is not the wrapper around the gospel. It is the gospel made visible.

A scholar named Gerhard Lohfink spent a book, called *Jesus and Community*, arguing that this was the point all along, that God has always worked by calling out a people whose common life would be a sign to the nations, and he gave that people a name worth keeping. A contrast society. Not a collection of individuals who each privately believe some religious things and happen to gather on Sundays, but a community whose shared life is so unlike the world around it that the life itself becomes the argument. Israel was called to be this and mostly failed at it. The church was born to be this, a people whose way of living together would be visibly, stubbornly different, so different that an outsider could look at it and be unable to account for it by any of the usual explanations, and would have to ask where such a thing could possibly come from.

Jesus said the same thing more simply, on the last night of his life, when he told his friends what the world would use to identify them. By this all people will know that you are my

disciples, if you have love for one another. Not if you win the argument. Not if you take the culture. Not if you out-shout the rival tribe or capture the institutions or elect the right people. If you have love for one another, in a way the world can actually see and cannot reproduce, the world will know. He staked the entire credibility of the movement not on a position paper but on a visible quality of life together, a love so concrete and so durable that a watching outsider could look at it the way that pagan in the plague years looked at the Christians nursing his fever, and ask the only question that finally matters, where does that come from, I want to know the God who makes people live like that.

Now hear the indictment, because it is ours, and it is the sharpest thing I have to say in this chapter. The reason the contrast is so faint right now is that the church has mostly let the culture sort it into tribes exactly like all the other tribes. We have churches sorted by politics, where everyone votes the same way and the gospel has quietly become the chaplaincy of a party. We have churches sorted by class and by race and by age and by taste, each one a comfortable affinity group of people who were already alike, and an affinity group is the precise opposite of a contrast society, because there is no contrast in a room full of people the market would have gathered anyway. The world can assemble people who are already alike. It does it in its sleep, with an algorithm, for free. Only the gospel can assemble people who have nothing in common but Christ, the progressive and the conservative and the rich and the poor and the citizen and the stranger, and sit them at one table and make them family and have it be true. That room is a miracle. The affinity group is just demographics with a steeple, and a watching world that is already exhausted by its own tribes has no reason to look twice at ours.

*The world can assemble people who are already alike.
Only the gospel can assemble people who have nothing
in common but Christ, and that room, when it exists, is
the most persuasive thing on earth.*

Witness, not conquest

This is where the church has to break its oldest and deepest habit, and I do not think we understand how deep it goes. Christendom trained us, over sixteen centuries, to change the world by holding the lever. It taught us to assume, so far down that it feels like instinct rather than assumption, that the way you accomplish a Christian end is to get Christian hands on the law and the throne and the institutions and pull. We reach for the lever the way you reach for a railing in the dark, without thinking, certain it is there and certain it is the way to stay upright. And it is exactly the instinct the early church did not have, could not have had, because the lever was nowhere near its hands. The church that turned the ancient world upside down never once held the controls. It had one tool, and the New Testament has a word for the tool, and the word is witness.

The Greek word is *martyria*, and you can hear our word *martyr* sitting inside it, which tells you at once what kind of tool it is. Witness is what you do when you cannot coerce. You cannot make the watching world believe. You cannot legislate the kingdom into a human heart or conquer your way to a conversion, and so you do the only thing left to a people with no lever, which is to live the truth out loud and in public and let it cost you whatever it costs, and to trust God with the result. Witness is the weapon of the powerless. It is the only weapon Jesus ever actually authorized, and it is, by an enormous margin, the most effective one in the history of the world, because it converted an empire from the bottom of a prison, with no army

and no law and no throne, armed with nothing but a way of dying that the empire could not explain.

And here is the irony the church has never fully faced, the trade at the very center of our long confusion. The day we got the lever, we began to lose the witness. When Constantine handed the church the empire in the fourth century it looked like the greatest victory imaginable, and it brought some real goods, and I will not pretend otherwise. But it also began a long slow exchange that thinkers from Yoder to Stanley Hauerwas have called the Constantinian shift, and the heart of the exchange was this. A church that could now command obedience slowly forgot how to compel by love. Why out-die an empire that is now yours to run? Why win the slow way, by witness, when you can win the fast way, by decree? And so the muscle of witness, the one that had carried the church for three unbroken centuries, began to atrophy the very moment the lever came within reach, and it has been weak ever since, because a church with its hand on the controls never has to develop it. We traded the strength that had converted Rome for the strength that Rome already knew, and we called the trade a triumph, and we have been slowly discovering the true price of it for seventeen hundred years.

Lesslie Newbigin, who had watched the church lose its grip on the West and had thought harder about it than almost anyone, asked the essential question and gave the answer that ought to be framed in every church that is frightened of the future. How is it possible, he asked, that the gospel should be credible, that people should come to believe that the power which has the last word in human affairs is represented by a man hanging on a cross? How does a claim that absurd on its face ever become believable to a watching world? And his answer was disarmingly simple and enormously demanding. I am suggesting, he wrote, that the only

answer, the only hermeneutic of the gospel, is a congregation of men and women who believe it and live by it. A hermeneutic is the thing that makes a text intelligible, the lens through which a message can finally be read and understood. And Newbigin is saying that the only lens through which the world will ever be able to read the gospel is the life of a community that embodies it. Not the billboard. Not the law. Not the election, and not the platform. The congregation, living the thing, in front of the neighbors, is the argument, and there is no other translation of the gospel that the world is able to read.

The imagination we lost

There is a kind of poverty that comes from traveling light for too long, and the church is suffering from it badly, and it is the last thing I want to name before I hand you to the end of this book. For centuries the culture carried the Christian memory for us, the calendar and the stories and the assumed furniture of a Christian imagination, and like anyone who lets someone else hold the heavy things, we forgot how heavy they were and eventually forgot we owned them at all. Now the culture has set the bags down, and we have reached for our inheritance, and found ourselves poor, holding a faith stripped down to a few slogans and a worship set, with two thousand years of accumulated depth sitting in a storehouse we have forgotten how to enter. Charles Taylor has a name for what the modern condition has done to us. We have become buffered selves, he says, sealed off, insulated, where our ancestors were porous selves, open at every point to a world they experienced as charged with God and meaning and presence. We live now inside what he calls the immanent frame, a world felt as closed and flat and disenchanted, a universe of matter and mechanism with the transcendent pushed out to the edges or out of the picture altogether, and Smith reminds us that

this is the air all of us breathe now, believer as much as unbeliever, so that even our faith has gone thin, and we believe in God the way you believe a fact rather than dwelling in him the way the saints did, in a world lit from the inside by his presence.

You cannot argue your way back into a full world. You have to be re-formed into it, and the practices are how the re-formation happens, and they are precisely what Christendom let us set down. The church spent two thousand years developing a technology of the soul, a whole architecture of practice designed to take an ordinary person and slowly form them into someone who can see and inhabit the real world, the one with God in it. The way back therefore runs backward, into what the church has long called the Great Tradition, into the company of the dead. C. S. Lewis warned about chronological snobbery, the unexamined assumption that whatever is newer must be wiser and that the past has nothing to teach the present but its errors. G. K. Chesterton called the cure the democracy of the dead, tradition understood as the refusal to let the small and arrogant aristocracy of those who merely happen to be walking around right now outvote the vast company of the faithful who came before. After Christendom, the church cannot afford chronological snobbery for one more day, because we are too thin, too new, too thoroughly formed by the very age we are trying to resist, to survive on our own shallow resources. We have to go back and drink from the deep wells, Augustine and the desert mothers and fathers and the medieval mystics and the Reformers and the long unbroken line of the faithful, not out of nostalgia but out of thirst, because they were not buffered and we are, and they have something we have lost and desperately need.

None of this is escape and none of it is antiquarianism. It is the opposite. A person formed by these old practices is not less able

to face the post-Christian world but vastly more, because they are no longer a thin modern self trying to hold a few facts against the whole crushing weight of a disencharmed age. They are a deep and rooted creature who actually lives in the real world, the enchanted one, the world the secular age has trained everyone else to disbelieve, and a rooted creature is the one thing a drought cannot kill. That is the imagination we lost, and it is, whether the world has words for the hunger or not, the very thing the world is quietly starving for. The buffered self is exhausted and does not know why. The church holds the answer in its own storehouse, and has held it the entire time, and the long slow work of the years ahead is in large part the work of going back inside and bringing it out.

So the whole strategy of the long after comes down to the sentence I started with, and I can say it now with the weight of the argument behind it. Not stronger tribes. Deeper disciples. Not the biggest room but the deepest roots. Not the lever but the witness. Not an affinity group the market could have gathered but a contrast society only the resurrection can explain. This is slower than politics and quieter than a campaign, and it does not photograph well, and it is the only thing that has ever actually worked, because it is the thing the church was doing on the morning the empire that had presided over its funeral discovered it was still alive. And that leaves one last question, the one this book has been walking toward from its first page. What holds a people to a work this slow, a work whose harvest they will not live to see, whose completion belongs to God and to generations not yet born? Only a promise could hold anyone to that. And there is a promise, made not to an empire but to a powerless few standing in the shadow of a pagan rock, that has outlived every empire since, and it is to that promise, and to the people who will carry it into the long after, that we turn last.

Chapter 18: A People for the Long After

I want to end this book by telling you the truth about the clock, because nearly everything that goes wrong in the church right now goes wrong because we are in a hurry, and the people of God were never a people in a hurry. So let me say the hard thing first, the way Jeremiah said the hard thing first. You and I are not going to see the end of this. The recovery of a deep, faithful, post-Christendom church is not a project we are going to finish. It is not a problem we will solve in a program cycle, or a campaign, or an election, or a lifetime. We are early in something long. We are the first wave of exiles, the ones who arrived in 597 before Christ with the ash of Jerusalem still in our clothes, standing in a foreign city with our whole world behind us and a letter in our hands that has just told us the number. Seventy years. We are near the front of it. We will die near the front of it. And the sooner we make our peace with that, the sooner we can stop reaching for the fast and ruinous answers, because the fast answers, every one of them, are the answers of people who cannot bear to wait.

Go back to the letter one last time, to the number the false prophet could never stand to say. When seventy years are completed for Babylon, God tells them, I will visit you and fulfill to you my promise and bring you back to this place. Seventy years. Not the two short years Hananiah was selling in the temple with the full radiant confidence of a man who has never once been wrong on purpose. Not a disruption to be endured with the bags by the door. A lifetime. The far edge of a

human span in the ancient world, a number so long that nearly everyone who first heard the letter read aloud would die in Babylon, and their children would grow old in Babylon, and only their grandchildren would walk the road home. This is the arithmetic the take-it-back crowd cannot do, and the arithmetic the give-it-up crowd does not need to, and the arithmetic every faithful exile in history has had to learn by heart. The work is longer than you are. You will pour out your one life on something you will not see finished. And that is not the failure of the work. That is its actual shape among a people whose God has always thought in generations and never in news cycles.

So here is what the seventy years asks of us before it asks anything else, before build or plant or seek or pray. It asks whether we can plant a garden whose fruit we will not gather. That is the whole test, and it is a harder test than any of the courage the martyr stories ask of us, because courage can be summoned in a moment and this cannot. This has to be lived across decades of apparent nothing. Think of the monks in the centuries after Rome fell, copying the Scriptures by hand in the cold, line after line, page after page, in scriptoria lit by tallow while the roads outside grew over and the aqueducts cracked and the old order came apart, none of them living to see the civilization their patience would one day seed. They did not copy because they could see the harvest. They could not see the harvest. They copied because the word was true and the work was theirs and the seeing was God's business and not theirs. Think of the masons who laid the foundation stones of a cathedral that would take a hundred and fifty years to raise, who quarried and set and carved knowing with total certainty that they would be dead a century before the spire went up, that they would never once kneel in the finished thing their hands had begun. They built anyway. That is gardening on the scale of

centuries. That is the posture the seventy years requires, and it is precisely the posture our age has trained out of us, because we are a people of the launch and the metric and the quarter, and we have imported all of it into the life of faith, wanting revival by next year and a recovered culture by the next election and our own sanctification on a schedule we can watch. We plant nothing slow because nothing slow shows up in the numbers. And then we wonder why the church feels so frantic and so shallow and so perpetually disappointed in a God who keeps refusing to hurry.

I feel the rebuke of this in my own chest, and I will not pretend I stand outside it. I am a man of my age, formed by its impatience, addicted to its measurements, wanting to see the fruit of my work in my own lifetime and ideally this year. I have measured faithfulness by visible results the way the world measures everything, and the seventy years stands over all of it and says, gently and without moving, no. That is not how my kingdom keeps time. I did this. I have wanted to be the generation that wins, the one that gets to stand in the victory, and that want, however righteous it dressed itself, was the take-it-back error wearing the clothes of zeal, because underneath the anger and the activism the whole demand to restore Christendom by force is at its root a refusal to accept the number. It is the insistence on seeing the harvest in my own lifetime. And that demand has never once, in the entire history of the people of God, produced anything but false prophets and broken people, because you cannot do multigenerational faithfulness while requiring a one-generation payoff. The seventy years is God's gentle and devastating refusal of our hurry. It tells us the work is longer than we are. And a people who can accept that become the only kind of people who have ever built anything that lasted.

But I need to separate this carefully from despair, because the

prophet of the seventy years is not the prophet of decline, and they are easy to confuse from a distance. He is not telling the exiles it is over. He is telling them it is long, which is a completely different word, facing a completely different direction. Decline faces down, toward the grave, and gives up. Nostalgia faces backward, toward the lost country, the old arrangement, the Jerusalem that was, and it spends the whole exile aching for a return to the past that is not coming. Biblical hope faces forward, toward the thing God is doing next, the city he is building, the return that is also an advance. The exile consumed by nostalgia will waste the seventy years grieving a country that is gone. The exile who has biblical hope will spend them building, because he knows the God who sent him here is also the God gone on ahead of him, and that the future, not the past, is where the promise actually lives. The whole difference between a bitter exile and a faithful one is which way he is facing while he waits.

We are not the generation that gathers the harvest. We are the generation that plants the trees, and calls that faithfulness, and leaves the fruit to God and to faces we will never see.

Now I want to set beside the seventy years the other promise, the one from the New Testament that the frightened church loves to quote and almost never reads for who it was spoken to. Jesus stood with his disciples at Caesarea Philippi, and it matters enormously where he was standing, because we have sanded that off too. Caesarea Philippi sat at the foot of a great rock face at the northern edge of the land, and that rock was carved full of niches for the shrines of other gods, a whole cliff of pagan devotion, and at its base was a deep cave the ancients called the gate of the underworld, the mouth of hell itself, where they

believed the dead went down. Jesus took his little band to that exact spot, under that exact cliff, in the shadow of that exact cave, and it was there, with the shrines of the nations at his back and the mouth of the underworld at his feet, that he made the promise. On this rock I will build my church, and the gates of hell shall not prevail against it. Notice who heard it. Not an empire. Not a majority. Not a movement with a budget and a building and the deference of the culture. A dozen confused men, most of them fishermen, standing in a pagan district under a rock face bristling with other people's gods, a tiny powerless band with nothing to their name, and to that little group, in that place, he said the gates of hell would not hold against them. The promise was never attached to our dominance. It was never attached to Christendom. It was attached to him, and to the strange deathless thing he was starting from underneath, and that thing has now outlived every single empire that ever presided over its funeral. Rome buried it and Rome is gone. It will outlive this one too.

We forget the scale of what that little band went on to do with no power at all, and we forget it precisely because we have been taught to measure the church by the power it lost. So let me set the account straight, because it is the whole ground of the hope I am offering you. The most explosive growth in the entire history of Christianity happened when the church had no political standing whatsoever. Not a little. None. It was illegal, it was slandered with the ugliest rumors an empire could invent, it was periodically hunted and its members burned and fed to animals for the amusement of crowds, and across three centuries of that it went from a few thousand followers of an executed Galilean to something near half the Roman world. The sociologist Rodney Stark sat down and ran the arithmetic, and it does not require any miracle of mass conversion to explain. It requires a steady

growth rate of around forty percent a decade, the ordinary rate of a vigorous new movement, sustained for nearly three hundred years. The only question worth asking is why. Why did this odd, powerless, hated minority keep growing through the worst the empire could throw at it, when by every worldly measure it should have been stamped out a dozen times. And the answer is not the answer we want, because the answer is not strategy and not platform and not cultural power, since they had none of it. The answer is that they lived in a way the empire could not explain.

When the great plagues came, the one under the Antonines in the 160s and the one that still bears Cyprian's name in the 250s, and the cities filled with the dying and the smell of the dead, the pagan response was the rational and ancient one. You fled. You left the sick by the road, even your own, and you got out, because to stay was to die. And the Christians stayed. They nursed the sick, their own and their pagan neighbors alike, at appalling cost to themselves, because they served a Lord who had touched lepers and because they did not finally believe that death was the end of the story. A nursed body sometimes lives. A pagan nursed back from the edge of death by a Christian who had no earthly reason on earth to sit at his bed does not forget who sat there. And it went further than the plagues. In a world that carried unwanted infants out to the hillside to die of exposure, most of them the girls, the Christians went out and gathered them up and raised them as their own. In a world that treated women as property, the church gave them honor and the widow a place and the marriage a dignity it had not had. In a world sorted ruthlessly by blood and rank, the church sat the slave and the master at one table and called them brothers and meant it. Some unknown Christian wrote a letter to a puzzled pagan named Diognetus in the second century, and he put it

exactly. Christians live in their own countries, but only as sojourners. Every foreign land is their homeland, and every homeland a foreign land. They are in the flesh, but they do not live according to the flesh. They are the soul of the world. And Tertullian, writing around the year 200 while the persecutions were still on and the blood was still wet, threw a line at the empire that has never lost its edge. The blood of the martyrs, he said, is seed. He meant it as a taunt and a fact at once. Every time you kill us, more of us appear, because the watching world cannot stop asking what a man could possibly have that would let him die like that, without hatred and without fear.

That is the church we are being handed back. That is the address we are going home to. We have spent so long grieving the power we lost that we forgot the power was the very thing that, the first time around, the church did not have and did not need. A church that could not coerce had to convert. A church that could not buy loyalty had to earn it. A church that could not summon the magistrate had to summon nothing but the witness of its own astonishing life, and that witness turned out to be the most persuasive argument the ancient world had ever met. This is why I keep insisting, against every panicked instinct in us, that the exile is not the church's emergency. It is the church's native condition. Christendom was the exception, a sixteen-hundred-year holiday from our actual address, and the holiday is over, and we are simply going home to the strange country we always lived in. The apostles assumed it as plainly as they assumed the sunrise. Peter opened his first letter to the scattered Christians of Asia Minor by calling them elect exiles of the dispersion. Chosen, and strangers, in the same breath. And the writer of Hebrews said it with a kind of ache that ought to reframe every anxiety we carry about the country. These all died in faith, he wrote of the patriarchs, not having received the things promised,

but having seen them and greeted them from afar, and having acknowledged that they were strangers and exiles on the earth. And then, plainer still. Here we have no lasting city, but we seek the city that is to come. That is our passport, and it always was. We only forgot it for as long as the culture let us feel at home, and feeling at home is the one thing the New Testament never once promised us.

There is a man I keep returning to when the ground feels like it is giving way, because he watched a whole world end and did not lose his faith in the ending, and his composure is the composure I want for the church in the long after. In the year 410 the impossible happened. Alaric and the Goths came over the walls and sacked the city of Rome, and the civilized world went into shock the way you go into shock when a parent dies, even an old and failing parent, because some part of you had quietly believed they would always be there. Rome was the eternal city. Rome was eleven hundred years old. Rome had been, for thirty years now, a Christian empire, ever since Theodosius made the faith official in 380. And it fell, to barbarians, in three days of fire, and out of the grief came the accusation, this is your fault, Rome was strong when Rome honored the old gods and you Christians talked her out of them and now the barbarians are in the forum and it is on your heads. And the harder grief, the one we forget, was inside the church, among Christians who had come to believe that a baptized Rome was the point, that God had crowned history with a Christian empire, and who now watched the permanent thing burn and felt their faith buckle, because if Christian Rome could fall then what exactly had God promised and what exactly were they standing on. Into that double grief an aging bishop in North Africa sat down and spent thirteen years writing the book that should be the constitution of every Christian living after Christendom. There are two cities,

Augustine said, and they have been intertwined since the beginning, and they are built by two loves. The earthly city is built by the love of self, extending even to contempt of God. The heavenly city is built by the love of God, extending even to contempt of self. Rome was the earthly city. Rome was always the earthly city. Rome was never for one single day the City of God, not even when it flew the cross over the legions, and so the fall of Rome is not the fall of the kingdom, because the two were never the same thing to begin with. He pried apart with both hands the exact fusion we have made, and he made them look at the difference while the ash was still falling.

And there is a detail at the very end of his life that I cannot get out of my head, and I will hand it to you here at the end of the book because it carries the whole weight of what I am trying to say. As Augustine lay dying in the year 430, the Vandals were at the gates of his own city, Hippo, besieging it. The world he had spent his life defending was visibly coming apart around his deathbed. The barbarians were not a theory or a forecast. They were outside the wall, within sight of his window. And he died in peace, this man, with the enemy in view, because he had spent thirteen years teaching himself and everyone who would listen that his city, his real city, was not the one under siege. That is the freedom on offer to us in the long after. Not the freedom of a church that wins. The freedom of a church that has stopped confusing the burning empire with the indestructible kingdom, and can therefore watch the smoke without despair, and get back to the work of loving the God whose city has no walls that any Alaric can breach. Learn that difference now, while it is only your country shaking. Learn it now, and you will not lose your faith when it finally gives way.

So this is the charge, and it is enormous, and it is the whole book

gathered into a handful of imperatives. Be the church. Be the contrast society in a culture of lonely tribes, the room where people who have nothing in common but Christ sit at one table and call each other family, which is a miracle the market can never reproduce and the affinity group can only counterfeit. Be the deep disciples in the age of the inch-deep, the people with roots that were put down long before the sky turned to brass, because the drought does not create shallow faith, it only exposes it, and the only thing that has ever lived through a drought is depth. Be the witnesses who have set down the lever and picked up the cross, who have understood at last that a church which cannot coerce must persuade, and a church which cannot legislate must love, and a church which cannot conquer must witness and bleed if it comes to that and trust God with an outcome it can no longer manufacture. Be the elect exiles who seek the welfare of the city without ever bowing to its gods, who are Daniel and not his inversion, serving Babylon to the hilt and worshipping it with nothing, keeping the windows open toward the true city and taking the lions as the price. None of that requires the water to come back. All of it is available to a church with no power at all, which is the only kind of church that has ever actually changed anything. We did not need Christendom to be the church before it existed. We do not need it back to be the church now that it is gone.

In Its Welfare, Your Welfare

We began this whole book with a verse on a coffee mug, and it is time to give it back its full weight, because the entire letter has been quietly building toward it and we have spent twenty-five centuries reading it with the load-bearing wall knocked out. For I know the plans I have for you, declares the Lord, plans for welfare and not for evil, to give you a future and a hope. We have

read that as a private promise of personal good fortune, a guarantee that my particular dreams are about to come true, and in reading it that way we have missed the single most important word in the sentence. The word translated welfare is shalom. And it is the same word, shalom, that stands three verses earlier in the command we have circled through this entire book. Seek the welfare of the city where I have sent you into exile, for in its welfare you will find your welfare. Shalom in the seventh verse. Shalom in the eleventh. The very same Hebrew word, laid down twice, four verses apart, by a writer who chose it on purpose. This is not a coincidence and it was never a coffee mug. The shalom God plans to give you in the eleventh verse is bound, by the deliberate repetition of one word, to the shalom he commands you to seek for the city in the seventh. Your welfare and the city's welfare are the same welfare. He said it twice, with the same word, so that we could not finally pull them apart, and we pulled them apart anyway, and framed the second half over the fireplace, and let the first half fall on the floor.

Hear the word at its full strength, because the whole promise turns on it and we have shrunk it to almost nothing. Shalom is not the thin thing we have reduced it to, not mere quiet or the absence of trouble or a private inner calm you buy with a devotional and a candle. It is wholeness. It is flourishing. It is the way things are supposed to be when they are finally right. A city has shalom when the hungry are fed and the worker is paid fairly and the stranger is safe and the sick are tended and the weak are not crushed under the strong and the neighbors know one another's names. That is the thing God commands the exiles to seek, not for Jerusalem, which is gone, but for Babylon, the very empire that burned the temple and dragged them there in chains. And that is the thing God promises the exiles in return, so tightly bound to the first that you cannot receive the one without

spending yourself on the other. This is the whole letter, and the whole of this book, gathered into a single sentence. The plans God has for your good are not a promise that he will lift you out of Babylon into a private prosperity of your own. They are the promise that as you seek the good of the city he planted you in, you will find your own good waiting there, hidden inside the welfare of the place you were sent to bless. You will not find your shalom by hoarding it behind a wall, or by keeping your bags by the door for a rescue that is seventy years away, or by dissolving into Babylon until there is no self left to flourish. You will find it exactly where the letter said you would. In its welfare, your welfare. Nowhere else. It was never anywhere else.

So this is finally what it means to live well, and it is why the whole of this book has insisted, against every other definition on offer, that the good life is not the one the culture is selling. To live well is not to escape the exile. It is not to end it early by force, and it is not to make a comfortable peace with it by surrender. To live well is to seek the welfare of the city where God has sent you, because in its welfare you will find your own. And that is not an abstraction. It is a set of ordinary verbs, six of them, that this book has walked through one at a time, and now I want to gather them into the single life they were always meant to be. Build the house, and live in it, and stop holding your real life in reserve for a better place that is always just ahead. Plant the garden you may not harvest, and then sit down and eat its fruit with thanksgiving, because the God of exile sets a table even here. Take a wife, and raise children who know a truer story than the one Babylon is telling them, and do not let the line thin out in despair, because a conquered people that stops believing in a next generation has already died. Seek the flourishing of the poor and the stranger on your own street, the neighbor Babylon forgot how to be, because the shalom of a city is always

measured first at its margins. Pray for the city, by name, day after day, until the praying has quietly dismantled your bitterness from the inside and you find, to your own surprise, that you have come to love it. And keep your windows open toward the true city, and when Babylon asks for the one thing that belongs to God alone, do not bow. Build. Plant. Marry. Seek. Pray. And do not bow. Six verbs, held together across one lifetime, and that is not a strategy for surviving until the good life resumes somewhere else. That is the good life. It always was.

I am not going to end this book by promising you that the exile is nearly over, because Jeremiah did not, and every prophet who has ever promised a short exile has turned out, without exception, to be lying. The number is still seventy years. It is still a lifetime. You and I will very likely die in Babylon, with the gardens we planted still years from their fruit, and the recovery of a deep and faithful church still unfinished in our hands, and our grandchildren, not us, walking whatever road home God is preparing. And I want you to feel the weight of that and not have it lifted, because a false comfort at the end of a true book would betray everything the book was for. But hear the thing the number does not cancel, the thing that stands underneath it and holds it up. The God who wrote the letter did not send his people into exile and then withdraw to wait for them at the border. He went with them. He went into Babylon, into the fiery furnace where the three would not bow and a fourth figure walked with them in the flames, into the lions' den where Daniel kept the windows open, into the long captivity and the strange centuries, present in exile as surely as he had ever been present in the temple, and more so, because now there was no building to mistake for him. He is with his exiles still. In the houses and the gardens and the marriages and the ordinary prayers. In the daily, unglamorous, unphotographed labor for the welfare of a city that

does not yet know his name.

This is the last thing, and it is the thing I most want you to carry out of this book, because it overturns the whole way we have been taught to think about the days we are living in. We have treated the exile as the interruption, the parenthesis, the hard stretch to be endured until the good life resumes on the far side of the return. It is not. For the people of God, the exile has nearly always been the place where the good life is finally learned. It was in Babylon, not Jerusalem, that Israel gathered the Scriptures and built the synagogue and hammered out a portable, durable, unkillable faith that could survive anywhere on earth, because it was no longer propped up by a temple and a land and the assumption of the culture. The exile did not suspend Israel's faith. It forged it. It stripped the faith of its scaffolding and drove it down, past the borrowed power and the easy respectability and the comfortable water, all the way to the rock, until there was nothing left to stand on but God, and the people discovered that God had been the only thing holding them up the entire time. That is the gift buried inside the loss we have been grieving. That is why the drained room where cultural Christianity used to stand is not a tomb but a beginning. The water was never the point. He was. He is. He will be, long after the last of the scaffolding has come down and the building, his building, is still standing in the morning light.

So build your house. Plant your garden. Take a wife, raise your children, seek the welfare of the city, pray for its peace, and keep the windows open. Do not wait for Babylon to become Jerusalem, and do not pretend that it already has. Live, fully and faithfully and without fear, in the city you did not choose, for the sake of a God the city does not yet know, and trust him with the seventy years and with the homecoming at the end of them that

you may not live to see. Seek the welfare of the city. And in its welfare, exactly where the letter promised it would be, hidden all along inside the good of the place you were sent to bless, you will find your own.